

NEW YORK TIMES BESTSELLING AUTHOR

JOHN C.
MAXWELL

THE 16
UNDENIABLE
LAWS OF
COMMUNICATION

APPLY THEM

AND MAKE THE MOST OF YOUR MESSAGE

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*This book is dedicated to John Vereecken.
For twenty-five years you and Karla have been helping me in Latin America.*

*You are a
Leader of Leaders
Communicator Extraordinaire
Builder of Teams
Caster of Vision
and
an Incredible Friend.*

*You, Karla, and Susi have expanded my calling to transform nations beyond anything
I ever could have imagined.
I can never thank you enough!*

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INTRODUCTION

Everyone Has a Message

WHAT DO YOU WANT TO say? Will you be able to deliver that message? When you do, will you communicate well enough that it gets through and accomplishes what you want it to?

Everyone has a message. It may be a message for the moment or the message of a lifetime. You may need to communicate the vision for your company. Or want to speak at the PTA meetings at your child's school. Or wow your high school or college classmates with a great presentation. Or present the quarterly report without putting your colleagues to sleep.

Or present a product. Or run for office. Or preach a sermon. Or make your living by becoming a professional speaker. Or maybe you just want to be able to share your heart with members of a small group.

If your desire is to share any kind of message, you want to be able to communicate it well. You want to be able to make the most of your message. Can you?

According to *Harvard Business Review*, "The number one criteria for advancement and promotion for professionals is an ability to communicate effectively."¹ It is also vital to our everyday life. Communication is how we influence others. It's essential to developing and maintaining relationships. It's at the heart of our social activity. Research analyst and communication expert Hayley Hawthorne says, "Communication is the connective tissue between humans, holding the potential to bring us together, create shared understanding, align on and execute initiatives, and so much more. At the end of the day, communication is the vehicle for transformation."²

Yet at the same time, public speaking, which I define as communicating a message to a group of two or more people, intimidates a lot of people. In one of his routines, stand-up comedian Jerry Seinfeld said, "I saw a study that said speaking in front of a crowd is considered the number one fear of the average person. I found that amazing. Number two was death. Death is number two? This means, to the average person, if you have to be at a funeral, you would rather be in the casket than doing the eulogy."³

It doesn't have to be that way.

I believe most of the people who fear communicating to a group of people avoid doing it because they don't want to do it poorly; they worry they will fail. I know this because in 2011, I founded the Maxwell Leadership Team, a company that trains people as coaches and speakers. When people come to receive their training, they are required to deliver a five-minute message to a small group of fellow trainees at their table. Every person giving their talk wants to do well. They have a message they want to deliver, and they're anxious to learn how to be effective communicators. But they're never as good as they could be. That's why we train them.

When it comes to communication, everyone stumbles in the beginning. I've spoken more than thirteen thousand times in my speaking career, and I'm currently at the top of my game. But my first experience speaking in public was terrible. (You'll read about that in the book.) Why wasn't I any good? Because *nobody's* good the first time! Like anything else, speaking has a learning curve. But if you have solid principles to guide your growth, you can improve quickly. And every time you speak, you get better. As Hayley Hawthorne said, "Mastering communication skills isn't something that can be done overnight. Developing communication skills is a journey that takes time."⁴ But I can tell you this: the journey is worth every step!

I've written *The 16 Undeniable Laws of Communication* to help anyone give a talk to others. Just as I worked to help people with leadership, teamwork, and personal growth with my other *Laws* books, I want to help you with communication with this one. And what was true of those laws of leadership, teamwork, and growth is also true of these:

- 1. The laws can be learned.** Some are easier to understand and apply than others, but every one can be acquired.
- 2. The laws can stand alone.** Each law complements all the others, but you don't need to know one to learn another.
- 3. The laws carry consequences with them.** Apply the laws, and you will make the most of your message and increase your influence. Violate or ignore them, and you will not be effective in communicating to others.
- 4. The laws are timeless.** Whether you're young or old, experienced or inexperienced, the laws apply just the same. They applied to your grandparents, and they will apply to your great-grandchildren.
- 5. The laws are the foundation of good communication.** Once you learn the principles, you will have to practice them and apply them to your life. If you do, you will be a better communicator.

Billionaire businessman and philanthropist Warren Buffett said, "The one easy way to become worth 50 percent more than you are now—at least—is to hone your communication skills—both written and verbal."⁵ He also said, "If you can't communicate, it's like winking at a girl in the dark—nothing happens. You can have all the brainpower in the world, but you have to be able to transmit it. And the transmission is communication."⁶

Whether you want to lead a business, teach a class, sell a product, preach a sermon, train a staff member, coach a team, earn a degree, run a nonprofit, or speak at a neighborhood meeting, learning to communicate better will help you. Learn and apply the Laws of Communication, and you will make the most of your message. And that will help you succeed in everything you do.

WHO SAYS IT

THE LAW OF CREDIBILITY

Your Most Effective Message Is the One You Live

WHAT WOULD HAVE HAPPENED IF the “I Have a Dream” speech during the March on Washington in 1963 had been delivered by segregationist governor George Wallace instead of Martin Luther King Jr.? Or if the Gettysburg Address in 1863 had been made by Jefferson Davis, president of the Confederacy, instead of Abraham Lincoln? Or if the Sermon on the Mount had been preached not by Jesus Christ but by Judas Iscariot? Or Pontius Pilate?

How would the people listening have responded? Would they have rioted? Would they have attacked the speaker? Would they have simply walked away? At the very least, their messages would have fallen flat. And their words would have been forgotten. Why? Because the noble, inspiring, memorable, life-impacting words in those messages would not have matched the people who spoke them. When it comes to communication, a disconnection like that doesn’t work, because your most effective message is the one you *live*. Anything else is just empty words. That is the Law of Credibility.

FIRST FOR A REASON

This first law of communication is not more important than the others, but there’s still a reason it’s first. As a communicator, if you don’t learn and live this law, the others won’t help you much. Who you *are* gives credibility to everything you *say*. As my friend Jamie Kern Lima, the founder of IT Cosmetics, says in her book *Believe It*, “Authenticity doesn’t automatically guarantee success... but inauthenticity guarantees failure.”⁷ If you speak words you do not live, you lack authenticity and your communication will not be successful.

The Law of Connecting (chapter 7) teaches that communication is all about others; your focus should be on your audience. While that’s true, communication doesn’t *begin* with your audience; it begins with *you*. That’s true for everyone who wants to become a good communicator. The relationship we have with ourselves determines the relationships we will have with others. If we don’t accept who we are, if we are uncomfortable with ourselves, if we don’t know our own strengths and weaknesses, if we aren’t authentic, then the attempts we make to connect with others will misfire. Once we know ourselves, like ourselves, feel comfortable with ourselves, and act true to ourselves, then we are capable of knowing others, liking them, feeling comfortable with them, and being authentic with them.

THE QUALITIES OF A CREDIBLE COMMUNICATOR

To know and become your authentic self with others and communicate with credibility, you need to do five things:

1. Be Transparent

Communication is more than just sharing information. It's really about sharing yourself—your *real* self. That level of honesty is the key to being able to connect with people. Brené Brown, in her book *The Gifts of Imperfection*, says, “Authenticity is a collection of choices that we have to make every day. It's about the choice to show up and be real. The choice to be honest. The choice to let our true self be seen.”⁸

It can feel like a risk to be authentic and transparent. People might not like the real you. But they might not like a phony version of you either. And if they *did* initially like an inauthentic version, when they found out it wasn't really you, they wouldn't like that either. Wouldn't you prefer to be liked or disliked for who you really are? I know I would.

People don't want perfect communicators, but they do want authentic ones. Speakers who are open and real in their communication are attractive because they share their failures as well as their successes. They can be honest and direct while still being empathetic toward others. It takes courage to be transparent, and people admire that in communicators—especially when those speakers value their listeners.

Nobel Prize-winning novelist John Steinbeck said, “A man's writing is himself. A kind man writes kindly. A mean man writes meanly... a wise man writes wisely.”⁹ When people are authentic, both their writing and speaking reflect who they really are. If you want to know me, read my books or listen to me speak. I stopped trying to project an image or be someone I wasn't in my early twenties. Since then, I've never tried to be someone other than my imperfect self. That commitment was tested when I started writing books in my early thirties. My publisher cautioned me about a few things he believed would hurt the sales of my books. I wanted to write to leaders. He said that would greatly limit my audience. I love lists and numbers, and I like putting them in my books. He said readers don't like that and recommended that I stop using them.

I seriously considered changing my style to please my publisher, but in the end, I decided that I needed to be who I was. My calling is to help leaders. My gifting is teaching leadership. I think in lists, outlines, and numbers. I decided to write the books I believed I should write, even if it meant reaching fewer people. As it turned out, more people than they expected connected with my message and my style. And more than forty years later, I'm still writing what I love based on who I am.

2. Be Consistent

Mark Batterson says, “Almost anybody can accomplish almost anything if they work at it long enough, hard enough, and smart enough.”¹⁰ What he's really talking about is consistency. Since the best predictor of what a person will do today is what he did yesterday, a solid pattern of consistency gives a person credibility. What you repeatedly *do* tells others who you *are*.

When you first begin communicating with people, they don't yet know if you're consistent. Usually, they take what you say at face value. Your words carry weight because people aren't familiar with your actions. Over time, what you say carries less weight and what you do carries more. Nothing is easier than saying words. Nothing is harder than living them, day after day. If you give good advice

but set a bad example, you confuse—and eventually lose—your audience. Consistency is crucial if you want to become a good communicator.

For more than fifty years, I have been intentional about adding value to people. That's my motivation for writing, speaking, and building relationships with others. I see every day as an opportunity to rededicate myself to helping people, and a good day for me is when I do things that improve the lives of others. When I step onto a stage and say, "My name is John, and I'm your friend," people who are familiar with my history know that I want to help them. But this takes time. Good work must be stored up before it shows up. Consistency compounds. So does credibility. It may take time, but it always has a return.

3. Be a Good Example

Have you ever been working on writing a message and you found some material that seemed good or interesting, but you couldn't verify it through your own experience or observation? That is, it was really someone else's advice, not your own. Did you use it? Early in my career as a leader and speaker, I would. But it didn't sit right with me. After doing this several times, I made an important decision: I would not teach anything I did not wholeheartedly believe.

Making that choice gave my delivery greater conviction. A few years later, I decided to take that decision one step further. I would not teach anything I was not trying to live. That choice added greater credibility to my conviction because it committed me to being an example of what I taught. As James Kouzes and Barry Posner say, "The truth is that you either lead by example or you don't lead at all. Seeing is believing, and your constituents have to see you living out the standards you've set and the values you profess."¹¹

Roddy Galbraith, who has taught more than forty thousand Maxwell Leadership Certified Team coaches how to speak effectively, gives this advice to new speakers to help them choose material:

1. Relive what you have learned, allowing the audience to relive it with you.
2. Earn the audience's respect by sharing your wins and gain their love by sharing your failures.
3. Decide what you shall speak on by choosing what you have lived out.

Following this advice helps give these new speakers the credibility they need.

There's a story told about Mahatma Gandhi in which a woman took her little boy to see the great leader.

"Mahatma, please tell my little boy to stop eating sugar," the woman requested.

"Come back in three days," said Gandhi.

In three days, the woman and the little boy returned, and Gandhi said to the little boy, "Stop eating sugar."

Puzzled, the woman asked, "But why was it necessary for us to return after three days? Couldn't you have told my boy to stop eating sugar when we first visited?"

"I could not tell him that then," replied Gandhi, "because three days ago I was also eating sugar."¹²

This story illustrates the point that being a good example brings credibility to one's words. When someone gives good advice but sets a bad example, it creates confusion. That's why Ralph Waldo Emerson said, "What you are stands over you... and thunders so that I cannot hear what you say to the contrary."¹³ When words and actions don't line up for a speaker, he not only confuses the audience; he loses the audience.

4. Be Competent

My favorite hobby is golf, and one of my highlights has been playing in the AT&T Pro-Am Tournament at Pebble Beach. It's so much fun being paired with a professional golfer and playing the course. My brother asked me if I was nervous playing in front of a big crowd, and I said, "Not at all. None of those people came to see *me* play." My golf game can be summed up by something that happened one day when I was playing with my friend Ron Simmons. I was playing my usual game, which would put my score in the mid-eighties, when I hit a long, beautiful drive. I looked at Ron and asked, "Why can't I do that every time?"

"Because you're not any good," he immediately answered, and we both laughed because it was true.

Why do I bring this up? Because nobody has ever asked me to speak on the subject of golf. Why? Because I'm not competent in that area. Nor have I ever been asked to speak or write about music appreciation, technology, or archaeology. I have no credibility in those areas. What I'm asked to speak and write about are leadership and personal growth.

The "weight" of a communicator's words is determined by what they have accomplished. Where have you been successful? What skills have you acquired and used that you can pass on to others? You cannot give what you do not have. If you have not yet developed high competence in an area of your life that you want to teach about, then begin by working on that area and learning. Become great at what you do and then teach out of the overflow of your life. Competent people earn the right to speak into the lives of others.

5. Be Trustworthy

I mentioned Mahatma Gandhi while talking about being a good model, and many other stories about him shed light on the qualities that gave him credibility as a speaker. One was his trustworthiness, which he proved time and again. One such example occurred in South Africa at the turn of the twentieth century. Gandhi had moved there as a young man in 1893 to work as an attorney for the owner of a shipping business. When that job ended, he decided to stay to fight for the rights of Indians there because he and many others had suffered racism and abuse. In 1904, pneumonic plague broke out among the Indian population in Johannesburg.¹⁴ Gandhi came to the people's aid and rallied support, even creating a makeshift hospital in a warehouse to care for them. But the local government decided to take drastic measures to keep the disease from spreading; they intended to burn the village where the plague broke out. It was during this time that the people's trust in Gandhi was proven. In his autobiography, he wrote,

The decision was to make the whole location[']s] population vacate, and live under canvas for three weeks in an open plain about thirteen miles from Johannesburg, and then to set fire to the location [where they had lived].... The people were in a terrible fright, but my constant presence was a consolation to them. Many of the poor people used to hoard their scanty savings underground. This had to be unearthed. They had no bank, they knew none. I became their banker. Streams of money poured into my office.... So far as I can remember, nearly sixty thousand pounds were thus deposited.... The location[']s] residents were removed by special train to Klipspruit Farm near Johannesburg.... The location was put to the flames on the very next day after its evacuation.¹⁵

The accumulated wealth of that entire group of people was put into Gandhi's hands because they trusted him. He had established his credibility long before he needed it. As a result, he was able to help people, they were willing to move, and further deaths from the plague were averted.

Trust is a person's greatest asset. When you have established your trustworthiness, people know you possess good motives, that you genuinely want to help others. People can sense it. Trustworthiness makes leaders and communicators effective because people listen to them, believe what they say, and cooperate with them. Without trust, everything grinds to a halt.

Why do you desire to speak to others? What is your motivation? Are you genuinely there for the audience, to advance their cause? Or are you doing it for yourself? To advance your career? Promote your business? Get a book deal? Become famous? Those motives may not be wrong, but none of them builds trust. First and foremost, you must speak to benefit others. If you struggle with this, the Law of Connecting (chapter 7) and the Law of Adding Value (chapter 15) will help you.

PEOPLE LISTEN TO YOU BECAUSE...

As you work to gain credibility as a speaker, your influence with others will grow, and it will likely happen in a predictable way. In my book *The 5 Levels of Leadership*, I discuss how leaders gain influence, step-by-step. My longtime friend Dan Reiland, executive director of leadership expansion at the Maxwell Leadership Center, took the stages from *The 5 Levels of Leadership* and adapted them to teach communication. I want to share his lesson with a few changes and additions of my own. As you read these five levels of communication, think about your credibility with the various groups of people to whom you speak to identify where you are with them.

1. The Requirement Level: People *Have* to Listen

When I was twenty-two, I became the pastor of a very small country church in southern Indiana. I started with no experience preaching. I was young and green and had not yet built any relationships. But the people who attended services listened to my sermons. Why? Because I had the position of pastor. It didn't take me long to realize that relying on position to get people to listen is the lowest level of speaking. There was nothing wrong with beginning at that level; that's where most of us start. But if you want to become a good communicator, you can't stay at that level. I recognized this and made an important decision: I would work to improve my speaking. I would try to become bigger and better than my position.

We've all had the experience of listening to someone speak because we were required to. Maybe you've listened to a boss because you wanted to keep your job. Or you've listened to a teacher or professor because you wanted to pass a class. Or to a government official who was the gatekeeper for a process you needed to complete. You listened because the person had a position that demanded it, and you didn't have much of a choice.

If you want to become a good communicator, you must acknowledge that your position or title will not keep people engaged. You need to raise the bar for yourself and start developing skills that make others *want* to listen to you. That brings us to the next level.

2. The Relationship Level: People *Want* to Listen Because They Like You

Within a few months at that first church I pastored, I developed relationships with the people. I liked them, and they liked me. And I could sense a shift in them from *having* to listen to me to *wanting* to listen to me. Was it because my speaking had improved greatly? I doubt it. But my relationship with

them had. This confirmed the truth of the old saying, “People do not care how much you know until they know how much you care.” I discovered that communication was more than just speaking. It was relating to people.

If you speak regularly to the same people, the best thing you can do is develop good relationships with them. If you’re in situations where you can’t develop individual relationships, then be *relational*. Care about your listeners as people, be transparent and authentic, and live what you speak, and people will like you.

3. The Remarkable Level: People *Like* to Listen Because You’re Good

As a young speaker, when I sensed that my audience liked me and wanted to hear me, I became more motivated to improve as a communicator and give them even more reasons to want to listen. This is when I accepted the challenge of learning to become a good communicator. I estimate that it took me about eight years to find, develop, and refine my style. That may sound like a long time, but it was worth the effort. Was I done learning at that point? No. I didn’t stop then, and I still haven’t. I’ve been speaking for more than fifty years, but I continue to learn and grow. Being a good communicator is a journey, not a destination.

Dan calls this level of communication *remarkable* with good reason because it makes a person stand out. You can achieve this level only with dedication. It takes a lot of time and effort to become remarkable. If you get to this level of communication, people take notice and tell others because it is so unusual.

I want to pause here for a moment to encourage you. I want you to become remarkable! And I believe you can be. That’s why the rest of this book is dedicated to teaching you principles and skills that will help you on your communication journey. As you learn the laws and put them into practice, your speaking skills will improve. My best advice to you is to stay hungry to learn. Be like the little boy at the fair who wanted to buy a huge cone of cotton candy. The vendor took one look at him and said, “That’s a lot of cotton candy for a little boy like you.”

“Don’t worry,” the boy replied, “I’m bigger on the inside than on the outside.”

If you have already been working on your communication, then the laws in this book can help you to fill any “holes” in your ability and help you to fine-tune your skills. If you’re new to communication, it may take you quite some time to become remarkable, but *you can do it*. These laws will jump-start your learning.

4. The Reason Level: People *Seek* to Listen Because You Add Value to Their Lives

I’ve already mentioned the importance of a speaker’s motivation. In his book *Start with Why*, Simon Sinek says, “People don’t buy WHAT you do, they buy WHY you do it.”¹⁶ He wrote that in the context of leadership, but it’s just as important in communication.

The reason I started speaking and writing was to help people. My desire was to add value to them. But there’s a difference between *wanting* to add value to people and *succeeding* in adding value. It took me time and energy to figure out *how* to add value. And it took the earning of credibility to deliver on that desire. I want to share with you what that process looked like for me because I believe it will help you too. I had to:

- **Find Myself:** I found myself when I stopped trying to be like anyone else.
- **Know Myself:** I knew myself when I examined myself, asked myself questions, and gave honest answers.

- **Be Myself:** I became myself when I accepted the way God made me.
- **Improve Myself:** I improved myself when I consistently developed my speaking skills through trial and error.
- **Get Over Myself:** I got over myself when I stopped focusing on myself and how I looked to others.
- **Give Myself:** I gave myself when I started thinking about others and how I could help them.

As you work to become a better communicator, embrace each of these lessons. They will help make you someone capable of adding value to people

5. The Return Level: People Are *Eager* to Listen Because of Who You Are

There is one final level of influence a person can reach as a communicator. Dan labeled this the *Return Level* because the speaker's lifetime of work improving his craft, focusing on others, and adding value to them creates an extraordinary return on investment. At this point, people listen because of who you are and what you've done over a long period of time. This is the ultimate level of credibility for a speaker, and it comes from having moral authority.

Moral authority can be difficult to describe, but you know it when you see or hear it. A story told by Terry Pearce in *Leading Out Loud* about English actor Charles Laughton, famous for his readings of poetry and other literary passages, illustrates what I mean:

Sir Charles Laughton was attending a Christmas party with a large family in London. Well into the evening, the host decided that each person in attendance should read or recite a favorite passage, one that reminded them most of the Spirit of Christmas.

Laughton's turn came near the end, and he recited, in his beautifully trained voice, the Twenty-Third Psalm. Everyone applauded his effort, and the process continued. Within minutes, all had participated except one elderly aunt, who had dozed off in a corner of the room. She was particularly loved, and they gently woke her, explained what was going on, and asked her to take part. She thought for a moment, and then began in her shaky voice, "The Lord is my Shepherd, I shall not want...." The room hushed as she continued, and when she finished, tears were dripping down every face.

Upon leaving, one of the younger members of the family thanked Laughton for coming, and remarked about the difference in the response of the family to the two "readings." In one case, appreciation; in the other, deep connection and involvement. "How do you account for it?" asked the young man, shaking his head. Laughton looked at him and replied simply, "I know the psalm... she knows the Shepherd."¹⁷

MAKE THE CONNECTION

As you learn and grow as a communicator, working on your skills and techniques, never stop working on improving yourself on the inside. Good communicators know themselves, connect with themselves, and accept themselves. You can do this by connecting with:

Your *thoughts*, which help you prepare your content
 Your *feelings*, which inspire the delivery of your content
 Your *actions*, which give credibility to your content

Every time you prepare to speak, ask yourself, *Is this something I know? Is this something I feel? Is this something I do?* Look for a yes to all three questions, and work to keep those things in alignment.

You are the message you speak. If what you're preparing to deliver doesn't connect with you, it won't connect with others. It won't breathe life into others if it doesn't live in you. Why? Because your most effective message is the one you live. That's the Law of Credibility.

THE LAW OF OBSERVATION

Good Communicators Learn from Great Communicators

HOW DOES ANY PERSON LEARN to communicate to an audience? Hall of Fame baseball player Yogi Berra, who became better known for his catchy sayings than he did for his catching in games with the Yankees, said, “You can observe a lot by just watching.”¹⁸ That is the essence of the Law of Observation. Good communicators learn from great communicators.

THE WISDOM OF WATCHING

A few years ago, I came across a joke that I love. A fox, a wolf, and a bear went hunting and each got a deer. A discussion followed about how to divide the spoils. The bear asked the wolf how he thought it should be done. The wolf said everyone should get one deer. Suddenly the bear ate the wolf. Then the bear asked how the fox proposed to divvy things up. The fox offered the bear his deer and then said the bear ought to take the wolf’s deer as well. “Where did you get such wisdom?” asked the bear.

“From the wolf,” replied the fox.¹⁹

Like all communicators, I got my start by watching others speak and learning lessons from them. For me, it began early because my father was a preacher. Many Sundays as a child, I heard my dad communicate a sermon to the church. He spoke with great passion—and what a voice! He was from the generation before amplification. His voice was deep, and he could project. My dad was an excellent speaker. I loved listening to him. His greatest strengths were his love for people, his personal credibility, and his great conviction.

When I was in seventh grade, Dad took me to hear Dr. Norman Vincent Peale speak at Veteran’s Memorial Auditorium in Columbus, Ohio, and that gave me another speaking model to observe and learn from. Dad was a student of Peale and his books, and he practiced the same “power of positive thinking” philosophy Peale promoted. Peale was upbeat and encouraging, and he told lots of stories when he spoke. Those qualities became something I identified as important to good communication.

In the fifties, you might have been able to hear a president of the United States speak on the radio, but if you wanted an opportunity to hear other great speakers, you had to go see them live. In the Midwest in the fifties and sixties, my family would attend multiday events called camp meetings where great preachers spoke one after another all day long. Old-fashioned rhetoricians such as

Lawrence B. Hicks would inspire people in the audience to stand to their feet and clap, shouting, “Amen!”

I started to seriously study other speakers when I was eighteen. By then, I knew speaking would be an essential part of my career. Because I would be preaching, I naturally started by observing preachers. I greatly admired the speaking of Charles Williams. He was a brilliant man with a photographic memory, a great orator who used flowery phrases. Because he was so skilled, I tried speaking in his style. What a disaster! It was like wearing another man’s clothes that didn’t fit me. My mindset is more practical than philosophical, and I’d rather be funny than flowery. His way of speaking worked great for him but not at all for me.

When I was in my midtwenties, I got a chance to be part of a speaking lineup in Vicksburg, Mississippi, with a legendary preacher named R. G. Lee. He was world-renowned for a message called “Payday Someday” that he had delivered more than twelve hundred times. I had listened to a recording of him delivering that message when I was in college. I knew I was not in his league—or the league of any of the other speakers on the program. In fact, when I met Dr. Lee before the event, I was so intimidated by him that I offered to give him my speaking time in the lineup.

“No, no, son,” he said, “I’m excited to hear you.”

When I spoke, he sat in the front row and encouraged me by listening. Afterward, he shook my hand and said, “That was a wonderful message. You have a great future. Can I take a picture with you?” I couldn’t believe he wanted a photograph with me! It was something I would remember later when I met young leaders whom I wanted to encourage. After the photo was taken, he even offered to meet me the next morning for breakfast.

Around that same time, I saw Paul Harvey speak, then Cavett Robert, a lawyer and salesman who had become a professional public speaker in his early sixties after he won the Golden Gavel Award from Toastmasters International. Robert went on to found the National Speakers Association and promoted keynote speaking as a profession.²⁰ I also saw Zig Ziglar speak for the first time. He really opened my eyes to greater possibilities when it came to communication. Zig made the most of his southern drawl. He recited poetry and used humor. He moved around on the stage. He asked questions and interacted with his audience. In the first message I saw him deliver, he used an old-fashioned hand pump as a prop on stage to help make his point. Like a lot of speakers in the seventies, I learned a lot from him and applied what I could to my speaking.

By the time I moved to San Diego in 1981, I’d been speaking professionally for twelve years and had learned by observing hundreds of excellent communicators. By then, I thought I was becoming pretty good as a speaker. But it didn’t take me long to figure out that audiences in California were different from those in the Midwest. I looked around and observed communicators such as Chuck Swindoll, Ray Stedman, and Lloyd Ogilvie, and I immediately worked to modify my style, making it more informal, conversational, and relevant.

Why do I bring up the names of all these communicators, most of whom you’ve probably never heard of? To make a point: each of us will have a unique history of observing and learning from other communicators who are better than we are if we want to become good speakers. If you don’t already have a history of watching and learning from great speakers, then you had better start now, because good communicators learn from great communicators. That’s the Law of Observation.

MY STAGES OF COMMUNICATION GROWTH

In his 2015 letter to shareholders of Berkshire Hathaway, Warren Buffett wrote, “Much of what you become in life depends on whom you choose to admire and copy.”²¹ Buffett attributes a lot of what he learned about managing companies to Tom Murphy, who was his mentor. Murphy built Capital Cities Communications into a telecommunications empire. In 1995, Murphy sold his company (then Capital Cities/ABC) to Disney for approximately \$19 billion.²² It took someone who knew how to become a billionaire to teach Buffett how to become a billionaire.

Warren Buffett’s statement is also true about communicating. Who you will become as a communicator depends on who you choose to admire and copy. As I look back now, I can see that my communication journey proceeded in four stages based on the people who I learned from and how I applied the lesson.

1. I Worked to Learn the Basics of Good Speaking Where I Was

My starting place was to look at others within my professional group—in my case, within my denomination—and I learned by observing the best speakers. I watched them, learned from them, and imitated what I thought would work for me. I spoke as often as I could to get practice. I tried different techniques, failed often, made adjustments, and improved.

2. I Learned More from Great Communicators Outside My Own World

As I became better, I widened my view. I looked at other communicators, professionals such as Zig Ziglar, to learn from them. I also began to observe great communicators from every field and profession. I’ll discuss that more later in this chapter.

3. As My Audiences Changed, I Changed to Keep Connecting with Them

The more experience I gained as a communicator, the more tuned in I became to my audience. As I expanded my speaking career, I had to keep learning new ways to connect with people. I will discuss this in great detail in chapter 07 with the Law of Connecting.

4. I Started Teaching Core Principles That Everyone Could Apply

In the seventies, I began teaching leadership. My audience was primarily church leaders. During the eighties and nineties, more and more businesspeople attended my conferences to learn leadership, and I realized I could help more people if I shifted my speaking from church-specific leadership practices to universal leadership principles. This was when *The 21 Irrefutable Laws of Leadership* was born. This shift meant I had to reinvent myself again as a speaker, but it was well worth the effort to increase my influence and impact.

Today I continue to study communication so I can learn and grow. I will do that until the day I die. Why? First, because I love communication and want to know everything I can about it. Second, I know there are communicators out there who are better than I am and from whom I can learn. Third, audiences continue to change. If I’m not continuing to grow, one day I’ll wake up and find myself irrelevant. I don’t want that to happen.

BETTER PEOPLE MAKE YOU BETTER

If you have not already begun observing communicators and learning from them, then begin now. If you desire to be a good comedian, watch great comedians and learn from what they do. If you want to

become a good trial lawyer, watch great attorneys speak in the courtroom. If you want to become a good classroom teacher, observe great teachers to gain a better understanding of how they teach. If you want to lead a business well, watch great business communicators cast vision, speak to their employees, or introduce their products. Start wherever you are, and then practice your craft. Speak as often as you can and apply what you learn. Use whatever techniques you can imitate, borrow, or steal. Pay attention to what works and what doesn't. Adapt and figure out your own style using whatever works for you.

If you start to become good as a communicator in your field, don't stop there. There's an old saying: "If you are at the head of the class, you are in the wrong class." To continue growing as a speaker, expand your view of communicators from whom you learn. Watch highly skilled and experienced communicators in every field. And do it with intentionality, not casually. Each time you observe, ask yourself these questions:

- *What did the communicator do to connect?*
- *Why did the introduction work so well?*
- *What made the structure work?*
- *What was the best moment?*
- *How did the communicator create it?*
- *What made the communication memorable?*
- *What was his or her best communication quality?*
- *How much was personality and how much technique?*
- *What did he or she do that I can try?*

That's what I did. I studied communicators from different fields with different skills, and here are some of the things I learned:

I Learned about Intimacy by Observing Walter Cronkite

I grew up watching TV's Walter Cronkite, the anchor of the *CBS Evening News*, which he headed from 1962 to 1981. Speaking like an honest fatherly figure, Cronkite was described as the "most trusted man in America." During the years he was on the air, he shaped the opinions of the nation as he covered the assassinations of John F. Kennedy, Martin Luther King Jr., and Robert F. Kennedy; the Apollo 11 moon landing; Watergate; and the Vietnam War. After Cronkite visited Vietnam and publicly stated the war could end only in a stalemate, President Lyndon Johnson said, "If I've lost Cronkite, I've lost Middle America." Some believe this may have convinced Johnson not to run again.^{[23](#)}

What made Cronkite so effective was his ability to create intimacy with viewers. Prior to his broadcasts, people were used to getting news by reading newspapers, listening to the radio, hearing the stilted voices of newsreel narrators, or listening to politicians' speeches. But communication in the sixties was changing. Speaker, author, and coach Nick Morgan has written about the shift from public oratory in large spaces to more intimate communication. He says,

The growing use of microphones and speaker systems allowed for a more physically restrained approach to speaking before large audiences. But the real sea change in speaking styles came later. It is usually attributed to the Kennedy-Nixon presidential debates in 1960, the first to be televised. But in fact, the switch happened in the 1950s, as people forsook outdoor

speeches and lecture halls for the comfort of the intimate little screen in the living room. Instead of watching a speaker address us from a distant stage, we invited Walter Cronkite into our homes. With the television screen framing his head and shoulders, Cronkite appeared to be talking to us from a few feet away, within a space we usually reserved for talk about fairly personal matters with people we trust. The close personal contact—or the illusion of it, at least—made us feel connected to Cronkite and other television figures; they became implicitly trustworthy in our minds.

In this seemingly intimate space created by television, the old-fashioned kinesthetic approach to public speaking—the large gestures, the sweeping phrases, the grand conceits—was obviously out of place. What we needed instead, and what we got, was the personal conversation appropriate to this cozy environment. Over time, the illusion of physical closeness conveyed by television created in all audiences an expectation of intimacy, both spatial and emotional, from a speaker.^{[24](#)}

Because of television, people expected communication to be a more personal conversation. People craved less performance and more intimacy and warmth. As a communicator, I had to find a way to convey that.

I've discovered that when I sit on a stool on stage and engage my audience in a more conversational tone, I can create a more personal connection with them. I love that. The moment I sit, I can see the people in the audience get more relaxed. That action has transformed my communication.

I Learned the Value of Being Natural by Observing John F. Kennedy

A lot has been written about the 1960 debate between John F. Kennedy and Richard Nixon. It was the first presidential debate to be televised, and many commentators assert that it changed American politics forever. I remember watching it on television when I was thirteen years old and being captivated by Kennedy. While Nixon looked haggard and uncomfortable, Kennedy looked relaxed and youthful with his easy smile and natural delivery. His body language seemed to fit the moment, and his answers were just the right length. Even as a young teenager, I was able to understand his points and follow his thinking.

After Kennedy was elected president, like many young people in our country, I followed him and tried to listen to him communicate whenever I could. One of the things I heard him say that really spoke to me as a teenager was, “Everyone has a ‘change-the-world’ speech in them.” Those words planted a desire in my heart that has lasted sixty years. I’ve been committed to helping people and changing my world through my communication ever since.

I Learned About Timing by Observing E. V. Hill

E. V. Hill was a preacher in Los Angeles who had great positive influence in the African American community. He once invited me to preach in his church, which I considered a great honor. When I watched him preach, I saw that his sense of timing was impeccable. When he came to a very tender part in his message, he would pause. He slowly walked around the side of the lectern to gain connection with his audience, and he would let the auditorium become utterly quiet. Then, with a lowered voice, he would speak with great emotion and gentleness. Everyone was touched by what he said because he said it in the right way at the right time.

He became a model for me. When I physically move on stage, use pauses, and slow down to share something of importance, I use techniques I observed from E. V. Hill. I learned to do it well—but not

as effectively as he did it. He was the master. In the Law of Anticipation (chapter 9), I will discuss how to use timing when speaking.

I Learned About Clarity by Observing Ronald Reagan

When Ronald Reagan was serving as the fortieth president of the United States, I used to love watching him speak. Often referred to as the Great Communicator, Reagan was able to connect with his audience because he chose words that were simple, compelling, and easy to understand. He communicated using simple wisdom and succinct quotable phrases. For example:

“We can’t help everyone, but everyone can help someone.”

“Peace is not absence of conflict; it is the ability to handle conflict by peaceful means.”

“Recession is when a neighbor loses his job. Depression is when you lose yours.”

“When you can’t make them see the light, make them feel the heat.”

“Inflation is as violent as a mugger, as frightening as an armed robber, and as deadly as a hit man.”

“I’ve always believed that a lot of trouble in the world would disappear if we were talking to each other instead of about each other.”

“Mr. Gorbachev, tear down this wall.”^{[25](#)}

Too many speakers try to impress their audience with how clever they are. Reagan tried to impact his audience with how simple his message was. I will discuss this more in the Law of Simplicity (chapter 10).

I Learned About Projecting Confidence by Observing Margaret Thatcher

In 1979, Margaret Thatcher became the first woman to serve as British prime minister, a post she held until 1990. Nicknamed the Iron Lady, she projected confidence and strength as a leader and communicator, and she was not afraid to meet the opposition head-on. A chemist by education, she believed she could come up with a solution to any problem. When she had won her place as prime minister, she said, “Where there is discord, may we bring harmony. Where there is error, may we bring truth. Where there is doubt, may we bring faith, and where there is despair, may we bring hope.”^{[26](#)}

My wife, Margaret, and I had the privilege to be among a small group who spent an evening with the former prime minister. As she spoke to us, her confidence commanded the attention of everyone in the room. And during an opportunity for us to ask questions, her answers conveyed a strong sense of security. I was reminded of her recently when someone came up to me after I was speaking and said, “When you speak, I feel that all is going to be well.” That was such a great compliment because I admired that trait in Thatcher, and I have attempted to convey security to others when I speak.

I Learned About Believability by Observing John Wooden

During the 2000s, I had the privilege of getting to meet with Coach John Wooden a couple of times a year to ask questions and learn from him. I was his fan many decades before I ever got to meet him because he was such a great coach. Leading the basketball program at UCLA, he won ten NCAA National Championships in twelve years. More importantly, he invested in his players and changed their lives.

Coach Wooden's integrity, credibility, and trustworthiness were as legendary as his ability to teach and coach. In his book *Wooden on Leadership*, he explained his approach and how it impacted his players:

Frequent and gratuitous praise removes the great value of a sincere compliment. Leaders who dole it out with little thought sacrifice a most powerful motivational ally—the pat on the back.... For example, I avoided the phrase, “That’s great.” Instead, I would say, “Good, very good. That’s getting better.” Or, “That’s the idea. Now you’re getting it. Good.” I kept in mind that how I conveyed information was often as important as the information itself. My tone was measured, and my demeanor controlled. And I was honest.²⁷

When I finally met John Wooden for the first time, one of my first impressions was his trustworthiness. He listened well, spoke carefully, and was sincere. Because I tend to believe the best in everyone and can be generous in my praise, I took note of his demeanor, and it reminded me not to overcommunicate positive praise but instead to follow his example.

I Learned About Using Rhythm by Observing Martin Luther King Jr.

One of the greatest speakers of my lifetime was Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. When I was a teenager and he was campaigning for civil rights, I used to hear some of his speaking on the radio and on television. What struck me was the way King used rhythm and pauses to communicate emotion and meaning to his audience.

David Murray, the founder of the Professional Speechwriters Association and the Executive Communication Council, has written about the musical quality of King's speaking:

Most song lyrics look dead and dull on a page. In this [I Have a Dream] speech, the best *prose* is in the first two-thirds. But the music starts when King departs from his text—or appears to. He stops talking and he begins to sing:

I have a dream that one day this nation will rise up and live out the true meaning of its creed: “We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal.”

I have a dream that one day on the red hills of Georgia, the sons of former slaves and the sons of former slave owners will be able to sit down together at the table of brotherhood.

I have a dream that one day even the state of Mississippi, a state sweltering with the heat of injustice, sweltering with the heat of oppression, will be transformed into an oasis of freedom and justice.

I have a dream that my four little children will one day live in a nation where they will not be judged by the color of their skin but by the content of their character.

If those words moved you just to read them, it's because your imagination is putting them in King's voice, etched in your memory. But let someone read them in a tone-deaf verbal ramble, as we all did in grade school, and you realize how much King's rhythm and melody are what made these lines immortal. Delivery isn't all—but it's a lot.²⁸

In fact, King's speech has been analyzed for rhythm and found to be “just right to help audiences absorb and comprehend his message.”²⁹

I did not try to imitate King's style, but I learned from him to pay attention to the rhythm of my speaking—to speed it up when I wanted to create energy and excitement, and to slow it down or stop

altogether for emphasis. I will discuss this in greater depth in the Law of the Change-Up (chapter 14).

I Learned About Courage by Observing Winston Churchill

Not all the communicators I learned from were active in my lifetime, nor have I heard all of them in person. As I studied World War II, I learned about the communication of Franklin D. Roosevelt, an excellent communicator whose “We Have Nothing to Fear but Fear Itself” speech during the Depression and “Day of Infamy” speech after the attack on Pearl Harbor moved the nation. But his counterpart across the pond during the war, Winston Churchill, was an even greater communicator. Perhaps no leader of the twentieth century displayed as much courage in communicating as he did—or understood its importance more. He said, “Courage is rightly esteemed the first of human qualities, because, as has been said, ‘it is the quality which guarantees all others.’”³⁰

When the entire British establishment sought to appease Hitler before the war, Churchill stood and spoke against the coming Nazi threat. He was proven correct when the Nazis invaded Poland in 1939. With Britain at war with Germany, Churchill became prime minister of Great Britain in 1940. In his first speech to the House of Commons as prime minister, he delivered one of his most memorable speeches:

I would say to the House, as I said to those who have joined this Government: “I have nothing to offer but blood, toil, tears, and sweat.”

We have before us an ordeal of the most grievous kind. We have before us many, many long months of struggle and of suffering. You ask, what is our policy? I will say: It is to wage war, by sea, land and air, with all our might and with all the strength that God can give us: to wage war against a monstrous tyranny, never surpassed in the dark, lamentable catalogue of human crime. That is our policy. You ask, what is our aim? I can answer in one word: It is victory, victory at all costs, victory in spite of all terror, victory, however long and hard the road may be; for without victory, there is no survival.³¹

Under Churchill’s leadership, Britain stood bravely against the Nazis as Germany bombed Britain relentlessly, killing forty-five thousand civilians in eighteen months. He encouraged the people of his nation to be brave, keep calm, and carry on. Not only did he exemplify courage, but he wanted every leader in wartime England to exhibit it. Journalist, historian, and author Erik Larson writes that Churchill taught the art of being fearless because he believed “confidence and fearlessness were attitudes that could be adopted and taught by example.”³² War Cabinet secretary Edward Bridges said of Churchill, “Only he had the power to make the nation believe that it could win.”³³ But Churchill himself was more modest: “I never gave them courage,” he said. “I was able to focus theirs.”³⁴ That’s what great communicators do! They bring out the best in people and help them focus it so they can accomplish great things.

I’ve learned a different lesson from every great communicator I’ve observed. But here’s the one lesson I’ve learned from *all* of them: *Great communicators always connect!* Each communicator does it differently because there are many ways to do it. This is the most important lesson in communication. As you observe great communicators to learn from them, pay close attention to them and their audience while asking yourself these questions:

1. *When did the speaker connect?* This is about timing.
2. *How did the speaker connect?* This is about skill.

3. *How long did the speaker connect?* This is about greatness.
4. *How can I connect like that speaker?* This is about your potential.
5. *What are my connecting keys?* This is about your technique.

I'll teach you the keys to connecting in the Law of Connecting (chapter 7). When you discover one of *your* connecting keys, you are on your way. As soon as you do, practice it continually until it becomes a part of you. It must be natural to be effective. As you keep speaking, develop more connecting keys. The more you use to unlock your communication, the better you will connect. And that's one of the differences between good and great communicators. Good ones connect occasionally. Great ones connect continuously.

If in the past you've been casual about learning communication by observing great communicators, I challenge you to become intentional about it. Go hear people speak in person. Watch TED Talks. Listen to podcasts. Study great speeches. You're living in a fortunate time when you have greater access to more great communicators than any other time in human history.

And do more than that. Travel. Walk in the footsteps of great communicators. Many times, when visiting Washington, DC, I have stood on the steps of the Lincoln Memorial where Martin Luther King Jr. gave his "I Have a Dream" speech and imagined the National Mall filled with people who were inspired to have hope. I've been on many other "field trips" to places where great communicators touched lives:

- I have visited the bunker where Winston Churchill discussed England's darkest hours.
- I have read the speaking notes of Ronald Reagan in his presidential library.
- I have stood in the pulpit of the great transformational leader John Wesley.
- I have talked with Pope Francis in St. Peter's Square after he delivered a message.
- I have sat with Billy Graham and talked about speaking to stadium crowds.
- I have interviewed Maya Angelou in a green room before we spoke.
- I have knelt and asked great communicators to pray over me.

Why have I done these things? Why do I continue to do them? Because I want to make a difference, and I know speaking is one of the ways I can do that. The better I become at communication, the greater positive difference I can make.

Good communicators are not born being able to speak. A Chinese proverb says, "To know the road ahead, ask those coming back." If you want to become a good communicator, you need to learn from those who've gone ahead of you. Good communicators learn from great communicators. That's the Law of Observation.

THE LAW OF CONVICTION

The Stronger You Believe It, the More People Feel It

WHAT DO YOU TRULY BELIEVE in? What value do you hold so dear that it's deep in your heart and soul? What belief is so strong in you that you would be willing to *live* your life for it, so important that you would *give* your life for it? *That* is a conviction for you. As a communicator, you should seek to speak on subjects connected to what you deeply believe, to your strongest convictions. Why? Because the stronger you believe it, the more people feel it. That is the Law of Conviction.

THE EVOLUTION OF A CAUSE

When I met Joanne Hession, she was a highly successful businessperson. Born in Ireland, she had attended University College Dublin and earned a bachelor's degree in finance and a master's in management and organization studies. She had founded and successfully led two businesses: one to help business schools around the world with leadership and accreditation projects, and another that trained people to become entrepreneurs.

Joanne has not only a head for business but also a heart for people, which had been developed in her twenties. She worked as a volunteer helping victims of the Rwandan civil war in refugee camps on the border in Tanzania. Witnessing the poverty, loss, tragedy, and corruption the refugees suffered, she had concluded that "education was the only thing that couldn't be stolen from them."

I met Joanne in 2016 in Orlando, Florida, when she decided to become a leadership coach and attended our Maxwell Leadership Certified Team training. I saw her again the following year when my nonprofit leadership foundation was launching an initiative in Paraguay, offering values-based roundtables we call transformation tables. When we do this in a foreign country, many certified coaches volunteer to train local people as facilitators. When Joanne experienced the roundtable method of teaching values, she thought, *This could work in Ireland!*

For many years, Joanne had desired to improve her country. After her experience in Africa, she recognized the benefits she and her fellow citizens possessed simply because of where they were born and their access to excellent education. She loved and believed in her country, but with those advantages, she believed the Irish could get better and do so much more.

So, in 2018, Joanne founded LIFT: Leading Ireland's Future Together. Her vision was to turn Ireland into what she called "a first-world beacon of positive leadership." Stepping away from her work with her two companies, she dedicated herself full time to the new nonprofit organization,

which she led without pay the first two and a half years. One of the first things she and her cofounders did was invest in research studies to learn what leadership qualities the people of Ireland believed were needed to improve their country. The top responses were listening, positive attitude, respect, empathy, honesty and integrity, accountability, determination, and competence. With the help of Global Priority Solutions, which pioneered teaching values through roundtables, LIFT developed material to teach those qualities. Then to launch, Joanne sought input and support from business leaders and people across society, including education, sports, and community groups. LIFT paid for everything using what Joanne called the Robin Hood Model. “The organizations that can, pay for it. For those that can’t, we give it away. We never turn anyone away. It’s for the people of Ireland, by the people of Ireland. I don’t own it. Nobody else owns it. It’s Ireland’s.”

In four years, LIFT has trained more than 22,000 roundtable facilitators, engaged 355 organizations, partnered with 260 schools (one-third of the nation’s total), and trained more than 50,000 people in leadership values. And Joanne and LIFT are still going strong. “In ten years, we want to train 10 percent of Ireland’s population to improve the country,” she said. “After that, we’d like to share what we’ve learned with other countries.”^{[35](#)}

When Joanne founded LIFT, she originally intended to get it running and return to her businesses. Not now. Her businesses are running well without her. Besides, why would she stop doing what she was always meant to do after she had finally found it? Her communication, her leadership, and her service are all connected to her conviction. She loves what she does, and it shows.

I KNOW THIS CAN HELP YOU!

Having convictions changes your life. Communicating with conviction changes other people’s lives. I have a conviction that has charged me up and driven me to keep communicating into my seventies. And that conviction often causes me to be emotional. I believe that when people learn and live good values, they become more valuable to themselves and others. They gain value because they become more confident. They find a sense of direction and purpose. They do what’s right, even when it’s difficult. And they develop self-worth. It transforms their lives.

They become valuable to others because they care about other people. The values they live help them improve their families by being better children, parents, and spouses. They become better neighbors. They contribute to society. They want to change their world, and they can! A group of transformed people can transform a community, a region, a nation, and beyond.

That’s why my nonprofit foundation has launched initiatives introducing transformation tables to countries such as Paraguay, where Joanne experienced them. For over a decade I have shared my belief in values with millions of people and have watched many lives positively change. My bucket list has one gigantic desire: in my lifetime, I would like to see a country transformed because enough people in it have learned and live good values.

Another conviction connects to my certainty about the way values can transform people’s lives and their world. Change needs to be led by transformational leaders. That’s one of the reasons I dedicate so much time and energy teaching leadership. And when our foundation is invited to a country to teach values through transformation tables, I deliver a specific message to leaders in the eight streams of influence in that country: government, business, education, media, arts and entertainment, sports, family, and religion. It’s called “The Characteristics of Transformational Leaders.” I never grow tired of sharing it, because it flows from my sense of conviction. I teach that transformational leaders:

1. See things others do not see.
2. Believe things others do not believe.
3. Say things others do not say.
4. Feel things others do not feel.
5. Do things others do not do.
6. Receive things others do not receive.

Every time I deliver this message, it is filled with conviction because *I'm* filled with conviction.

EVERY GOOD SPEAKER'S CONVICTION

If you want to be an energetic and effective communicator, you need to be a person of conviction. That begins with strong positive beliefs about yourself, your audience, and the message you have to offer others.

1. Personal Conviction: I Can Make a Difference

If you want to be a great communicator, your motivation for speaking must be to make a difference in the lives of people. To successfully make a difference, you must believe you *can* make a difference. I believe I can make a difference. I believe I can change my world. You must believe that too. That's where your conviction must start.

Speaker, author, and entrepreneur Ed Mylett tells leaders, "Everybody you lead does not have to believe what you're saying!... They only need to believe that YOU believe what you're saying."³⁶ The same is true for communicators. If you are convinced you can help people, they will listen to you and give you a chance.

2. People Conviction: People Can Improve Their Lives

For you to make a difference in people's lives, you must hold the conviction that their lives *can* be improved. The two go hand in hand. In organizations, you often hear leaders say their people are the most appreciable asset. That is true—but only if you appreciate people by investing in them with training, resources, and time. Too often leaders *say* they appreciate their people, but they don't *show* it. If they really believed it, they would do it.

Good leaders and good speakers believe in people, believe they can change, believe they can grow, and believe they can improve. And they help them to do those things.

3. Purpose Conviction: When I Know My *Why*, I Know My *Way*

One key to strong conviction in communication comes from knowing your purpose. Belief in yourself and your purpose creates a powerful combination. This is how these two convictions interact:

Low Personal Belief + Low Purpose Belief = I won't get started.

High Personal Belief + Low Purpose Belief = I won't continue.

Low Personal Belief + High Purpose Belief = I won't achieve my purpose.

High Personal Belief + High Purpose Belief = I will achieve my purpose.

Your purpose is connected to your strengths, something I discuss in the Law of Leverage (chapter 8). But your purpose is also connected to your personal convictions.

YOUR PERSONAL CONVICTIONS

What are your strongest personal convictions? Can you articulate them? Have you connected them to your purpose? Do you use them in your communication? If you don't know the answers to these questions, I want to help you.

For several years, my nonprofit organization has been teaching values to middle school and high school youth using a curriculum I developed and wrote with the assistance of Erin Miller, a member of my writing team. As part of that teaching, we help students recognize what they feel, think, know, and do so they can develop convictions they can act on to change their world. The process is the same for adults, so I want to share these same ideas with you to help you identify your personal convictions.

What Do You Feel?

The feeling question can be the easiest to answer for most people because feelings are accessible, and we react emotionally to so many things in our lives. If you pay attention to your emotions, you can learn from them. What we feel often influences our actions first. During a crisis, feelings usually dominate. But they also give us hints about what we're passionate about.

What feelings speak to you? What touches your heart so deeply that it makes you cry? What gives you such joy that it makes your heart sing? What makes you so angry that you want to do something about it? What gives you hope to make a difference? Tap into your feelings to gain insight into your personal convictions.

What Do You Know?

While feelings are valid and give you clues about your convictions, they sometimes are not based on facts. That's why it's important for you to add *what you know* to how you feel. Following your feelings while ignoring facts will limit you. But relying on facts and ignoring your feelings will frustrate you. You need to integrate the two.

What do you know to be true no matter what? No matter what you feel. No matter what circumstances you face. What are the truths about life that you know you can take to the bank? These are also indicators of conviction. Integrating what you know with what you feel will strengthen your convictions.

What Do You Think?

Thinking has great value because it brings feeling and knowing together, evaluates both, and seeks good conclusions. It acts as a highlighter, bringing out the best of your emotions and knowledge, and as a filter, removing the worst parts of each.

No matter your age, you've experienced a lot of life. What have you observed? What have you figured out? What have you learned by examining your failures and successes? What are the principles and practices you've discovered that have helped you—and that have the potential to help others? These also help you to recognize your convictions.

What Will You Do?

Now that you have examined your feelings, looked at facts, and added what you've learned, it's time to identify your convictions and put them into action. When you test a belief, if it's solid, it becomes a conviction.

THE VALUE OF VALUES

When I was growing up, my strongest conviction related to my faith. As I grew older, I began to consider additional ideas, values, and principles I could rely on. I discovered that convictions acted like anchors in a storm, holding me steady during rough times. They were like friends who gave me assurance when I was uncertain. They were like the North Star, able to guide me when I felt lost. And they were like a cool drink of water, able to refresh me when I was weary.

When I was in my midthirties, I created a talk called “Principles That Guide My Life” because I believed that sharing my convictions could help others to figure out theirs. I share them with you now with the same hope:

1. My attitude determines my altitude.
2. There is not much difference between success and failure.
3. Personal growth precedes professional growth.
4. Helping others succeed helps me succeed.
5. Having integrity is the only way to live.
6. Getting along with people is my most important ability.
7. Paying now and playing later is the key to achievement.
8. Giving is the highest level of living.
9. Life is not a dress rehearsal, so live today fully.
10. Success is having the love and respect of those closest to me.

If you're familiar with my speaking or have read any of my books, I'm sure you've seen these convictions come up over and over again. I believe them 100 percent. They are part of my values. They have helped me have a satisfying and productive life. And they are part of my message. I believe they will do the same for anyone else who chooses to embrace and live them.

HOW TO COMMUNICATE WITH CONVICTION

So, I ask again: What do you truly believe in? Do you know your convictions? If not, spend some time thinking about the principles that guide your life. If you have already identified your convictions, are you ready to use them to clarify your messages, improve your communication, and make a positive difference in your world?

You have the potential to become a communicator of conviction if you embrace and practice the Law of Conviction. In addition, here are three practical steps you can take right away to help your conviction improve your speaking. To communicate with conviction you must believe in these three things.

1. Believe in Yourself

Professors Martin E. P. Seligman and Peter Schulman at the University of Pennsylvania performed studies on the impact of attitude and confidence on people's success. They chose to study insurance salespeople because they knew people in that profession deal with an especially high rate of rejection. What Seligman and Schulman found was that salespeople who were optimistic lasted longer in the profession than those who were pessimistic. People with optimistic confidence sold 37 percent more insurance than their pessimistic counterparts.^{[37](#)} The lesson we can learn from their study

carries over to communication. If you don't believe in yourself, how in the world will your audience believe in you?

To be effective as a speaker, you must have confidence, but that confidence must never cross the line into arrogance, or you'll lose your audience. *Forbes* contributing writer Travis Bradberry wrote about the power of confidence when it comes to leaders, but his observations apply equally to communicators:

We gravitate to confident leaders because confidence is contagious, and it helps us to believe that there are great things in store. The trick, as a leader, is to make certain your confidence doesn't slip into arrogance and cockiness. Confidence is about passion and belief in your ability to make things happen, but when your confidence loses touch with reality, you begin to think that you can do things you can't and *have done things you haven't*. Suddenly it's all about you. This arrogance makes you lose credibility.

Great, confident leaders are still humble. They don't allow their accomplishments and position of authority to make them feel that they're better than anyone else.^{[38](#)}

Conviction brings confidence, and confidence fuels conviction—as long as the focus is on helping others, not on advancing yourself.

2. Believe in Your Message and Your Audience

It's vital that you believe in both your message and your audience for you to communicate with conviction. In the next section of the book, "What Is Said," I discuss creating good content. And in the Law of Connecting (chapter 7), I write about the importance of your audience. If you lose belief in them, you'll have a hard time communicating effectively. If either belief wavers, your communication suffers.

For several years I owned a company called Injoy Stewardship Services. Our mission was to help nonprofit organizations raise money, and we were successful; our clients raised more than \$3 billion for their causes with our assistance. The process always started with a member of our team going out to these organizations and making a sales presentation on how we could help them.

One day, one of our presenters sat with me and said, "I make the same presentation to hundreds of organizations, and I'm bored. Can you help me regain my passion for my talk?" I started by asking him if he believed we were the right company for the job.

"Oh yes," he said. "We do a better job than any other company in the industry."

I asked if he believed the message he was sharing was the right one or if there was a better way of finding out a potential client's challenges and presenting how our company could help them.

"I believe in our message," he answered, "and I think we present it the best way we can. If there were a better method, I'd use it."

Based on his answers, it was clear he believed in the message. I could come to only one conclusion. He was bored because he was focused on himself instead of the people who were listening to his presentation for the first time. He had conviction, but it wasn't focused on the people he could help.

When you speak, your conviction becomes contagious when your focus is on others and the benefits they will receive from your message. That's when belief blossoms and gains real power. Ordinary presenters become extraordinary communicators when they believe in both.

I have given some of my speeches hundreds of times, yet every time I give them, I'm fired up. Why? Because it's new to me? No. Because it's new to my audience. Because my message has helped me, I possess a strong conviction that it will help others. Are you convinced that what you have to say can help your listeners and impact them in a positive way? If so, your speaking will gain conviction.

3. Believe in the Power of Your Words

When you carry conviction, you become certain. And certainty shows strength. That comes out in your language, which makes the communication of your message even stronger. What you say is positive, not negative. Your language is active rather than passive. Your phrasing is strong, not tentative. And when you believe in the power of your words, you also speak with emotion. That's not a sign of weakness; it's a sign of strength. Don't be afraid to show your heart when you speak.

Great communicators understand this. Winston Churchill wrote, "The orator is the embodiment of the passions of the multitude. Before he can inspire them with any emotion he must be swayed by it himself. Before he can move their tears his own must flow. To convince them he must himself believe." Churchill was only twenty-three when he penned those words, but he practiced them his entire life.^{[39](#)}

As a communicator, when you are convinced you can help others and offer them the best course of action, people in your audience feel secure, gain confidence, and begin to accept your advice. If you are authentic, stand for something, live good values, and give your best, you will always strengthen your audience and add value to them.

COVID CONVICTION

In 2020, when COVID-19 grew into a global pandemic, millions of people around the world died, and hundreds of millions more were traumatized. What struck me as everything shut down and people became isolated was that at a time when people needed help and reassurance most, they had difficulty receiving it.

As a speaker who lives to add value to people, I found that particularly frustrating. In one week's time, my speaking calendar had gone from two hundred thirty-five dates to none, from the expectation of positively impacting half a million people to zero. Everything in me knew that people wanted and needed help, and I would not be able to travel to them to give it.

What did I do? I decided to begin recording lessons every week that individuals and organizations could watch online to be encouraged and equipped. I chose to project strength and confidence that I hoped would help people get through the pandemic. I wanted people to receive not only help but also hope, especially since none of us knew how long the pandemic would last. It was my way of trying to do my part during that difficult time.

A different world cannot be built by indifferent people. If you want to make a difference, you need to know your convictions and act on them. And if you want to be a change-making communicator, you need to harness the power of your deepest beliefs when you speak. Why? Because the stronger you believe it, the more people feel it. That's the Law of Conviction.

WHAT IS SAID

THE LAW OF PREPARATION

You Cannot Deliver What You Have Not Developed

WINSTON CHURCHILL ONCE COMMENTED ON a rival by saying, “He can be described as one of those orators who, before he gets up, does not know what he is going to say; when he is speaking, does not know what he is saying; and when he has sat down, doesn’t know what he has said.”⁴⁰ In other words, that person was prone to winging it instead of working it. Whether through arrogance or indifference, that’s what too many speakers do. But the reality is that without proper preparation, communication doesn’t soar; it falls flat.

Author, entrepreneur, and motivational speaker Jim Rohn said,

You cannot speak that which you do not know. You cannot share that which you do not feel. You cannot translate that which you do not have. And you cannot give that which you do not possess. To give it and to share it, and for it to be effective, you first need to have it. Good communication starts with good preparation.⁴¹

The best communicators always prepare.

As I’ve said, my speaking career began as a pastor in Hillham, Indiana, a tiny farming community. The people there were delightful and enjoyed hearing me speak. I immediately gravitated to speaking. It was my favorite part of being a pastor, and I soon recognized I possessed a gift for communication. I also realized that because I was young, my congregation did not place high expectations on my speaking. No matter how good or poor the message, they were pleased.

One week, I ran short of time and prepared my message in only two hours. I was nervous about how it would be received, but the congregation didn’t seem to notice the difference. That’s when a thought occurred to me: I could wing it. I could do an adequate job using only a couple of hours of prep time and use the extra time to play golf at a great course less than three miles from my home.

Would I wing it or work for it? If I were going to work for it, I would need twenty hours of prep time—ten times more than I could get away with! It wasn’t an easy decision. I was strongly tempted to wing it, but I finally chose to do the work, and I did for three reasons.

First, I was a rookie at preaching, and I recognized I needed to spend a lot of time working on messages so that I could develop my preparation skills. Second, I knew I needed to study and grow in my knowledge and understanding of my subject material to become more mature and experienced in

applying it to my own life before trying to pass it on to others. Finally, I believed the people in my church deserved to receive the best I could give them on Sundays, not something I slapped together.

I made that decision fifty-four years ago, and I've never regretted it. In fact, as I look back at my journey as a communicator, I recognize it was one of the most important choices I made. With the benefit of age, I know if you wing it, success is improbable. If you work for it, success is inevitable.

PREPARATION OR DELIVERY?

People often ask me which I prefer: the preparation for teaching or the teaching itself. My answer is, I love both. When I am preparing a lesson, that's what I love the most. I find the thinking and writing process deeply satisfying. However, when I'm speaking, I love that the most. When I'm communicating with people, I think, *I am made for this!* Doing both brings me deep satisfaction. And the bottom line is that great preparation helps me to communicate well as much as it helps the audience enjoy the message.

One reason preparation is so valuable and enjoyable to me is that I need to communicate to myself before I communicate to my audience. Any message I want to deliver must speak to me before it can speak to others. If it hasn't helped me, it *cannot* help others. If I haven't learned from it, neither will my audience. If it won't prompt me to take action, how can I expect it to inspire others to take action when I deliver it?

My first audience is me. Your first audience needs to be you. If what you prepare speaks to you, teaches you, and inspires you to action, then it's probably ready for your second audience. Don't try to give what you do not have.

TWO MESSAGES IN ONE

As a communicator, when I prepare for an audience, I am always working on two messages at the same time. The first message is specific to them and the situation. I think of it as "My Best Message" because I want to deliver the best content I can. It's what every audience deserves. This is the message I prepare on paper to be delivered to my audience. It is the message they *want* and came to hear. It is specifically created to meet their present need and is intended to improve their lives.

The other message is something I try to deliver every time, everywhere, to everyone. I think of this as "My Big Message," and it's always the same. Where My Best Message is prepared on paper, My Big Message is prepared in my heart. It is what the people *need* to hear. It's bigger than the content because it's meant to develop people. It answers four questions I've learned to ask myself as a communicator because they frame my thinking and influence my speaking:

1. What do I want the people to *See*?
2. What do I want the people to *Know*?
3. What do I want the people to *Feel*?
4. What do I want the people to *Do*?

These questions may seem simple, but it took me years to wrestle them down. I worked and reworked them, changed and tweaked them, until my soul was satisfied. For thirty years, I've made sure every message I deliver answers these questions.

1. What Do I Want Them to See? Their Possibilities!

How we *view* things determines how we *do* things. When people see their possibilities, their world expands. I want to help people shift from asking, “Can I?” to “How can I?” *Can I?* is filled with doubt. *How can I?* is positive and determined. It is filled with possibilities and encourages problem-solving and action.

Stephen R. Covey wrote about the difference between these two kinds of thinking in *The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People*:

Most people are deeply scripted in what I call the Scarcity Mentality. They see life as having only so much, as though there were only one pie out there. And if someone were to get a big piece of the pie, it would mean less for everybody else.... The Abundance Mentality, on the other hand, flows out of a deep inner sense of personal worth or security. It is the paradigm that there is plenty out there and enough to spare for everybody. It results in the sharing of prestige, of recognition, of profits, of decision-making. It opens possibilities, options, alternatives, and creativity.^{[42](#)}

I possess an abundance mentality, and every message I deliver comes from that outlook. I firmly believe everyone has greater possibilities, and I want to help them see those possibilities.

When we were writing values curriculum for students in middle schools that the Maxwell Leadership Foundation would be using in South and Central America, we felt it was important to teach an abundance mindset to the children. Erin Miller, who helped write the curriculum, said, “Too many kids grow up in a negative, scarcity environment where they have never seen their possibilities. Let’s teach and show them who they could become if they develop their potential.” That is a worthy goal of any teacher or communicator.

When you prepare to communicate, do you see people’s possibilities? More importantly, do you help *them* to see their possibilities?

2. What Do I Want Them to Know? Their Value!

Many people have been beaten down and discouraged by others. As a result, they don’t recognize their own value. They feel like Charlie Brown, who was continually beaten down by Lucy. In one comic strip, she railed,

You, Charlie Brown, are a foul ball in the line drive of life! You’re in the shadow of your own goal posts... You are a miscue... You are three putts on the eighteenth green... You are a seven-ten split in the tenth frame... a love set! You have dropped a rod and reel in the lake of life... You are a missed free throw, a shanked nine iron and a called third strike! Do you understand? Have I made myself clear?^{[43](#)}

Lucy’s attitude is like that of too many speakers. She talked down to others. Good communicators talk people up. They believe in their audience, see their best, and encourage them because they see their value.

Because I never want people to miss this, I tell them all the time that I value them. Skeptical people have asked me, “How can you say that when you don’t even know me?”

My response comes out of my faith: “I value you because God values you. He doesn’t make mistakes!”

Valuing others begins with seeing value in yourself. Author and speaker Brian Tracy says, “The more you like and respect yourself, the more you like and respect other people. The more you consider yourself to be a valuable and worthwhile person, the more you consider others to be valuable and worthwhile as well.”

How do you feel about yourself? Do you believe you have value? Do you believe you have something to offer others? Are you willing to believe others have value, and are you willing to express it? If you can answer yes to these questions and focus on people’s value as you prepare your message and as you speak, it will transform your communication.

3. What Do I Want Them to Feel? Empowered!

The purpose of communication isn’t to *impress* your audience. It’s to *empower* your audience. You don’t want people coming away saying, “Wow. She’s amazing. She has done great things!” You want them saying, “Wow. This is amazing. I can do great things!”

How can you empower people? Whether you’re talking with two people or speaking to a large audience, do these five things:

- **Embrace people’s potential.** I see everyone as a ten out of ten, and I tell them that. You can too.
- **Give people permission to succeed.** I try to “open the gate” for them to walk in new territory. You can too.
- **Invite collaboration.** This means working together aggressively, as opposed to *cooperation*, which is merely working together agreeably. People are more likely to reach their potential when working with others. I encourage collaboration. You can too.
- **Encourage ownership.** As much as I want people to succeed, only they can make themselves successful by taking action. I encourage them to do that. You can too.
- **Ask them to hold themselves accountable.** People realize their possibilities when they are accountable for results. I help them understand that achieving results fuels a cycle of encouragement. You can too.

Empowerment is an incredible gift to give another person. It not only helps people believe they have the freedom to be successful; it also helps them know others *want* them to be successful and believe they *can* be.

4. What Do I Want Them to Do? Apply and Multiply!

The speaker’s challenge is to take an audience from *know-how* to *do now*. You want to help them apply what they learn and share it with others. I learned this because it was my privilege to be invited at a young age to speak with experienced communicators at Success Seminars. I enjoyed listening to them, was inspired by them, and, along with the thousands in attendance, gave them standing ovations. I learned so much from watching them: I admired their great delivery, unbelievable stories, unforgettable quotes, and hilarious humor. However, after a couple of years on that circuit, I slowly realized that most of the speeches ended with a standing ovation—and nothing more. People walked away feeling good, but the next day, they did nothing with what they heard.

Observing this, I made a decision. I did not want to be a motivational speaker. Instead, I would become a motivational *teacher*. I wanted people to do more than feel good. I wanted them to go home feeling informed and inspired enough to take action to improve their lives. I still want them to do that

now. Not only that, but I want them to share what they've learned with others so that they apply and multiply what I've given them. I never want them to be like the farmer who was asked by his neighbor, "Are you going to attend the new county agent's class?"

"Nope," the farmer replied, "I already know a whole lot more about farming than I'm doing." What good is being educated beyond your willingness to act?

If I can describe possibilities to people that will expand their ability and capacity, give them a clear path toward these possibilities, help them believe in themselves, and inspire them to act, I can genuinely help them. And that's what communication is all about.

THE VALUE OF PREPARATION

In the early twentieth century, Fielding Yost coached the University of Michigan football team to a record of 165 wins, 29 losses, and 10 ties during his twenty-five-year tenure.⁴⁴ He won the second-most football games in Michigan's history. He often spoke about the importance of preparation versus the will to win. His words have been echoed by other influential coaches such as Vince Lombardi, Bobby Knight, and John Wooden. Yost said,

Preparation—that is the big thing. It is all right to talk about this "will to win," but I tell you it is not of much worth unless you have the will to prepare, whether for the game you are to play or for the business or profession you are to enter. A one horsepower man cannot do much to achieve a great result. He must develop by preparation, so that when the test comes he has something to rely upon and is able to make use of it.⁴⁵

The will to prepare is just as important in communication. Here's why:

We Play at the Level of Our Preparation

Spectacular performance is always preceded by unspectacular preparation. I once asked John Wooden, the UCLA Bruins basketball coach who won ten national championships, what he missed after his retirement from coaching. "Practice," he answered without hesitation. "Great practices make great teams." He went on to explain that he was very relaxed on the bench during games. Why? Because the hard work had already been done in their preparation before the game. His players' level of practice determined their level of play.

How you spend your time preparing is more important than *how much time* you spend preparing. As I prepare for any speaking engagement, I go through five steps to make sure I'll be ready at "game time":

1. Ask Set-Up Questions

I always request a pre-call with the organization or host of an event I will speak for. My goal is to add value to them and the people I'll address. So at a minimum, I ask these questions:

- What is the event?
- Does it have a theme?
- Why have you chosen me to speak?
- What is the context?
- What is the subject?

- Are there specific things you want me to talk about?
- What would you consider a win?
- Is there anything else I can do to add value to you?

You can create a great speech and deliver it with skill, but if it's the wrong message for the wrong people, it won't be successful, nor will it help anyone.

2. *Prepare My Subject*

Once I know those details about my audience and context, I'm ready to work on my message. I *always* outline my message (unless I am asked to speak extemporaneously in the moment). I write an introduction, but when I speak, I often springboard off the context of what is happening before I take the stage instead. Why? Because connecting is even more important than introducing my subject. I explain this in detail in the Law of Connecting (chapter 7).

For the body of my message, I write out my bullet points starting with foundational ideas or the most important ones. I work to make the wording of these points memorable. If I can create a rhythm, pattern, or hook to make them build and "sing," I will. I then add quotes, stories, and illustrations to the points to give them life, making them meaningful and fun. I finish the outline with an encouraging call to action.

All the time I'm preparing my outline, I'm asking myself these three questions:

- **How can I make it special?** I give this a lot of thought ahead of time. I tailor my messages and focus on adding value, so that helps make it special. If I write a message from scratch, I often let people know by saying, "I developed this lesson just for you" or "I've never spoken on this before."
- **How can I make it personal?** The best way I know to do this is to pair what they *do* know with what they *don't* know. What they know is based on their organizational culture, personal experience, and national origin. What they don't know is the insight I'm trying to communicate to them. That puts my message into their context.
- **How can I make it practical?** I never forget that my goal is to help my audience. I write that into my outline. And if possible, I do a Q&A with my audience to help them apply the lesson.

When I'm satisfied that I've been able to do these things, my outline is ready.

3. *Prepare Myself*

Before I speak, I want to prepare myself mentally, emotionally, and experientially. Again, I use questions to make sure I'm ready. I ask,

- Do I **Know** my teaching? I need to spend enough time with my outline that I know what I'm doing and where I'm going. I typically do this several hours before I speak.
- Do I **Feel** my teaching? Good communication comes from the heart—and goes to the hearts of others.
- Do I **Live** my teaching? When I was in my twenties, I decided I would never deliver a message that wasn't true to me. I would not deliver theories I hadn't tested and lived.

When I can answer yes to those questions with integrity, I'm ready to communicate.

4. Evaluate My Effectiveness While Speaking

When I step up to speak, it's game on! But it's also practice. Why do I say that? Because my greatest growth as a communicator has come during my speaking. Repetition is important. How do you get better as a speaker? By speaking—and paying attention to what works and what doesn't. As a young communicator, I sometimes found it difficult to evaluate my communication *while* communicating. For that reason, I often asked team members to evaluate my talk by giving me feedback. However, as I have matured as a communicator, my self-awareness of how I am presenting has gotten better. Even while I'm delivering my message, I ask myself,

- *Am I comfortable and confident?*
- *Is my audience leaning in?*
- *When am I connecting with my audience?*
- *When am I not connecting?*
- *Is my audience staying engaged?*
- *Do they seem glad they are hearing me speak?*

I continually adjust to make sure I keep connecting and my message keeps landing. If needed, I'll completely change course if I sense that I'm not delivering in the way I should.

What I'm always trying to do is exceed my audience's expectations. That can be difficult because people's expectations keep rising every time I give a keynote speech. For that reason, I continually raise the bar for myself. You should too. Consultant and former executive vice president and chief marketing officer at First Republic Bank Dianne Snedaker advised,

Set your standards high and keep them high. If you are interested in success, it's easy to set your standards in terms of other people's accomplishments. And then let other people measure you by those standards. But the standards you set for yourself are always the more important. They should be higher than the standards anyone else would set for you, because in the end you have to live with yourself, and judge yourself, and feel good about yourself. And the best way to do that is to live up to your highest potential. So set your standards high and keep them high, even if you think no one else is looking. Somebody out there will *always* notice, even if it's just you.^{[46](#)}

If you hold yourself to a high standard when you speak, you will keep getting better.

5. Reflect to Prepare for Next Time

Even when I'm finished speaking, I'm not finished with my preparation. Every communication experience is an opportunity for learning through self-evaluation. I do that—you guessed it—by asking myself questions:

- *Did I accomplish the Big Message objective?*
- *Did they see their possibilities?*
- *Do they know their value?*
- *Do they now feel empowered?*
- *Did I accomplish the Best Message objective?*
- *Did I help them?*

- *Are they likely to take action?*
- *Is there a way to make my message better?*
- *How can I upgrade my lesson notes?*

I've been communicating with people for more than fifty years, and it's very humbling to recognize how much more I need to learn. That's why I always reflect on every presentation after I make it and why I upgrade my notes after every presentation. I am constantly learning. I am a work in progress.

Preparation Furthers Personal Development

After more than five decades writing messages, I've come to a realization: one of the main reasons I'm still growing and developing at age seventy-five is that I write out, think through, and apply every lesson to my life before I teach it. Doing that work every time means I keep learning, improving, creating, discovering, developing, and growing. It's one of the most important disciplines in my life.

When I made the decision to *work it* instead of *wing it* as a speaker, I realized that preparation would become continual in my life. When I decided to write books, I knew it would be the same kind of decision. But the rewards have been great because it helps me keep improving. As author Malcolm Gladwell pointed out, "Practice isn't the thing you do once you're good. It's the thing you do that makes you good."⁴⁷

Preparation Multiplies Talent

What is the difference between talent and skill? Preparation. Talent is a gift; it's something you were born with. The greater the natural talent, the greater the potential a person has in that area. But talent does not become a high-level skill without preparation and practice. Here's how this works:

Low Gifting + Low Preparation = No Skill

Low Gifting + High Preparation = Average Skill

High Gifting + Low Preparation = Limited Skill

High Gifting + High Preparation = Great Skill

High Gifting + Continual High Preparation = Unlimited Skill

The more you have been gifted with natural talent, the better you will be when you first get started—and the more tempted you will be to rely on that talent alone. But if you want to reach your potential, you will need to put in the work.

Continual Preparation Brings Continual Improvement

How much natural talent do you have when it comes to communication? Is your gifting high, low, or somewhere in between? How do you know? Ralph Waldo Emerson said, "All the great speakers were bad speakers at first."⁴⁸ And I tell my new coaches, "Nobody's good the first time." If you've spoken once or twice, that doesn't tell you anything. The only way to find out is to speak before an audience—and to keep doing it. Frequency is the key to knowing. Until you speak frequently, you can't make an accurate assessment.

I've been told that mathematicians discount any statistics that lack necessary frequency. For example, if you flip a coin ten times, you will rarely experience a 50-50 split between heads and tails. However, if you flip a coin a hundred times, it's usually pretty close.

The same is true with speaking. You can't do it once, twice, or a dozen times and know whether you have talent. You can't measure your potential at that stage. You need to get in your reps. I used to say, "All's well that begins well." Now when it comes to speaking, I tell people, "All's well that begins!" If you're afraid of public speaking, you need to begin speaking, and you need to continue doing it. You need to practice. The only way to achieve excellence in anything is to do it enough times to test it. Wisdom will come as a result of doing something enough times that you can see the whole picture and develop understanding. I love the way James Clear expresses the importance of frequency in his book *Atomic Habits*:

It doesn't matter if it's been twenty-one days or thirty days or three hundred days. What matters is the rate at which you perform the behavior. You could do something twice in thirty days, or two hundred times. It's the frequency that makes the difference.⁴⁹

I'm very fortunate. I started my career as a senior pastor, which meant that on average I spoke three times a week for fifty weeks a year. In the three years I spent in my first position, I put more than four hundred reps under my belt. That kind of early practice was really controlled failure. I'd try new things, take risks, and experiment. The story of those early days was: fail early, fail often, fail forward. That preparation got me ready for later speaking opportunities.

Today I estimate that I have spoken more than thirteen thousand times, and I can tell you what the secret sauce is for speaking: frequency and consistency. Frequency gives short-term progress. If you speak frequently, you can start to "get it." Consistency gives long-term progress. If you speak consistently, you will be able to keep it. And the preparation and practice will never stop if you want to be at the top of your game. Just ask any elite athlete, concert pianist, highly sought-after speaker, or high-level performer in any profession. The higher you climb in proficiency and public acceptance, the greater the need to practice. Excellence is a result of many practices. So if you are gifted in speaking and you wing it, you may be in the top 50 percent of communicators. But if you are gifted and work it frequently and consistently, you can be in the top 5 percent.

PAY THE PRICE OF PREPARATION

One of the things that gives me joy is playing golf. I love everything about it—except my scores. I'm not as good as I would like to be. So I recently went to see my golf instructor, Warren Bottke, and I told him I wanted to improve my handicap. "I want to take my handicap from fifteen down to a single digit," I said.

"You can do that," he replied, which greatly encouraged me. Excited, I was ready for him to tell me what to do. "To reach that goal, you'll need to practice thirty hours a week."

"Wow!" I responded. "That's a lot of practice."

This reminded me of a time when I was hosting a leadership conference with over a thousand people in attendance. It was a wonderful day filled with laughter, learning, interaction, and growth. During the afternoon break a young man came up to me and said, "I'm inspired! I've decided I want to do what you do."

I just smiled. "Let me ask you a question," I responded. "Would you like to do what I *did* so you can do what I *do*?" He had no idea what it took for me to be able to do what I did on stage. As my friend Brian Tracy said, "Your success in your career will be in direct proportion to what you do after you've done what you are expected to do."

After thinking about this, I looked at my golf instructor and said, “I’ve changed my mind.”

I decided to live with my handicap the way it was and play golf when I want to with little practice. I love golf, but it is not my calling. I *wished* for a single-digit handicap. But my wish and my will to prepare were worlds apart. People who wing it end up with lots of wishes that go unfulfilled. People who work at it get results.

As you work to become a better communicator, after you’ve spent some time speaking, you’ll need to gauge your level of gifting and your level of commitment. If you prepare and practice, you can become good. You may even be able to become great. But remember, you cannot deliver what you have not developed. That’s the Law of Preparation.

THE LAW OF COLLABORATION

Some of Your Best Thinking Will Be Done with Others

ASPIRING COMMUNICATORS OFTEN ASK ME, “What advice do you have for me if I want to start speaking?” My first piece of advice is, “*Start speaking.*” The best way to learn and improve as a communicator is to practice, which I just discussed in the Law of Preparation (chapter 4). What’s the second piece of advice? Enlist the help of other people.

I didn’t understand this when I started my speaking career. I began as a Lone Ranger. My professional speaking and leadership careers started at the same time, when I was twenty-two. Back then, I believed that if I asked for help, the people who listened to me and followed me would view me as weak. And they would stop following and stop listening. As a result, I tried to do every leadership and speaking task myself. If I had a problem, I worked alone to figure it out on my own. When I got an idea, I’d think, *I’ll work on this until it’s really good. Then when I share it with people, everyone will think I’m brilliant.* What a mistake!

It would take me a decade to understand what would become what I call the Law of Significance, which says one is too small a number to achieve greatness. The same applies to communication. One is too small a number to achieve excellence.

Relying 100 percent on myself early in my career created two glaring problems for me. First, I often taught based on assumption. I assumed that I knew what people needed, but of course, I didn’t. That meant I often spoke on subjects no one wanted to hear about, giving solutions they were not looking for. Thank goodness my audience was grace-giving and took my youth and inexperience into consideration. The second problem was that everything I communicated was from my own limited personal experience and perspective. Again, that meant I missed so much and often failed to connect with people. As journalist and author William H. Whyte observed, “The great enemy of communication... is the illusion of it.”⁵⁰ I assumed I was communicating and connecting, but often I was talking only to myself. Back then, I didn’t know the Law of Collaboration, which says some of your best thinking will be done with others.

THE VALUE OF COLLABORATION

Billionaire philanthropist Andrew Carnegie said, “It marks a big step in your development when you come to realize that other people can help you do a better job than you could do alone.” That was a step I took in my speaking, and it’s one I hope you will take too. Several years ago, James Surowiecki

wrote a book called *The Wisdom of Crowds*. In it, he describes how groups of people often solve problems and come to conclusions more accurately than individuals alone, even when some of those individuals are experts in the field. Surowiecki opens his book with a compelling example that occurred in Britain more than a hundred years ago. In 1906, scientist Francis Galton was attending a country fair called the West of England Fat Stock and Poultry Exhibition, where local farmers and townspeople gathered to show their cattle, sheep, horses, chickens, and pigs. Galton, an expert on heredity and statistics, attended because he was interested in the effects of breeding on physical and mental qualities in livestock, but he was also interested in human genetics.

One of the events at the fair was a competition in which attendees could pay six pence to guess how much a live ox on exhibit would weigh after it was butchered and dressed, a difficult task. The people with the best guesses would receive prizes. Seeing this, Galton got an idea. He wondered how good the people in the group would be at making such a guess. A few might have expertise in livestock or butchering, but most would not. Galton, an eighty-five-year-old curmudgeon with a low opinion of people, expected people to guess poorly. He later wrote, “Many non-experts competed like those clerks and others who have no expert knowledge of horses, but who bet on races, guided by newspapers, friends, and their own fancies.”

Galton asked the organizers if he could borrow the entry slips for the contest after it was over. Each slip of paper contained the person’s guess and their personal information. When he received them, Galton did a statistical analysis of the 787 slips of paper he examined. As you might guess, nobody guessed the exact weight of the dressed ox, which was 1,198 pounds, not even the professional butchers. But Galton was shocked to discover that when he calculated the average of *all* the guesses, it was 1,197 pounds—only one pound off from the actual weight.^{[51](#)}

Surowiecki concludes,

Most of us, whether as voters or investors or consumers or managers, believe that valuable knowledge is concentrated in a very few hands.... We assume that the key to solving problems or making good decisions is finding that one right person who will have the answer [or becoming that person].... The argument of this book is that chasing the expert is a mistake, and a costly one at that. We should stop hunting and ask the crowd.^{[52](#)}

To become a better communicator, that’s what you need to do. Seek the wisdom of others, not from a random crowd but from a team or trusted group. As Surowiecki points out, “Groups are often smarter than the smartest people in them.”^{[53](#)}

It took me a while to learn this lesson, but now any time I am preparing to speak or to lead, my first thought is, *Who do I need to collaborate with?* I understand that success begins with *we*, not *me*. No one person has all the answers. Every speaker or leader has blind spots and shortcomings. No individual is completely well-rounded and balanced. But teams can be. When I ask my team to help me, they *always* make me better. No wonder former NFL coach Bill Parcells used to remind his players, “Individuals play the game, but teams win championships.”^{[54](#)}

When I’m getting ready to write a book, I often bring together a group of people to help me. This book was no exception. I started with my writing team. Together we worked on a preliminary list of laws. I then sent the list to a group of excellent communicators so that they could spend time looking at them, thinking about them, and considering ways to improve them. Those communicators, my team, and I met, and they took the ideas to a new level. The book you’re reading is a result of that collaboration.

One of the most popular books I've written is *How Successful People Think*. In the chapter on shared thinking, I explain why I value collaborative thinking so highly:

- Shared thinking is faster than solo thinking.
- Shared thinking brings more maturity than solo thinking.
- Shared thinking is more creative than solo thinking.
- Shared thinking is the only way to have great thinking.
- Great thoughts are birthed out of many good thoughts.
- Shared thinking returns greater value than solo thinking.⁵⁵

Whenever I share my thoughts with a group of good thinkers, they come up with ideas I never would have had. I may go into a meeting with a good idea, but I walk out with better ones. Collaboration has a multiplying effect. It's like the difference between 1 plus 1, which is 2, and 1 beside 1, which is 11.

CHARACTERISTICS OF A GOOD COLLABORATION TEAM

In my many years of speaking and leading, I've learned that success or failure is not determined by the weight of what you need to accomplish or the heaviness of the load you carry. It's determined by the people you collaborate with to help you accomplish the task. With that in mind, I want to give you some guidelines to help you identify the kinds of people you will want to bring onto your team to help you become a better communicator.

1. Good Collaborators Have an Open Mindset

For people to help you improve in communication—or in any endeavor, for that matter—they need to be able to see possibilities. They need to see possibilities in you, in your potential, in your audience, in your ability to impact them, and in their ability to take what you say and run with it. Negative, narrow-minded people will not help you; only open people will.

When I look for good collaborators, I seek people who possess two qualities. First, they need to be people who think in terms of abundance, not scarcity. They must believe there are always solutions, not doubt that something is possible.

I discovered the importance of this difference in thinking in my early thirties when I was asked to be a part of a team writing commentaries on every book of the Bible. The invitation was an honor because all the other writers were older, more experienced, and more successful than I was. I was asked to write the commentary for Deuteronomy, and as soon as I got started, I knew I was in over my head. I began to doubt whether I could accomplish such a daunting task. *Can I do this?* I began asking myself. This question began to undermine my efforts, and my doubt increased. I started making excuses for not working on it. The longer I avoided the task, the larger it appeared and the greater number of reasons I saw for it being impossible.

Fortunately, the other writers who were working on their commentaries at the same time encouraged me. They imparted wisdom and gave me advice. They became my support team, and my mindset began to change. I began looking for solutions. Those solutions helped me to make progress. When you ask, “Can I?” the answer might be no. But when you ask, “How can I?” the answer almost always leads to yes. It took me a year, but I completed the task. And I'm very proud of the work I did.

The second quality I look for in potential collaborators is an options mindset. I want them to be like the old chicken farmer whose land flooded nearly every spring. He didn't want to sell the family farm and move, but he was getting tired of having to move hundreds of chickens every year and losing many of them. After an especially bad flood, he was complaining to his wife.

"Every year you whine about the same thing," she said. "I'm tired of hearing about it."

"Well," he barked, "what do you think I should do?" She looked at him and replied, "Buy ducks."

OK, that's a corny old story, but it shows the kind of mindset you want from people who will help you. An options mindset causes people to believe there are many solutions to any problem. And when there is more than one way, that means there's always a better way.

Every time I speak, I give it my best shot. But that doesn't mean I can't get better or that I can't give it another *better* shot. No matter what I do, I believe I can find a way to improve. The challenge is to find it.

2. Good Collaborators Ask and Answer Questions

Woodrow Wilson said, "We should not only use all the brains we have, but all the brains we can borrow." When collaborators ask questions that stir my thinking or answer my questions, it's like getting to borrow their brains. Their thinking improves my thinking.

I love questions. I learn so much from asking them and listening to answers. Recently I was teaching a lesson called "Questions to Ask to Develop Your Leadership" to a group of high-level leaders, and afterward during a Q&A, a leader asked, "Do you ask questions if you sense that you will not like the answer?" He was articulating what all of us have felt at times: suspecting that we have a problem and not wanting to face it.

"Yes," I answered. "I ask the question even when I may not like the answer. Even though it can be painful, some of the answers I don't like can be the ones that help me the most."

As you work to become a better communicator, you should not avoid asking tough questions you might not like the answer to. You must have courage and be honest with yourself if you want to improve. Here are some questions that may help you.

Questions Before You Speak

If you share your notes with your team before you speak, they can ask these five potentially tough questions to help you prepare:

1. *Have I seen the speaker live this message?*
2. *How has this subject influenced my life?*
3. *What do I not know about this subject that I need to know?*
4. *What is the most important part of this message and why?*
5. *What is the one thing I would do to improve this presentation?*

If your team members honestly share their responses to these questions with you, they can help you. The best time to improve your communication is on the front end, before you do it. Obviously, your team could ask you many other questions as well, but these are designed to help you improve *before* you deliver a speech.

Questions After You Speak

Your team can also help you improve *after* you speak if they answer these questions:

1. What was the response of the audience on a scale of 1 (low) to 5 (high)?
2. What was the strongest five minutes of the message?
3. What was the weakest five minutes of the message?
4. How can the lesson be improved?
5. How can the speaker be improved?

Your team's answers to these questions will help you expand the best part of your message, eliminate the weakest part, and improve your connection with the audience.

One more thought about questions: what you ask and how you ask makes a difference. Albert Einstein is reputed to have said, "If I had an hour to solve a problem and my life depended on the solution, I would spend the first 55 minutes determining the proper question to ask... for once I know the proper question, I could solve the problem in less than five minutes."⁵⁶ This addresses the importance of thinking about asking the right question. The more well-thought-out the questions are, the better the answers will be. And when the questions are asked in the spirit of improvement, not criticism, the more helpful they will be.

3. Good Collaborators Generate Ideas

In addition to being open-minded to asking and answering questions, good collaborators are also capable of coming up with good ideas. This may be the greatest value your team will bring because great speeches contain ideas that spark the imagination of the audience.

It's important to remember that an idea doesn't have to be your idea to be good. What's important is that every idea be brought to the table so that the best idea can win. As you bring together a collaborative team to help you with ideas, here are some things you should do:

Ask Everyone to Generate as Many Ideas as Possible

I've always found it to be true that the greater the *quantity* of ideas, the greater the *quality* of ideas. The more ideas you test, the more likely you are to find good ideas that work. Here's what I know from experience:

- The only bad ideas are the ones that die without birthing another idea.
- The team's best ideas added together should give you a breakthrough.
- Ideas are like rabbits. Get a couple and they multiply.

As Romanian-born artist Albert Szent-Györgyi said, "Creativity is to see what everybody has seen and to think what nobody has thought."⁵⁷ You and your team can discover an idea and take it in a whole new direction.

Today I have a reputation for being an excellent communicator, but like many people, I started out as an average speaker. But as I explained in the Law of Preparation (chapter 4), I got a lot of practice. During those early years, I tested a lot of ideas. Many of them didn't work. I lived the speaker's cycle of success: Communicate – Fail – Learn – Develop – Connect. The good news is that I learned a lot. The bad news is that if I'd had a team helping me generate ideas *and improve them*, I could have tested many of those ideas before I stepped in front of an audience, and my communication would have improved more quickly.

Adapt the Ideas of Others

Early in my career, I may not have had a team to help me come up with good ideas, but I did have access to books and tapes. I spent many hours reading and listening for good ideas. If I came across a quote or idea that grabbed me, I saved it. This was the start of the Law of Collaboration for me. Some of my best ideas came from other people. Often, I simply quoted them. But the more ideas I discovered and digested, the more ideas of my own I generated, springboarding off the ideas of others.

I have developed a lifestyle of looking and listening for great ideas, and it has led to some of my best work. Here are some examples:

- One evening, I was having dinner in Chicago with Robert Kiyosaki, the author of *Rich Dad, Poor Dad*. During our conversation he said, “Sometimes you win and sometimes you learn.” That got my attention. I loved that statement. And I asked him if I could use those words for the title of a book. He said yes, and that became the title of *Sometimes You Win, Sometimes You Learn*.
- I was playing golf with Victor Oliver, my editor at the time, and he told me about a marketing book he had read. Later he showed it to me: *The 22 Immutable Laws of Marketing*. “John,” he said, “you should write a book on the laws of leadership.” That idea was the impetus for me to write *The 21 Irrefutable Laws of Leadership*, which is now the bestselling leadership book of all time.
- When I was writing *Everyone Communicates, Few Connect*, my writing team convinced me to release the book online, one chapter at a time. As we posted the chapters on my blog, we asked readers to make comments to help us improve the book. We received hundreds of responses; the best ideas went into the book, and we gave people credit.

I can hardly count all the ways my team and other thinkers have helped me become a better speaker, writer, and leader.

Ideas are *birthed* during times of collaboration.

Ideas are *proven* during times of action.

Ideas are *improved* during times of reflection.

If you want more and better ideas, learn to collaborate with others. That’s where the process starts. Soon you will be using them to generate good ideas of your own.

Capture Every Good Idea

Most speakers write a message and spend hours, days, or weeks searching for ideas, quotes, stories, and anecdotes to include. They think, *I read that somewhere. Which book was that in?* and start rummaging through their bookshelves. Or they start searching the Internet.

When I sit down to write a message, I spend mere minutes gathering top-notch material. How is that possible? I’ve been looking for material for almost sixty years, and I’ve captured the best and filed it where I can put my hands on it literally in seconds.

As I already mentioned, I knew from the age of eighteen that I wanted to be a public speaker. That’s when I started looking for ideas. My father is the one who encouraged me to capture them so that I could use them. He would say to me, “The number one time-waster is looking for things that are

lost. You won't lose things if you have a place to put them." That's what prompted me to develop my filing system.

When I'm reading a book, if I find a quote I like, I stop right then and mark it on the page in brackets. And I ask myself, "What subject should that be filed under?" When I know the answer, I write the word next to the passage. Then I flip to the inside cover of the book and write the page number where I saw the quote and the subject. As I continue to read, if I find other quotes, I do the same. When I'm done with the book, I give it to my assistant, and she photocopies each quote, and it goes into a file on that subject.

If I'm reading a magazine or newspaper and I see a quote or story I like, I mark it, decide on the subject, and rip out the page to keep. It goes into that subject file.

If I'm listening to a podcast or a tape and hear something I want to capture, I get the whole message transcribed and mark the passages I want to keep. And—you guessed it—those go into files by subject.

This is how I have so many ideas, quotes, and anecdotes on hand and ready to use. When I'm writing a lesson and need a quote or idea, I turn my chair so that I can reach my files, grab the subject file I'm looking for, and find something that works. Every day, I am preparing material to write and speak because I never stop looking for it. And I never waste time finding it.

And here's what's great: my team also collects ideas, quotes, and anecdotes for me. When my writing partner, Charlie Wetzel, first began working with me almost thirty years ago, he wasn't good at finding the kind of material I wanted. He came from an academic background so he looked for ideas that were smart or clever. I had to teach him my criteria. Anything I use must check one or more of these boxes:

- **Heart.** It touches people at an emotional level.
- **Help.** It gives people something they can think or do that improves their lives.
- **Humor.** It makes them laugh.
- **Hope.** It inspires them and helps them believe in a better future for themselves or others.

All of these are ways to add value to people.

Charlie still writes with me and collects ideas, but the workhorse for this in recent years has been Erin Miller. She is constantly searching for material for me that helps me in my verbal communication and my books. And coming up behind her is a newer member of our team, Jared Cagle. He's learning the ropes and contributing too.

You may already have a team of people helping you generate good ideas. If not, I encourage you to create one. But even before that, you can start capturing ideas yourself. Every day, you can read and listen to find and file material for the future. If you develop that discipline, great material will be there when you need it.

4. Good Collaborators Give Honest Feedback

The final quality I look for in good collaborators is the willingness and ability to give good feedback. That's important because good communicators never stop trying to get better. I've been speaking for nearly five decades, I speak around two hundred fifty times a year, and I'm still working to get better.

After I speak, the first person I ask for feedback is my host. Exceeding my host's expectations is my first objective. But even when I succeed, that's not enough for me. I want to improve, so I ask for feedback from trusted members of my team. Here's why I'm such a fanatic for feedback:

- **I don't see myself as others see me.** Feedback increases my self-awareness and helps remove my blind spots.
- **I don't see things as others see them.** Feedback gives me a broader perspective than if I rely only on my own limited experience.
- **I don't see everything, so I ask, "What am I missing?"** I always assume that I am missing something, but if I don't intentionally ask people to point it out, they may not.
- **It shows my team I value their opinion.** I want to demonstrate to my team that I value them and care what they think. Everyone feels complimented when you ask their opinion.
- **It's a catalyst for improving.** I won't get answers to questions I don't ask. If I ask, I learn, and I can adjust.
- **It's the best way to discover the best idea.** Again, the best way to get a *great* idea is to put together many *good* ideas.

Anyone can give you valuable feedback. The more different people are from you, the more value their feedback is likely to have, because they will see things you don't. However, I've found the most valuable feedback comes from other successful communicators. While noncommunicators may be able to tell when you failed to connect with your audience, experienced communicators can tell you what caused the breakdown and why. So especially seek out feedback from them.

One of the communicators I've admired for many years is Chuck Swindoll. When I moved to California in my thirties, he was already a successful author and speaker, and he kindly took me under his wing. I was so grateful. He's someone who understands the value of collaboration. Years ago, he wrote a piece called "No Place for Islands." I love it because it illustrates the importance of working with other people. In part it says,

Nobody is a whole chain. Each one is a link. But take away one link and the chain is broken.

Nobody is a whole team. Each one is a player. But take away one player and the game is forfeited.

Nobody is a whole orchestra. Each one is a musician. But take away one musician and the symphony is incomplete.

Nobody is a whole play. Each one is an actor. But take away one actor and the performance suffers.

Nobody is a whole hospital. Each one is a part of the staff. But take away one person and it isn't long before the patient can tell....

You guessed it. We need each other. You need someone and someone needs you. Isolated islands we're not. To make this thing called life work, we gotta lean and support. And relate and respond. And give and take. And confess and forgive. And reach out and embrace. And release and rely....

Since none of us is a whole, independent, self-sufficient, supercapable, all-powerful hotshot, let's quit acting like we are. Life's lonely enough without our playing that silly role.

The game's over. Let's link up.^{[58](#)}

If you want to become the best communicator you can, don't try to do it alone. Seek out others to help you. Develop a team. Ask for help. Work together. You'll never regret it. Why? Because some of your best thinking will be done with others. That's the Law of Collaboration.

THE LAW OF CONTENT

When You Have Something Worth Saying, People Start Listening

IN JANUARY 1996, MICROSOFT COFOUNDER Bill Gates wrote an essay about the future of the Internet. The title of his piece was “Content Is King.”⁵⁹ He believed the fledgling online world of the 1990s and 2000s would take a path similar to the one broadcast media had up to that point, where the people who created content would be the influencers, not the technologists. Now, more than twenty-five years later, his assertion has proven true, and his statement about content has been repeated thousands of times by content creators, business executives, marketers, and media moguls.

If content is king, then communication is queen. They rule together, and they cannot be separated. What value does content have if it’s not communicated to anyone? And what value does communication have if there is no content?

One of the greatest challenges speakers face is the fact that the average person hears thousands of messages every day. Communicators are vying for people’s attention in this environment. In a world where you can instantaneously access content on virtually any subject, how can you make your content and message stand out? How will you grab people’s attention and hold it long enough to make a positive impact on them? How? You work at it. And here’s the good news: when you have something worth saying, people will start listening. That’s the Law of Content.

EVERY MESSAGE IS A PUZZLE

A message is like a puzzle. The goal for you as a communicator is to display a picture, making it easy for your audience to see it and understand it. As you generate the content of your talk and plan it, you are like a puzzle maker. You are laying out your ideas, which are the puzzle pieces of your message. You must work to make sure all the pieces fit together to create a compelling picture. But the challenge is that the people listening to you when you deliver the message will be the ones to assemble the puzzle from scratch and create a meaningful picture in the five, fifteen, or sixty minutes you have for speaking. If they can’t put it together and enjoy the process, you haven’t succeeded as a communicator.

I first began to think about this process as puzzle making after reading business and leadership consultant Peter Meyers’s description of “jigsaw management.” He compares leading people to putting together a puzzle, and says, “The task of the owner or general manager is to make the box top clear.”⁶⁰ He goes on to talk about the pressure people feel when they must put together a puzzle in a

compressed amount of time, their frustration when pieces are missing, or their annoyance if extra pieces that don't belong have been added.

Most communicators have more to say than they have time to say it. That means you must be selective. You can't give people a thousand-piece puzzle in a one-hundred-piece time slot. If you try to include more than a few main ideas in your message, you have too many. Think about the picture you want to create. What is on your "box top?" Your goal must be to include all the pieces needed to complete the picture with no extra pieces that might detract from it or confuse your audience.

As you know, not everyone who speaks is as selective as he should be. For example, Felix Frankfurter, a noted professor at Harvard Law School, served as an associate justice of the Supreme Court of the United States from 1939 to 1962. Even though his career required him to speak frequently, he wasn't known for making his messages easy for people to follow. His wife, Marion, who was a writer and editor, often pointed out his limitations as a speaker. "There are only two things wrong with Felix's speeches: He digresses," she explained, "and he returns to the subject."⁶¹

LET'S PUT THE CONTENT PUZZLE TOGETHER

If you don't want people in your audience to become frustrated when you stray from your subject—and when you return to it!—you need to become skilled at designing the puzzle of your message. You want people to be able to follow your thinking and see the picture you're trying to create. Here are nine steps you can follow as you create your content.

1. Start with Your Audience

Great content begins with understanding your audience. In the Law of Preparation (chapter 4), I explained the pre-call I make to the organization for which I will be speaking so that I can ask questions about the organization, audience, and event. It's vital to look beyond their marketing lingo and publicity to know who they are, understand what motivates them, and determine what they need. When you don't know your audience or don't craft your content to fit them, you're in danger of losing them, like the father of the four-year-old boy who was eating an apple in the back seat of the car. After taking a bite and holding onto the apple a few minutes, he said, "Daddy?"

"Yes?"

"Why is my apple turning brown?"

"Well," his father explained, "after you ate the outer skin off, the meat of the apple came in contact with the air, which caused it to oxidize, changing its molecular structure, and thus turning it into a different color."

There was a long silence, and the little boy asked softly, "Daddy, are you talking to me?"⁶²

I like what communication expert and author Nancy Duarte said about a speaker's audience: "The audience is the hero who will determine the outcome of your idea, so it's important to know them fully. Jump into the shoes of your audience and look carefully at their lives."⁶³

While it's vital for *any* communicator to put themselves into the shoes of their audience, it's even more important to do that if the audience considers the speaker to be more successful than they are, because in their minds, there is a success gap. Great communicators close this gap.

Recently I was talking with my friend Chris Hodges, who hosts a large annual event for pastors called GrowLeader. He was preparing his message for the audience of five thousand, and he asked my advice about his opening message. Chris is a down-to-earth person of great humility, but he is also the founder and leader of one of the largest and most influential churches in the world. I knew there

would be a perceived success gap, so my advice was simple. I suggested he open his talk with how he started as a pastor: “Tell them that you did not know what to do and the things you attempted didn’t always work. Let them know that in the beginning you had more questions than answers, and you never thought that your church would be one of the most influential churches in the world.”

Why did I give him that advice? I wanted his audience to see him as they see themselves. There was no obvious path from where they were to his level of success. He had to put on their shoes, go back to his beginning, and let everyone know that he once stood where they were. When Chris did this, the pastors knew that he understood them. Feeling understood opened them up to his message.

As you prepare a message, always start with finding out who your audience is and considering your subject from their point of view.

2. Stay in Your Strength Zones

When you know who your audience is, you begin to get a sense of what they need. What will you try to give them? The danger is trying to give them something they need that you don’t have. That is a recipe for disaster as a communicator. My advice to avoid that problem is for you to stay in your strength zone.

When I communicate, I speak and write only in the areas of my strengths. I stick to the eight subjects I know well and can address with excellence:

- Communication
- Leadership
- Equipping
- Attitude
- Relationships
- Success
- Significance
- Faith

These are the things I know and can speak about. My strength zones allow me to have not only knowledge but also moral authority because I’ve proven myself in those areas.

What are your strength zones? What do you do best? Where do you possess great skill and natural ability? Where do you demonstrate strong intuition? How have you been best able to help people and add value to them? These are the places you are effective and can be effective with others. The successes of your past will give credibility to your words.

3. Develop Your Thesis

Robert Frost said, “Half the world is composed of people who have something to say and can’t, and the other half who have nothing to say and keep on saying it.”⁶⁴ To help you avoid either fate, you need to develop a thesis for your message.

Your thesis is the main thought, expressed in a single statement, that contains the essence of your message. Every time you intend to communicate through speaking or writing, you should identify your thesis. The hardest people to follow are communicators who are searching for their core idea as they deliver their message. If you don’t know what your main point is, how will anyone else? Your thesis is the box top of the puzzle. It describes what the puzzle will look like when it has every piece in its

place. For example, the thesis of this book is: *If you learn and practice the laws of communication, you will become a better communicator.*

Sometimes I know my thesis before I begin writing. Knowing who my audience is, what they need, and what I can offer them leads me to my thesis. Other times, I follow my intuition. I start doing my research and I might even start writing my outline before I'm sure of the thesis. Either way, by the time I'm done writing my message, I know what my thesis is. I recommend that you know what yours is too.

4. Do Your Research

Your next two steps are doing research and creating an outline. You can do them in either order, but I almost always start with research because it stimulates my thinking and lights the flame of my creativity. Plus, I work faster when I start with something, rather than trying to create my outline from scratch.

I begin my research by gathering material to support my thesis. I pull together stories, quotes, thoughts, ideas, and illustrations. When I began my career, this was laborious. It's why I started my filing system. Every day I read, find, and save good content. When I'm ready to write a message, I have handpicked material waiting for me. Today there's no end to the amount of material you can access in seconds because of the Internet, so you have a different challenge. It's not finding material; it's finding the *right* material that not only fits your message but also fits you.

I encourage you not only to do research for specific talks you are planning to give, but also continually look for great material that fits your values and style. Capture and record that material using file folders or an electronic system. Your content will only be as good as your research.

5. Write Your Outline

The other critical part of the message-writing process is your outline. This functions as the bones of your speech. (The same is true if you're writing a book.) A good outline makes your message solid and holds it together. For example, the bones of this book are the sixteen laws. They provide the skeleton on which the meat of the book hangs. As a reader, you can look at a book's table of contents and see the bones of the book and judge whether you want to buy and read it. But when you give a speech, people can't see the bones (unless you give them a handout or project it on a screen), so you need to make the outline easy for people to listen to and follow. That's one of the reasons I always number my points. I also try to create a sense of continuity and rhythm in the outline so that people experience a sense of satisfaction as I deliver it and a feeling of completion as I end it.

Here are some examples. Thirty years ago, I created a faith-based message called "Five Things I Know about People." As I wrote the speech, I played on the word *body* to give it continuity and make it playful. Some of the points are a bit long, but they worked:

1. Everybody Wants to Be Somebody
2. Nobody Was Created to Be a Nobody
3. Everybody Can Help Anybody Become a Somebody
4. Anybody Who Helps Somebody Becomes a Somebody
5. God Loves Everybody and Makes Each of Us Somebody

Here's another example. It was a lesson I wrote on success using rhyme in its points to make it memorable. I taught that success is

- Knowing your purpose in life,
- Growing to your maximum potential, and
- Sowing seeds that benefit others.

That outline later became the basis for my book *Your Road Map for Success*. Other times, I'd use an acrostic to make my points memorable. Here's the outline of a message I created using the words **PLAN AHEAD** :

Predetermine a course of action.

Lay out your goals.

Aadjust your priorities.

Notify key personnel.

Allow time for acceptance.

Head into action.

Expect problems.

Always point to the successes.

Daily review your plan.

I created that message more than forty years ago, and I can still remember and recite all the points because of the acrostic.

As you work on your outline, don't think of it as a set of unrelated points. Make it memorable. A good outline can stand alone, and it has flow. A great outline has a hook that holds the whole thing together and creates a sense of anticipation in listeners that not only makes them think they know where you're going but also provides a few surprises in ideas or phrasing along the way. There's really an art to it, but you can master it if you continually work at it and try to improve with each message you write.

6. Put the Body on the Bones

In his book *An Experiment in Criticism*, novelist, professor, and critic C. S. Lewis wrote, "The first demand any work of any art makes upon us is surrender. Look. Listen. Receive. Get yourself out of the way."⁶⁵ While he was writing about examining works, his insight also applies to creating them. As we approach the crafting of a message, we must remain open to the possibilities it has when it's delivered. To do this, I approach a message with this three-step thinking:

1. Sense: How has this content affected me?

2. Surrender: This content is not about me; it's about others.

3. Share: How can this content positively affect others?

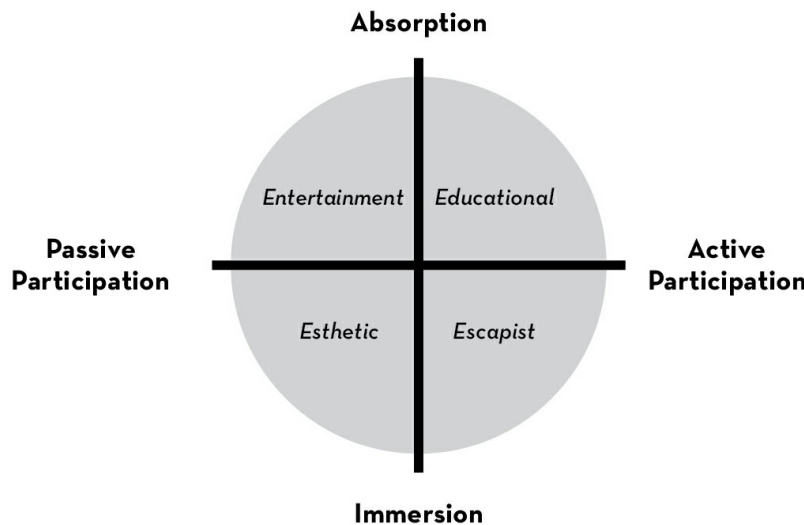
With those ideas in mind, I'm ready to do the hard work of preparing the body of my message.

I look at my outline and start fleshing it out, putting what I've researched into place. I illustrate each point with stories, quotes, anecdotes, and information. I add stories from my own life. I move things around as needed. I rephrase things. My goal is to create a memorable and moving experience for my audience.

B. Joseph Pine II and James H. Gilmore, who wrote *The Experience Economy*, describe the way people process experiences based on whether they are passive or active and whether they "absorb"

the experience or are immersed in it. They describe what they call the four experience realms: entertainment, educational, escapist, and esthetic.⁶⁶ (See the diagram from Pine and Gilmore on the following page.)

Entertainment occurs when people passively absorb the experience, such as watching a concert or reading a book. An educational experience also focuses on absorbing information, but in addition, the participants are actively engaged in mind, body, or both. People learning skills in a classroom or on a field learning to play soccer have this experience. An escapist experience is both immersive and active, such as when people visit theme parks, gamble in casinos, or play computer games. Esthetic experiences are immersive but passive, leaving no physical effect on their environment. Examples include gazing at the Grand Canyon or viewing an art exhibit.



People seek an educational experience to *learn*, an escapist experience to *do*, an entertainment experience to *sense*, and an esthetic experience to *be there*. However, Pine and Gilmore assert, “The richest experiences encompass aspects of all four realms. These center on the ‘sweet spot’ in the middle of the framework.”⁶⁷ The same is true for the richest experiences for an audience. For that reason, I look for ways as I write my outline to include all four of these realms for the audience. Here’s how I apply that:

- Education (To Learn): Where is the teaching in my content?
- Escapist (To Do): Where is the interaction in my content?
- Entertainment (To Sense): Where is the emotion in my content?
- Esthetic (To Be There): Where is the connection in my content?

The more ways you can add to your audience’s experience, the better the experience they will have; it will have greater impact and be more memorable.

7. Create Runways to Your Ideas

Every message is like an airplane flight. To get somewhere, it has to take off and it has to land. The success of your communication depends on these two things. If it can’t take off, it never flies with the audience. If you can’t land it, then it will crash at the end. Either way, you’ve lost your audience, and all the work you’ve done creating your content will be in vain.

There are a lot of ways to create a good takeoff. I like to build my starting runway by using these kinds of things:

- A question
- A quote
- A prediction
- A current event
- A historical reference
- A promise of improvement
- A heart connection
- An appeal to the audience's self-interest

My desire is to put at least four of these into the first five minutes of my message. The ones I use every time are the heart connection and the self-interest appeal. One of the reasons I so often say, "My name is John and I'm your friend" is that I want to make a heart connection with people. I want them to know I'm there for them, and I care for them. To appeal to their self-interest, I might say something like, "This morning I was thinking about you and how I could add value to you today." Again, I want them to know my goal is to help them and make them glad they came.

Just as you need a runway for a powerful takeoff, you also need one to achieve a smooth landing. I've watched too many speakers do a poor job of "landing the plane." Some just stop as if they ran out of fuel. Others look like they're practicing what pilots call touch-and-goes, where it appears they are about to land, but then they take back off. They circle back around, line up a landing, and take off again. The more they do this, the more their audiences become exhausted, confused, and frustrated.

My advice is to line up the best approach, know exactly where to land the plane, focus, and finish. You can do these things by

- Reviewing and summarizing your talk,
- Giving people an action plan, and
- Empowering them to take action.

If people are clear on what you said, know what to do, and are inspired to do it, you will have added value to them, and they will walk away feeling helped and empowered.

8. Plan Your Transitions

Recently a friend sent me a picture of a tour guide walking with a sign held high so his people could follow and keep up with him, but in the photo, no one was following. Not one person! The number one rule for any tour guide is: Don't lose your group. That's also true for communicators. And the quickest way to lose an audience is through poor transitions.

I call a transition the trapeze of a talk because moving smoothly from one idea to another is like letting go of one swinging trapeze bar and having to grab the next one. I've found that in a forty-five-minute presentation, I must navigate four to six trapeze moments where I have to let go of where I am to arrive successfully at where I want to go.

The thing that helps me most to transition well is that the main points in my presentations are numbered, so going from one number to the next makes a transition obvious and easy for my audience to follow. However, I also make frequent use of a pause. Since the pause is the most understood

transition in conversation, it's very effective in speeches. Then why do many communicators fail to use it? They avoid silence because they believe they are giving up control of the audience. But pauses can be used powerfully. I will examine the pause extensively in the Law of the Change-Up (chapter 14), so I don't need to say much about it here other than to encourage you to use it.

I use a lot of other techniques on stage to transition, but they are not written into my content. I move from place to place. I use a facial expression. I change the rhythm of my speech. I stand up or sit down. The best transitions come as the result of being connected to the members of your audience and interacting with them. If you don't have extensive experience speaking, look for places in your content where you can add cues to make physical transitions.

9. Use Phrasing That Creates Echoes

The final piece of the puzzle can be one of the most difficult to create but is often the most impactful: using phrasing that creates echoes in people's minds and hearts. To quote Mark Twain, "The difference between the *almost-right* word and the *right* word is really a large matter—it's the difference between the lightning-bug and the lightning."⁶⁸

When I prepare content, I work hard to create memorable phrasing. I know people will not remember every word of my speech. But if I use the *right* words, they will remember a sentence or a phrase, and it will become "portable." They will carry it with them after the experience, and they will repeat it to others.

This is a characteristic of great speakers. I don't remember all of any speech John F. Kennedy gave, but I do remember this phrase: "Ask not what your country can do for you—ask what you can do for your country."⁶⁹ He could have said, "What can you do for America?" but instead he made his words memorable.

Novelist Joseph Conrad observed, "Words have set whole nations in motion and upheaved the dry, hard ground on which rests our social fabric. Give me a right word and the right accent, and I will move the world."⁷⁰ An extraordinary example of this occurred in the speech Franklin D. Roosevelt gave on December 8, 1941. The day before, the president had learned of the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor around noon, and for the rest of the afternoon, he and his staff received fragmentary reports about the destruction and its toll. By evening, he had decided he would go to Congress the following day to ask them for a declaration of war.

Roosevelt's speeches usually took three to ten days to create and involved multiple speechwriters. But in this instance, the president called his secretary, Grace Tully, and said, "Sit down, Grace. I'm going before Congress tomorrow, and I'd like to dictate my message. It will be short."

He began, "Yesterday, December 7th, 1941, a date which will live in world history, the United States was simultaneously and deliberately attacked by naval and air forces of the Empire of Japan." He continued dictating without hesitation or revisions until he had completed a message of about five hundred words.

When Roosevelt received the typed copy, he didn't change much. The most significant change was to cross out "a date which will live in world history" and rephrase it to "a date which will live in *infamy*." He made other minor changes, but those words created echoes. That speech has come to be known as the "Day of Infamy Speech," and millions of Americans who weren't even alive when Roosevelt said those words can quote that line.⁷¹

Another great example is Martin Luther King Jr.'s "I Have a Dream" speech. In it, he used repetition, starting sentences with the phrase "I have a dream" eight different times. Today you can

say just those four words and people know you're referencing the speech that painted a picture of a better world of racial equality and reconciliation. King, like any teacher who knows the importance of repetition to learning, repeated the phrase yet without making it feel repetitious because he was creative and passionate in his delivery. Study great speakers, and you will find phrasing that has taken on a life of its own because of the creative and powerful way they worded their messages.

For years, I have made it my goal to use phrasing in my communication that will create echoes. I love when a well-known phrase such as "Sometimes you win, sometimes you lose" can be given a creative twist and becomes "Sometimes you win, sometimes you learn." And I always try to make a phrase catchy, so instead of saying, "Success requires hard work," I will say, "Pay now, play later" or "You have to give up to go up." Once I was talking with writer, director, and producer Tyler Perry and as he told me about continuing to work hard after he no longer needed to, I said, "When you can afford to quit, you can't afford to quit." It stuck with me and later inspired me as I addressed a company that had just experienced a record-breaking year. I said, "You didn't come this far only to come this far."

In any presentation, we say a lot of words. Most are heard and soon forgotten. However, if you intentionally work to create echo statements in your communication, your listeners will feel your speech as well as hear it, and they will remember parts of it long after you're done speaking.

Once I'm done creating my content, I'm still not done. I look at my notes, trying to evaluate the entire message, and I ask myself three questions:

- *How has what I'm communicating affected me?* If I'm not moved, my audience won't be either.
- *How can I make it unique and different?* Very few speakers or speeches are remembered; we have to *make* them memorable.
- *How can I make it better?* If I can do anything to improve it before I deliver it, I do it.

If you work hard on your content and make every message the best it can be, the Law of Content will start to kick in. You will say something worth saying and people will start listening. That will feel very satisfying. But don't let that stop you from continuing to strive, learn, and grow.

To remain relevant and relatable, learn something new every day. Keep researching and exploring. Keep asking questions. Live new experiences. Read and file content every day. Love what you do. And always update any lesson you intend to teach more than once. Your content will keep getting better only if *you* keep getting better. If you're continually growing, you will *never* run out of content, and you will *always* have something worth saying.

HOW IT IS SAID

THE LAW OF CONNECTING

Communicators Know It's All About Others

WHEN AUTHORS WRITE, THEY KNOW that some parts of their book are more important than others. Not every idea has equal weight. Some have much greater value than others. Many times, we leave it up to you, the reader, to discover those most important ideas on your own and take note of them without our bringing any extra attention to them.

This is not one of those times, so I'll be as clear as possible: *The Law of Connecting is by far the most important idea in this book.*

Why? Because communication is all about others. Too many speakers put all their emphasis on content. They believe content has more value than connection. That's not true. While both content and connection are important, good communicators know connection is more important than content. That's why I say communicators know it's all about others. That's the Law of Connecting.

WILL YOU MAKE THE CONNECTION?

When you listen to someone talk to others, you know immediately what they value: themselves, their content, or their audience.

People who focus on themselves *seek to gain attention.*

Speakers who focus on content *give out information.*

Communicators who focus on others *make a connection.*

Until you connect with people, there will be a barrier between you and them. No matter how good your content is, people will not receive it as well as they would if you connected first. Without connection, they may be *interested*, but they will not be *inspired*. People will receive more from a communicator with *average* content who *connects* than they ever will from a speaker with *great* content who *never connects*. Here's why: people do not care how much you know until they know how much you care. If you want to get through, you must connect. If you can connect *and* have great content, it will be a home run!

If you think about human nature, this makes sense. If it is true that almost everything we become and accomplish in life occurs with and through other people, then the ability to connect and create rapport with others is the most important skill we can learn. Spouses who connect with each other are more likely to stay married. Parents who connect with their kids are more likely to maintain positive

relationships with them. Leaders who connect with their team members are more likely to create productive teams. And communicators who connect with their audiences are more likely to get through to them and add value to them when they speak.

The ability to connect has become even more important now that we're communicating virtually more often. It's very easy for people to get distracted, drift, or tune out when they're on a video call. I'm very aware of this when I'm communicating live using technology. Viewers become passive, like dispassionate observers looking through a window at you. I do what I can to "enter" their room and try to be with them so they feel seen and connected.

For example, I recently hosted a Zoom mentoring call for young entrepreneurial moms. One mother had her small child on her lap as she was listening to my teaching, and her child began to fuss and cry. I could see that she was embarrassed. Instead of ignoring the distraction or trying to talk over it, I stopped teaching and spoke to her. I asked her the name and age of her child. I asked if she had other children. Then I talked for three minutes about how much I admired her desire to be a good mother and also learn and grow in her career. Soon, the other mothers used the Zoom chat to say how much they admired her too. She later let me know that she went from feeling embarrassed to embraced, and she was grateful.

When communicating virtually, you need to connect however you can. During the COVID-19 pandemic, a CEO friend was sharing his frustration because he could no longer communicate with the employees of his large company in person. He had been accustomed to getting feedback from them as he spoke. He felt as if he wasn't connecting on screen. He asked my advice. "Tell them you miss their feedback," I suggested. "And give them your cell phone number and ask them to text you." He tried that and said virtual communication no longer felt isolating; he sensed inclusion and connection with his employees again.

Connecting with people, especially while speaking, is very fulfilling to me. I focus on it before, during, and after I speak. Before I speak, the first question I ask myself is, *How will I connect with my audience?* The question I ask myself while I'm speaking is, *Am I connecting with my audience?* And when I'm finished, the question I ask myself is, *Did I connect with my audience?* If I can't answer those questions positively, I haven't been successful as a speaker. I haven't truly communicated.

HOW I LEARNED ABOUT CONNECTING

I have been a speaker for fifty-seven years. But I have been a speaker who connects for only forty-seven of those years. I had to learn how to connect with people, and you can too! While it took me ten years to figure out how to connect while speaking, the foundation was laid for connecting with people earlier in my life. I want to share what I learned through the years so that it doesn't take you as long as it took me to learn the Law of Connecting.

In My School Years, I Learned the Value of Connection

My third-grade teacher, Mrs. Stein, was good at teaching but not at connecting. She never built that bridge to us as students. As a result, we learned our lessons, but we did not love our teacher.

The next year I was in school, everything changed. My teacher was Mrs. Tacy, who turned out to be my favorite teacher. She not only taught well but connected well. Yes, we learned our lessons, but we also loved her. Fourth grade was my favorite year, not because I learned more but because of the connection I felt with her!

As I transitioned from elementary school to junior high, different teachers taught me different courses for the first time. Like most students, I liked some classes better than others. But rarely was the difference the subject of the class. Almost every time, what determined whether I looked forward to a class or dreaded it was the teacher. When the teacher connected with us, we connected with the class.

Later in college, we had more control over what courses we selected. Most semesters, my friends and I would gather to talk about what class we would choose, and we always worked our schedules around the professors we enjoyed—and the ones we wanted to avoid. The best teachers brought the best out of me. During those years, I began thinking about how I wanted to be like the teachers I loved, the ones who connected with their students.

Think about the best and worst teachers you've ever had. What made the best teachers great? I bet it was more than how much they knew or cared about their subject. It was how much they cared about you! Think about what made them so special. Learn from what they did and apply it to your communication. Caring connects.

My Dad Taught Me That Putting Others First Was the Key to Success

When I was a freshman at what is now Ohio Christian University, my father, who was then the college president, took me and four of my friends on a trip. The first night at our destination, Dad discussed our two options for activities we could do the next day. After explaining them, he took a vote, and I was outvoted. For the rest of the weekend, I moped and grumbled about how unhappy I was about not getting my way. As a result of my attitude and selfishness, I was miserable and negatively affected the trip for everyone else.

The night we got home, Dad sat me down and we had a long discussion, during which he taught me four truths:

1. It's not about you; it's about others, so get over yourself!
2. Immature people see things only from their own perspective.
3. Mature people see things from the perspective of others.
4. Immature people are seldom successful—and they're never significant.

To underscore this lesson and make sure I understood it, Dad grounded me for a month. And because I was still living at home, he was able to give me a daily assignment. He required me to add value to someone and to give him a report about it every evening at dinner that month. And it worked. For thirty days, I practiced connecting with others and learned why it was so important.

How are you doing in this area? Do you need to get over yourself, as I did? Have you realized that it's all about others? Do you work to see things from others' perspective? And do you work to do that while you're communicating with others?

KEYS TO CONNECTING WITH OTHERS

If you desire to communicate with others, then you must learn to connect. Connecting is job number one whether you're talking with one person, speaking to a group, or communicating to a crowd. You can accomplish that if you keep these five practices in mind:

1. Realize You Are Not the Main Attraction

When it comes to public speaking, my life has been blessed! Over the course of my career, I've had the chance to travel the world and speak to millions of people. I have communicated live to stadiums of seventy-five thousand people. I've been awarded Toastmasters' top award, the Golden Gavel. And I've been inducted into the Hall of Fame for the National Speakers Association. As far as I know, I'm one of only eight people who have experienced both of those honors. I've seen my photo six stories high on the side of a building where I was scheduled to speak. Because of my speaking ability, I was invited to meet with the president of the United States in the Oval Office. And more than a hundred times a year, I get hired to be the keynote speaker at big events. But I know I am not the main attraction, no matter where I go or what I do. The people are! It's about others.

Jerry Seinfeld, one of the top stand-up comics in the world and one of my favorites, understands this. Millions of people watched *Seinfeld* on television. And I don't even know how many people have paid to attend his live shows. Even though he has often been presented as the main attraction, he knows he is not the main attraction. Here's what he says about comedy: "If you are doing it for them, you'll be fine. If you're doing it for you, that could be problematic at a certain point—because they'll know it. They'll feel it. And they won't like it."⁷² In other words, it's not about you. It's all about them. Get over yourself! As I say in the Big Picture Principle in my book *Winning with People*, the entire population of the world, with one minor exception, is composed of others.

As you know, I am a person of faith. I started out as a pastor who preached every Sunday. I consider my messages to be important. But no matter how important my message or your message might be, we need to maintain perspective about ourselves. To help you understand what I mean, I'll share one of my favorite illustrations I used in a sermon:

It was the first Palm Sunday. Here came Jesus, riding into Jerusalem on an ass. Great crowds began to shout, "Hosanna! Hosanna!" Some threw down their coats on the road. Others spread out palm branches.

The ass perked up his ears. "Well," he said, switching a fly off a mangy patch. "I had no idea they thought so well of me!"⁷³

Where am I going with this? Anytime someone comes up to me after I've spoken and says, "Wow! That was terrific!" they are not actually saying "hosanna" to me. I need to remind myself I'm just the ass who carried Jesus!

No matter how good you are or how important your message is, you must remind yourself that you're not the main attraction. That understanding opens the door to connecting with people. You're not there to impress them or to raise yourself up, increasing the distance between you and them. Your goal should be to close the distance.

2. Make Your First Impression Your Best Impression

Psychologists say that people take about seven seconds to size up others and decide whether they like them.⁷⁴ This occurs not only when people meet you one-on-one but also when you step forward to speak. Think of it as the seven-second test. Those first few seconds are crucial because once someone mentally labels you as likable or unlikable, everything else you do will be viewed through that filter. When people like you, they will look for the best in you. When they don't, the opposite is true.

When I'm interacting with people one-on-one, I try to practice the thirty-second rule, which I wrote about in my book *25 Ways to Win with People*. Within thirty seconds of a conversation, I try to say something encouraging to the person I'm interacting with. When my daughter Elizabeth was a

youngster, she once told me, “Dad, I love the way you look people in the eye and say something positive about them when you meet them.” That made my heart smile.

Most people are focused on themselves when they first meet others. They worry about how they look or how the other person perceives them. Ironically, that’s the exact opposite of what you should do. Instead, you should focus on them. No wonder actress Lisa Kirk said, “A gossip is one who talks to you about others; a bore is one who talks to you about himself; and a brilliant conversationalist is one who talks to you about yourself!”⁷⁵

A few years ago, I was invited to speak to a large crowd of businesspeople in Moldova. Before that event, I got to meet with the one hundred leaders who had been responsible for setting up the event and bringing in the attendees. As we gathered in a nearby room, knowing we had less than a half hour before the event began, they asked me to speak to them. My greatest desire was to thank them, but as I looked at their faces and saw them leaning in, I sensed there was a better way to do that than talking for twenty-five minutes.

“Thank you for making this event possible,” I said. “I’ve been asked to speak to you, but is it OK if I talk for just five minutes? Because what I really want is to be able take a picture with each one of you.” They leaped to their feet and applauded. In that moment, I wanted them to know that *I knew* I was not the main attraction. They were! That made a great first impression, and we connected.

3. Be Intentional in Seeking to Understand Their World

When you speak and you’re failing to connect with people, you can see in their faces they are thinking, *So what?* But when you are connecting well, you can see they are thinking, *Me too!* How do you inspire that? By working to see from their perspective and trying to understand their world.

When my friend Jim Rohn talked about leadership, he often said, “Start with where people are before you take them where they want to go.” When it comes to speaking, I believe you have to find people before you can connect with them. Being intentional about “finding” people means seeking to understand their world so that you can find common ground with them. And then going to where they are makes it possible for you to connect.

In *Winning with People*, I wrote about the Exchange Principle, which says instead of putting others in their place, we must put ourselves in their place. This is an essential concept for connecting, whether with an individual or a group. I do this in several ways before I speak. I try to find out as much as I can about my audience, and I try to put myself in their place mentally and emotionally. I try to anticipate what their hopes and dreams are so I can speak directly to them. I also put myself in their place physically. If I can, I’ll go out into the room before the audience comes in, and I’ll sit in a seat one of them will soon occupy. I look up at the stage and remind myself that people may be looking at me, but it’s not about me. It’s all about them. If I can, my preference is to sit with them and go up on stage from the audience, not from backstage. If I feel emotionally connected to them, I am ready to speak.

In 2019, I received the news that I would be receiving the Horatio Alger Award and be inducted as a member of the Horatio Alger Association. I was familiar with Alger, the author, because my father introduced me to his books when I was a kid. I loved the rags-to-riches stories of entrepreneurialism his heroes embodied. But I was even more excited to be connected to the Horatio Alger Association. A nonprofit organization, it was founded in 1947 to recognize achievement and help promising young people in difficult circumstances. Since 1984, the association has awarded more than \$245 million in need-based college scholarships to more than thirty-five thousand students.⁷⁶

The night of the award ceremony, the other eleven recipients and I were each expected to deliver a short thank-you speech to the members of the association and their guests. Everything about the event was formal, from our dress to the location—the United States Supreme Court—to the program. Even our thank-you speeches had been scripted and rehearsed. But as I listened to the other speeches from the green room, my thoughts were focused on the young people who would be receiving that year’s scholarships. All of them had come from difficult situations and faced tremendous odds, yet they had worked hard, succeeded in school, and were receiving scholarships to universities so they could pursue their dreams.

By the time it was my turn to speak and I stepped onto the stage, I had decided that I wasn’t going to give the speech I’d rehearsed. Instead, I looked up at those high school kids who were seated in the balcony. I took a moment to thank the association for the reward, but then I said, “Tonight is really all about the students, and if you’ll allow me, I’d like to take a few minutes to talk just to them.”

For the next ten minutes, I addressed those kids. I told them how proud I was of them and how much I believed in them. I praised them for the way they overcame the obstacles in their lives and excelled in school. I told them I knew they had a head start on success because they had already learned that life was not easy, and they had achieved so much despite it. And I encouraged them to live their best life. When I was done, I applauded them. In response, every person in the audience got up from their seat, turned around to see those smiling kids in the balcony, and gave them a five-minute standing ovation. It was beautiful.

When the audience turned back, I was already gone. I used the moment to slip off stage. At first, everyone looked surprised. But then they got it. The night was about the kids, and they applauded again.

When all the speeches were done and the ceremony was over, I made my way up into the balcony and spent time with those students. We all laughed and smiled and took pictures together. It’s a night I’ll never forget.

The word *communication* itself hints at the importance of finding common ground when speaking to others. *Communicate* comes from the Latin word *communicatus*, meaning “to impart, share” or literally “to make common.”⁷⁷ To connect, we need to establish commonality. The greater the commonality, the greater the potential for effective communication.

4. Be Personable

The first three practices for connecting with people will help you take the attention off yourself and put it on others, where it belongs. When you realize you’re not the main attraction, focus on others to make a good impression, and work to understand people, you lay the groundwork for connection. The next two practices will help you focus on things you can do to *improve yourself* for the sake of others.

Start by doing whatever you can to make yourself accessible to people emotionally, intellectually, and physically. Communication is about removing barriers. For example, when I’m on stage speaking, I sit on a stool and put my notes on a high-top table or music stand. I make myself comfortable so people feel at ease and secure as they listen to me. I know who I am, and I’m okay with it. Being at ease with yourself helps others be at ease with you, which I call the Approachability Principle in *Winning with People*. If you are uncomfortable as you speak, the audience feels it, and they become distracted by it and miss your message. If you’re ever nervous when you speak, don’t announce it. Once you do, your audience feels obligated to worry about you. Presenters who cause worry don’t inspire great confidence. To be personable, you need to learn to be comfortable with who you are.

When I speak and say, “My name is John, and I’m your friend,” I’m letting everyone know that my talk will be conversational. Often, I’ll take it one step further and say, “On the count of three, give me your name.” The entire audience yells out their names at once and I reply, “Nice to meet you.” What am I doing? I’m trying to be personable to remove barriers. I want them to think of me as a friend, not “the speaker.” As they listen, I want them to feel that I am talking *to* them and *with* them, not *at* them.

I also work to make my words inclusive and inviting. I use *we*, *us*, and *our*. I never use technical jargon or business buzzwords or any language that would indicate that we’re not on the same level and in this talk together. I am intentionally open and authentic.

Sometimes being personable and authentic can take a funny turn. A few years ago, when I was speaking in Baltimore, I was walking around the stage and decided to sit down on a railing at the side of the stage while I talked to the crowd. As I spoke, I slid a couple of inches and felt my slacks rip. I stood up and surreptitiously checked with my hand and discovered a six-inch tear!

“Oops!” I said out loud as I quickly sat back down on the rail. “I have just ripped my slacks,” I told my audience, “and I need a new pair. Who can help me? My waist is forty inches and my inseam is thirty-one. The color is blue. If someone will go buy me some, I’ll pay for them, and I’ll give you a bunch of my books.”

A lady in the crowd stood up and shouted, “I’ll do that,” and off she went to the applause of the audience. I then stood up and continued my teaching, moving around on the stage sideways so that my back never turned to the audience. With every exaggerated movement I made, they howled with delight. That personable posture helped us connect even more.

5. Develop Charisma

The final action you can take to connect with people is to develop charisma. You may be wondering, *Is that possible?* especially if you feel like you lack it. But here’s some great news: charisma is a choice! The person who helped me understand this was my friend Dan Reiland. I thought charisma was a personality trait everyone was born either with or without. Dan helped me understand that charisma is present in people who focus on others first. That’s when I began teaching the Charisma Principle: people are interested in the person who is interested in them.

You can develop charisma when you focus on others by being present, projecting confidence, and creating warmth.

Charismatic Communicators Are Fully Present

When you walk into a room and greet others, which phrase best expresses your thinking: “Here I am” or “There you are”? People who give others 100 percent of their attention radiate charisma. They make others feel like they are the only other person in the world. They are present. Having interest in others is irresistible.

I mentioned earlier that I got to meet with a US president in the Oval Office. That was Bill Clinton. As much as anyone I ever talked with, he was entirely present while we were talking. He continually made eye contact, even when he lifted a glass to take a drink of water. As we chatted, twice a member of the Secret Service entered the office to remind him that it was time to leave for Camp David. After a second interruption, he took me into a side room so that we were able to talk another thirty minutes undisturbed. Here was the president of the United States making *me* feel important.

When I’m talking one-on-one with someone, I work to *be there and be aware*. I look for ways to intentionally add value to the person I’m with. When I’m with them, I’m theirs. I never pick up my

phone while we're talking, unless it's to take notes, and if I do, I tell them that I am taking notes, not reading or sending a text.

When I'm speaking to an audience, I show that I am entirely present in a different way: I focus on what I call my 4 Fs of speaking awareness: Feel, Felt, Found, Find.

1. I try to sense what my audience *feels* and acknowledge and validate their feelings.
2. I share with them how I have also *felt* the same way.
3. I share with them what I've *found* that has helped me.
4. I offer to help them *find* help for their lives.

This is really an expression of understanding their world and then offering to add value to them where they are. Think of it as practical charisma.

Charismatic Communicators Project Confidence

Abolitionist preacher Henry Ward Beecher said, "Did you never see a person whose coming into a room was like the bringing of a lamp there?... Their lives are so radiant, so genial, so kind, so pleasure-bearing, that you instinctively feel, in their presence, that they do you good."⁷⁸ I believe what Beecher was describing is charismatic confidence. That kind of confidence is contagious.

For communicators, where does that confidence come from? It comes from feeling confident about their message and from being confident that the time together with their audience will have a positive impact on their lives. Confidence comes as a result of

- Believing the best about people,
- Knowing that the content of your message has helped you,
- Knowing that it will help them, and
- Believing that their response will be positive.

When you possess confidence in those areas, it's easier to connect—and it's easier to deliver. If you remember that you're not building a case for your subject matter but rather building a relationship so that you can help people, you can make a difference.

Several times a year, the Maxwell Leadership organization hosts a training event called the International Maxwell Conference (IMC) to certify new coaches and speakers. At every IMC I get to speak for ninety minutes about the DNA I want our leaders to possess. I let everyone know:

We Are People of Value
Who Value People
And Add Value to People

I communicate to every speaker and coach that I want them to possess these values. But I also instill confidence in them so they can be effective. Why?

To be people of value, we must have confidence in ourselves.
To value people, we must have confidence in others.
To add value to people, we must have confidence in service.

If you possess confidence in yourself and others, and that confidence is focused on adding value to people, you will be attractive to others.

Charismatic Communicators Create a Feeling of Warmth

People know when you like them, and they like being liked. It makes them feel warm and comfortable in your presence. They feel accepted, valued, noticed, important—special. Warmth creates connection. It creates an environment where people sense good things can happen.

If you focus on others and adding value to them, while being confident in yourself and your ability to help them, you will be able to connect. You don't have to be perfect to communicate. In fact, trying to be too perfect and polished can actually work against you. There's something endearing about presenters and presentations that are not perfect. When the speaker is comfortable with his or her imperfections, people are drawn into the experience. So embrace your humanness.

If you're an NFL fan, think of John Madden. He is a great example of a connecting communicator. He often looked disheveled. He was a mountain of a man, but, as analyst Christine Brennan said, he was kind, gentle, smart, and “a lovely human being.”⁷⁹ His language was sometimes quirky. He sometimes sounded more like a fan than a professional commentator. He wasn't perfect, and he laughed at himself. But he loved football, football players, and football fans. People could sense that, they related to him, and they loved him. Because he knew it wasn't about him, he connected.

If you want to become a great communicator, you need to focus on the people in your audience and give them your best every time you deliver a message. And never forget: communicators know it's all about others. That's the Law of Connecting.

THE LAW OF LEVERAGE

Good Communicators Lead with Their Strengths and Use Them Often

ONE OF MY JOYS IN life is mentoring leaders and communicators. That's something I've done for more than a quarter century, and I've had the privilege of helping some fantastic people navigate the journey of improvement in speaking and leadership. One of the people I started mentoring in the late nineties is Kevin Myers, the founder of 12Stone Church. I first met Kevin when he was a kid just starting out in his career, but by the time I started mentoring him, he was in his midthirties and was already a terrific communicator.

One of the teachings Kevin developed during that time was called "Home Run Life." In it, he used the running of the bases in a baseball game as a metaphor for living a successful life. It was a wonderful message that had the potential to help a lot of people, so I invited him to be a speaker for two events my company was hosting. First, I wanted him to deliver the message at a leadership conference in El Paso, Texas. And then I wanted him to be one of the main speakers at a conference we had recently started called Catalyst, which later grew into one of our largest events with over twelve thousand people in attendance. But Kevin's experience turned out to be very different from what he and I expected. And it gave birth to the Law of Leverage.

ANYONE CAN HAVE AN "EL PASO" MOMENT

For you to fully appreciate Kevin's experience and the power of the Law of Leverage, you need to hear his story directly, so I've asked Kevin to tell it himself:

It was a huge deal, being asked by John to speak. I was turning forty, John was mentoring me, and life was good. John's invitation to speak alongside him at his leadership conference in El Paso and at Catalyst made life even better. I was humbled, honored, blown away, and fired up. To me, this was like being called up to the majors from the minor league. Deep down, I knew the first win would be for the team, but I also believed this would be career defining. I had been speaking professionally every week for eighteen years, but I knew it would be the most important communication I had ever delivered in my career.

The day of the conference came, and I flew into El Paso with John and the team. I was scheduled to be the second or third speaker, and I was excited. When John introduced me with

his usual kind affirmation, I stepped up to the metaphorical plate to deliver my talk.

Even though I had delivered this message before, I prepared thoroughly. I planned to capture my audience with humor: five minutes inspired by a routine of comedian Brian Regan about being lousy in little league. That would be followed by a smart transition into the idea that everyone wants a home run kind of life. Then I'd hit them with my life-changing content. I knew this was going to be amazing.

Only it wasn't.

Five minutes into my talk, the only sound in the room was crickets. I was not only failing to connect, but the entire experience was dead—for my audience *and* for me.

I began to lose my way. I tried another approach, but it was another “swing and a miss.” I began to panic. I started sweating. I must have looked like an MMA fighter who was taking a beating in the octagon. I felt like I was being swept into a black hole in space.

At this point in my career, while delivering thousands of messages, I had never once lost my way on stage. I mean *never*. It was so disorienting that I stopped the communication.

“I’m sorry,” I told the audience, and especially John, “but this is not working. It’s being recorded and I’m failing to be helpful to you. Would you let me have a do-over? Let’s restart the cameras, and let me just give you the core of the material.” I kid you not, it was that bad.

So I decided to just wing it. I’d been speaking for nearly two decades. I’d been successful on a debate team. I’d acted on stage in high school. I had great instincts, so I’d deliver it on the fly.

Only it didn’t fly. I crashed and burned for the next thirty minutes. When I finally finished, I walked off stage to pity applause.

It was the single worst communication experience of my life, and for the first time, I understood why public speaking was often cited as people’s number one fear. Even as I write this, I cringe. I feel nausea, the panic returns, and I start to sweat. I’d failed John. I’d failed to help my audience. And I’d fumbled a great opportunity. It totally unraveled my confidence.

On the flight home to Atlanta, John was gracious—and curious.

“Hmmm, Kevin. You’ve never been in a black hole on stage before, have you?” he asked. “You’ve never experienced a complete failure in communication like this?”

I confessed I hadn’t, but I could not even process it, let alone look him or anyone else in the eye while thinking about it. I didn’t know how to go forward. Fortunately, John started teaching me what he now calls the Law of Leverage: good communicators lead with their strengths and use them often. Since we met regularly, he fleshed it out for me. I started using it every week in my speaking, and I could see its impact immediately. But he and I both had in the back of our minds that Catalyst was coming up soon, and that was going to be a bigger stage with a bigger audience than El Paso.

Over lunch one day, John said, “Kevin, I don’t know what to do about you speaking at Catalyst. While you’re a gifted communicator and the concepts are strong, we cannot afford an El Paso.” John’s team didn’t want to risk a repeat failure on my part. Neither did John. Neither did I!

“Well, John,” I responded, “I’ve had some time to process that, and I’ve had some time to apply the Law of Leverage. On one hand, I hope you take me off the list of speakers. That relieves the pressure on me. On the other hand, I hope you keep me on it because I think I can get a double, triple, or, who knows, maybe even a miracle home run. But it’s obviously your call. And I’m content either way.”

I can't tell you why John decided to let me speak again at something as important as Catalyst. It was a huge risk. Looking back, if I were John, I would've said no. However, he gave the green light.

Everyone Can Have “Catalyst” Moments

The day of Catalyst, I was introduced and stepped in front of thousands of people in the audience, and I think John and his team held their breath. As I prepared to deliver my message, I tried to keep the thought of El Paso from paralyzing me.

This time, instead of leading with someone else's strength, humor, I led with my own—heart. I talked about my early struggles in leadership, my years of utter defeat, and my desire to quit. I shared how I had decided to shut down my organization and walk away from it. I had even gone back to my old boss in Michigan to ask for my old job. But he told me to return to Atlanta to keep trying. I *knew* that most of the people in the room could relate to my experience. They had been there. Or they were there now. And then I taught the solution, how to live a Home Run Life.

What happened that day is what marathoners call a *runner's high* and pro athletes call *being in the zone*. The connection worked, the room went with me, and my message was a home run! I walked off stage to a standing ovation. That day I experienced the power of the Law of Leverage.

FINDING YOUR VOICE

The Law of Leverage took Kevin's speaking to another level. It teaches speakers to discover their strengths and use them often so they are always *giving* their best *out of* their best. When you find your strengths, you find your voice. From then on, your communication fits who you are. It becomes natural. Novelist Doris Mortman said, “Until you make peace with who you are, you'll never be content with what you have.”⁸⁰ If you want to grow as a communicator, you must learn your natural primary strengths and use them when you speak.

I think we know to focus on using our strengths in other areas of life, yet we often neglect to apply this truth to our communication. That was true for me when I was a young communicator. As I've already explained, I started out imitating other speakers without success. I was looking at communicators and asking myself, “What do they have that I want?” Instead, I should have been looking at my audience and asking, “What do I have that they want?” Only after I stopped emulating others and discovered my own authentic voice did my messages start carrying weight and increasing in influence.

What happens when we don't leverage our strengths for success? We end up trying to improve our weaknesses. But that's ultimately a lost cause. A fable written in 1940 by George H. Reavis, who was at that time the superintendent of public schools in Cincinnati, Ohio, illustrates this fantastically. He called it “The Animal School”:

Once upon a time...

The animals decided they must do something heroic to meet the problems of a “new world.” So they organized a school. They adopted an activity curriculum consisting of running, climbing, swimming, and flying. To make it easier to administer the curriculum, all the animals

took all the subjects. The duck was excellent in swimming—in fact, better than his instructor. But he made only passing grades in flying and was very poor in running.

Since he was slow in running, he had to stay after school and also drop swimming in order to practice running. This was kept up until his webbed feet were badly worn and he was only average in swimming. But average was acceptable in school, so nobody worried about that except the duck.

The rabbit started at the top of the class in running but had a nervous breakdown because of so much make-up work in swimming.

The squirrel was excellent in climbing until he developed frustration in the flying class, where his teacher made him start from the ground up instead of the treetop down.

He also developed a charley horse from overexertion and then got a C in climbing and a D in running.

The eagle was a problem child and was disciplined severely. In the climbing class he beat all the others to the top of the tree but insisted on using his own way to get there.^{[81](#)}

Reavis ends the story by telling how an average eel became the star of the school because he did nothing as poorly as the animals working in their weaknesses.

In the real world, we know that people don't desire average. Nobody is looking to hire a mediocre speaker or is excited about following an uninspiring leader. Nobody wants to be taught by someone who is merely adequate. People want to be engaged, inspired, instructed, and entertained! To become the best version of yourself as a communicator, you must start with your strengths, use your talent, and add skills, knowledge, and practice to the mix. Those factors will become multipliers to your communication.

USING YOUR STRENGTHS TO COMMUNICATE

How can you use your strengths to make yourself a better communicator? First, you need to know what they are. If you're a self-aware person, you have a head start. If you're not sure, I suggest you begin by examining your ability in three areas.

1. Leverage the Strength That Best Helps You Connect

The best place to start leveraging your strengths—and this is where I started with Kevin—is to consider the four primary connection points of communication: heart, help, humor, and hope. In El Paso, Kevin tried to connect with humor. Does Kevin have a good sense of humor? Yes. Does he use it when he speaks? Yes. Does he do it successfully? Again, yes. Is it his lead strength to connect? No. Heart is. Kevin is at his absolute best when he shares his heart. My advice is that you *lead* with your best connecting strength 99 percent of the time and return to it often when you speak.

Heart

What is heart? It's an emotional connection. Heartfelt communication is authentic and personal. It's vulnerable and open. It comes from your heart and appeals to the hearts of others. It also comes from a place of empathy, not manipulation. If you try to play on people's emotions in an inauthentic way, it won't work. People will see through it. But if you are your genuine self without pretense or posturing, it draws people to you and creates a bond with them, a bond of trust. Heart encourages others.

After Kevin and I discussed his El Paso experience, he realized that heart was his best way of connecting. So he changed his opening and his emphasis in his talk at Catalyst. He was open about his past brokenness, the failure of his leadership, his near financial bankruptcy, and his strained marriage. He was honest about how he had been striking out in life. Did he still use humor? Absolutely. His audience needed moments of laughter to relieve the emotional tension. Did he help them? Yes. That was the bulk of his message. Did he inspire hope? Yes! When he was finished, they believed if they applied what he taught, they could have a home run life too. But he led with heart and returned to it often in his talk.

Help

Help is adding value to people by giving them practical tools that can improve their lives. It means equipping people to change what they see, how they think, and what they do. It's giving people concrete "handles," especially when you are presenting intangible ideas. When you give your audience help, they are grateful because they walk away knowing how to change, grow, and improve. Help is instructive.

Most of my outlines are filled with practical help. This comes out of my desire to be a motivational *teacher*, not a motivational *speaker*. Many years ago, I read that most people walk out of a seminar or conference excited, but they don't remember what they learned or how to apply it. When I looked at my own communication, I realized I focused too much on inspiration and motivation. That's when I began adding more practical application to everything I taught, turning my *desire* to help others into *ways* to help others.

Humor

Of the four connection strengths, humor is perhaps the most difficult—unless you are naturally funny. Humor is seeing the funny or absurd side of life. It's using an unexpected twist to make people laugh. When you can make an audience laugh, it knits them to you. When humor is your strength, you can use it to bypass the front door and reach people through the back door. Humor is entertaining.

My friend Steve Harvey tells communicators not to try to use humor if you're not naturally funny. I think that's good advice. What I think he's really saying is if humor isn't your strength, never try to open a talk with a joke or try to force laughter. But even if you don't have Steve's gift, you can still include elements of humor in your speaking. Some communicators tell jokes. Others banter with their audience. Some are great at one-liners. Others use slides with funny pictures or cartoons. There are many roads to humor.

I can be pretty quick with a line that makes people laugh, especially if it's self-deprecating. But my two main sources of humor are telling funny stories I've collected and using facial expressions or body language to get a laugh. As you work humor into your communication, experiment to see what works for you.

Hope

The fourth way to connect with people is by giving them hope. It's breathing life into people, helping them see that today can be better, the future can be better, *they* can be better. It's showing people their possibilities, inspiring them to believe those possibilities, and assisting them in reaching for them.

I feel very comfortable using all four of these methods for connecting, but I believe hope may be my greatest strength. I see great possibilities in people and for people. I believe they can have a better

life, and I am convinced that what I share with them can help them get there. My hope for people is great, and I want to share it with them, so everything I teach is filled with hope.

Which of the four is your best connecting strength? Perhaps as you read about them, you knew. If not, how do you discover it? Ask yourself these questions:

- Which one of the four comes most easily to me?
- Which one of the four creates the most traction when I communicate?
- Which of the four do people most affirm after I speak?
- Which of the four am I using when I experience “magic moments” on stage?

If you’re still not sure, record your presentations and watch or listen to them. Or ask friends to give you feedback after you speak by asking them, “What parts of the talk drew you in the most? What part do you remember most? What part did you enjoy the most?” These are all clues to your connecting strength. Once you know what it is, lead with it and return to it often to make sure you’re leveraging it.

2. Leverage the Natural Talents That Help You Succeed

While your motivational strength for connecting is a huge part of improving your communication, it’s not the only part. You need to use as many of your other natural talents as you can to become a better speaker.

In *StrengthsFinder 2.0*, Tom Rath explains that every human being has talents that are just waiting to be uncovered. If we use these strengths, we can be successful. As he points out, “You **cannot** be anything you want to be—but you **can** be a lot more of who you already are.”⁸² His formula for success is this:

Talent (a natural way of thinking, feeling, or behaving)

×

Investment (time spent practicing, developing your skills, and building your knowledge base)

=

Strength (the ability to consistently provide near-perfect performance)⁸³

StrengthsFinder helped me better understand my specific talents, and I use them intentionally every time I speak. My top five strengths are strategic, maximizer, woo, activator, and achiever. How do I use these strengths when I speak?

Strategic

The Big Message that I wrote about in the Law of Preparation (chapter 4) demonstrates my strength in strategizing. As a reminder, here are the components of my Big Message. Every time I speak, I think of my audience and ask,

- What Do I Want Them to See? Their Possibilities
- What Do I Want Them to Know? Their Value
- What Do I Want Them to Feel? Empowered
- What Do I Want Them to Do? Apply and Multiply

I bring my strategic talent into the way I construct a message and how I want my audience to respond to it.

Maximizer

Maximizers always want to do their best, and they want to help others to be their best. This is a very high motivation for my speaking. I want to encourage people to aspire to success, and I want to show them the best ways to become successful.

Woo

People with *woo* have a natural ability to win others over. While anyone can find a way to connect with others, someone with *woo* can do it more quickly and easily. I leverage that every time I speak. The more quickly I can connect, the sooner I can help people.

Activator

Activators have a bias toward action. They like to get things done, and they help others get things done. And of course, without action, people go nowhere. Since activation is a talent, I always finish my speaking by prompting people to act. I encourage them to apply and multiply: apply what they just learned and multiply their effort by helping others do the same.

Achiever

Achievers don't need motivation from others to get going. They are naturally motivated, and they love accomplishment. As an achiever, I start every day asking myself, *What will I accomplish today?* and end it asking, *What did I accomplish today?* This attitude drives me to achieve positive results every time I speak. It's what compelled me to write this book.

What natural talents do you possess that can help you become a better speaker? Every strength can become a communication asset if you harness it for the benefit of your audience. If you don't know yourself, study yourself. Read *StrengthsFinder 2.0* and take the assessment. Or use the Right Path assessment. Or study the Enneagram. Anything that helps you understand yourself better can be helpful. Then, figure out how to leverage your talents when you speak.

3. Leverage Your Skills That Can Help Others Succeed

In the Law of Anticipation (chapter 9), you will read about how I discovered CLEAR—Communication, Leadership, Equipping, Attitude, and Relationships. I believe these five areas are my most highly developed skills. Just about everything I speak on falls into one of those categories.

What are yours? What are the areas in your life where you have developed knowledge, experience, skill, and success? If you are early in your career, you may not yet know what they are. If you're experienced, you should know. Tap into these areas of expertise every time you speak because each provides you with something you can give others to help them succeed. Take an inventory and start drawing from them.

Now that you understand the Law of Leverage, you'll see that good communicators lead with their strengths and use them often. Someone like my friend Steve Harvey obviously uses humor when he speaks because it is a strength. But beyond that, he also possesses extraordinary emotional

intelligence. He is intuitive, and he uses that talent to connect with people. He usually gets a laugh, but he often shares his wisdom to teach.

I think about someone like Don Yaeger, a *Sports Illustrated* writer and editor turned speaker. Don is one of the best storytellers I know. Yes, he knows sports and uses this knowledge in his speeches, but he always connects using heart. When he speaks, you know he's going to make you laugh and very likely make you cry.

Former president Barack Obama used hope as his greatest connection tool. He always led with it and returned to it often. *Hope* was even a major theme of his campaign and appeared on posters with his image. He inspired people to believe the country and the world could be a better place, and they voted for him as a result.

And a world changer like Mahatma Gandhi used help in his communication. He leveraged his understanding of people, training as a lawyer, work with the poor, and knowledge of the British Empire to win independence for the people of India.

Any strength you possess can be leveraged for better communication, and it should be—as long as you wield it to benefit your audience members, not to manipulate them for your own benefit. As you think about your own strengths, my hope is that you discover them and lean on them. Become a good communicator. Lead with your strengths and use them often. That's the Law of Leverage.

THE LAW OF ANTICIPATION

When You Can't Wait to Say It, They Can't Wait to Hear It

WHEN WAS THE LAST TIME you were excited to hear a speaker who wasn't excited about his message? Can you remember? I bet you can't. Because it has probably never happened! Why? If the speaker doesn't have any enthusiasm about his subject, neither does his audience. And the opposite is also true: if the speaker possesses great enthusiasm, so will his audience. That's why I say, when you can't wait to say it, they can't wait to hear it. That's the Law of Anticipation.

I CAN'T WAIT!

Anticipation is one of my favorite words, probably because it's been a constant in my life. When I was a kid, I always woke up early and got out of bed immediately because I was afraid I'd miss something if I slept longer. My sense of anticipation was always off the charts. It still is. I love experiencing the excitement of believing something wonderful is about to happen, and I love to create that sense of anticipation in others.

Think about the times in your life when you've experienced positive anticipation. Maybe it was a special birthday. Or a first date. Or a dream vacation. Or Christmas. I know when I was a child, as soon as I finished Thanksgiving dinner, I started counting down the days before Santa would arrive at our house. That sense of anticipation was the secret sauce of Christmas. Anticipation is also the secret sauce of communication.

Before you get up and start speaking, members of your audience possess a mindset. They have expectations based on their personal history, their attitude toward the subject, their reasons for attending, their knowledge of you, and their circumstances leading up to that moment. They might be feeling any number of emotions:

- Dread: negative expectations about you or your message
- Indifference: neutral expectations toward you or your message
- Curiosity: tentative expectations about you or your message
- Anticipation: positive expectations about you or your message

As speakers, we'd love for everyone to feel high anticipation before we speak, but that's not realistic. So our job as we speak is to do what we can to create a sense of anticipation and then to

deliver the goods. If we succeed, and if we work to maintain that sense of anticipation, we can keep people sitting on the edge of their seats and take them with us on every step of the journey.

Of course, sometimes that doesn't happen.

One of my biggest speaking disasters occurred several years ago when I was asked to substitute for another speaker. I was home working one morning when I got an urgent call from the organizers of a big one-day event saying Christopher Reeve, who was scheduled to be their final keynote speaker, was sick. They wanted to know if I would jump on a plane to Boston and speak in his place that afternoon. It was an unusual request, but the organizer was a friend of mine, and I wanted to help him, so I agreed. This was before 9/11, so it was easier to hop on a plane on short notice.

As you can imagine, there was a mad rush to book tickets, get dressed, pack a bag, and decide what I would speak about. Fortunately, I made it in time. The last of all the other speakers for the day was just completing his speech as my ride from the airport screeched to a halt behind the arena. Someone rushed me backstage so that they could quickly get my mic installed. As I stood in the wings, I watched the host step out on the stage for my introduction. The first words out of his mouth were that Christopher Reeve was ill and would not be speaking. It struck me that the audience hadn't known Reeve wasn't showing up until *that instant*. They were on the edge of their seats expecting to see Superman. Instead, they would be seeing me—not a tall, dark, and handsome movie star who'd lived an inspirational life after a tragic accident, but a middle-aged, overweight speaker many had never heard of.

I walked onto the stage, and I could see the disappointment in everyone's faces as a few people offered polite, feeble applause. A large number got up from their seats, turned their backs to me, and walked out. Thinking back on it today, I am reminded of a story I'd once heard about the actress Helen Hayes. When she cooked her first turkey on Thanksgiving, she told her husband and son, "This is the first turkey I've ever cooked. If it isn't any good, I don't want anybody to say a word. We'll just get up from the table, without a comment, and go out to a restaurant to eat." When she returned from the kitchen with the turkey, her husband and son were seated at the table with their hats and coats on.

That was my starting position as their speaker! I worked as hard as I could to win that audience over, but it's an understatement to say that I had to start from a great deficit of anticipation. My greatest victory was that more people didn't leave as I spoke.

BUILDING ANTICIPATION

Because I love a sense of anticipation and recognize how beneficial it can be in communication, early in my career I started looking for ways to build excitement, and then not only to meet people's expectations when I spoke but to exceed them. I tried using several different communication techniques, some of which worked. I'll share those with you later in the chapter. But what I discovered is that building anticipation in an audience came primarily from my own mindset. If I wanted people to be excited, *I* had to be excited. I had to have a posture of continual improvement, where every day I had a passion to learn more, possessed the work ethic to become more, and was excited to share more with others. These things would keep my level of expectation high every time I spoke, and that sense of expectation would be *caught* by my audience.

My advice to you as a communicator is to adopt a growth mindset. Never stop growing and never try to position yourself as "the expert." Keep moving your expectations for yourself higher. As you rise in both your sense of anticipation and your skill, your audience's response will rise with you. Over time as you communicate, your audience's sense of anticipation will increase. When you

become good, people's anticipation will be good. When you become incredible, their anticipation will be even higher because they will expect to hear from someone incredible.

PERSPECTIVE: HOW WE VIEW THINGS IS HOW WE DO THINGS

To help you change your sense of anticipation, you need to change your perspective. We can become only what we see ourselves becoming. As you read the three perspectives on communication below, think about how you see yourself. Work to embrace and adopt each because when we change the way we look at things, the things we look at change.

1. Personal Perspective: Believe You Can Communicate

Your first and most important audience is yourself. Your most important tools of communication are the words you say *to* yourself, *about* yourself, when you are *by* yourself. What do you tell yourself? If you say, *I don't think I can communicate*, and then you step in front of an audience, people will feel your strong sense of doubt. Instead of thinking, *This is going to be great!* they will be thinking, *I hope this isn't too painful* or *How long will this take?*

Where does a sense of doubt come from? Thinking *I don't think I can* comes from believing *I don't think I am*. There is a definite connection between self-esteem and performance. You must believe in yourself and your ability to communicate effectively. As psychologist William James put it, "The one thing that will guarantee the successful conclusion of a doubtful undertaking is faith in the beginning that you can do it."⁸⁴

What do you tell yourself about yourself and your ability to speak? I repeatedly tell myself, *I am a person of value who values people and adds value to them*. Some people would call this a *mantra*. I call it a daily self-worth statement. It describes the way I think of myself and my intentions. I try to live that statement every day. You need to find and repeat that kind of statement to yourself.

One of the challenges of being a new speaker is not having much experience to draw upon. If you lack confidence because you haven't spoken much or if the idea of speaking frightens you, Susan Cain, the author of *Quiet: The Power of Introverts in a World That Can't Stop Talking*, gives advice that can help:

Psychologists have studied for years the process of extinguishing fears. They know exactly how to do it. It takes grit and energy; it can be a painful process; but it's not magic. The correct approach is to expose yourself to that which you fear in small, manageable doses.... From there, people work up to more challenging situations. The idea is to build on small, dependable successes that train the brain that the source of its fear is more benign than it had thought. Stressed-out public speakers see the podium as the equivalent of crossing a narrow bridge above a deep ravine. Once the brain learns that nothing calamitous happens at the mic, it stops signaling to the body to take flight.⁸⁵

Confidence is a big part of anticipation. Small wins like Cain describes can increase confidence and decrease fear. Gain those wins by seeking out small communication successes.

2. Speech Perspective: Believe You Have Something to Give

One of my personality quirks is that I'm highly optimistic and tend to see the best in everything. The negative side of this is that it creates blind spots, especially in the way I see people. But the positive

side is that I get excited about the things I love to do. For years, friends and colleagues in my inner circle have made fun of me when I tell them the message or book I'm currently working on is "the best I've ever written."

"Really?" they'll say. "Out of over one hundred books, this is your best book?" My answer is always yes. Because I'm constantly growing and learning, I believe I have something more, something better to give. And every time I write, I give it my all. So of course, I think it's the best I've ever done. The same is true for my communication.

When I first started speaking, I believed everything I was writing and presenting was the best I'd ever done. That was the good news. The bad news was that it still wasn't very good. I lacked skill and confidence and didn't have positive anticipation about myself, my speech, or my audience. My idealized hopes contrasted with the reality of what I could deliver. But slowly and with practice, I improved. As I got better, my anticipation grew, and the audience's confidence also grew because my skill had increased.

One of the things that helped me greatly was figuring out what I most wanted to teach. I wanted to help people become successful, and over the course of several years, I concluded they needed to learn in five specific areas. I mentioned this in the Law of Leverage (chapter 8), and I want to explain it now.

My first discovery was about the value of *attitude*. I learned this from my parents, who emphasized it with me and my siblings every day. I also realized the importance of *relationships* early in my life. I experienced my father and mother's love, and I watched them value people in a way that nurtured relationships.

A few years into my career, I became aware of the importance of *leadership* to success. I discovered that everything rises and falls on leadership. I worked to improve my own leadership, and it wasn't long before I started teaching others how to lead. That's when I recognized the power of *equipping*. When I started equipping others to lead, my leadership, effectiveness, and success went to a whole new level. The final piece of the puzzle was something I had been working on from the beginning of my career: *communication*. What started as a necessity of my profession became my greatest skill and something I could help others improve.

When I realized the initial letters of those five words could spell *clear*, I began using that acronym to represent the five categories I most often speak about: Communication, Leadership, Equipping, Attitude, and Relationships. I believe they are what people need to become a CLEAR success. I believe that if people learn and improve in those five areas, they will live more fulfilling lives, be more successful, and be better able to fulfill their purpose, making the world a better place.

What can you teach that you know can help other people? Have you started to figure that out? Charlie Wetzel, my longtime writing partner, has observed that professional communicators have certain key themes they feel called to teach. They return to these three to seven themes over and over again, expressing them in different ways or teaching certain aspects within each theme. My themes are represented by CLEAR. Kevin Myers's themes are connection to God, character, community, and competence. If you examine all of a speaker's messages over the course of a career, you would discover they fit in one of their thematic "buckets." The best communicators are especially skilled at finding creative ways to present these ideas in fresh ways over the years.

Try to discern what your themes are. Once you know them and you write messages based on your convictions, your confidence and sense of anticipation will increase. Your audience will sense your certainty, and they will share your anticipation, because your level of excitement will determine their level of excitement.

3. Audience Perspective: Believe People Can and Want to Improve Their Lives

It's one thing to communicate *to* people because you have something valuable to say. It's another to communicate *with* people because you believe *they* have value. That is the audience perspective you want to possess. There is no audience, however small, that is insignificant—only speakers who think so. I touched on this in the Law of Connecting (chapter 7), and I will explore it in depth in the Law of Adding Value (chapter 15), so I won't say much more here, except to emphasize that our attitude toward people determines how we treat people.

Psychologist and author Travis Bradberry indicates that research bears this out. He writes,

When teachers in the studies were told that certain (randomly selected) children were smart, those kids performed better, not only in the classroom, but also on standardized IQ tests.

Indeed, we get the most out of other people when we believe in them. Research shows that this happens because when we believe in someone:

- We treat them better than people we think will fail.
- We give them more opportunities to succeed than we give those we think will fail.
- We give them more accurate, helpful feedback than we give others, and
- We do more teaching because we believe it's time well spent.^{[86](#)}

When we believe the audience is worthy of our effort and we anticipate they will benefit, they sense it and respond positively. When we don't, they respond poorly. I saw a blatant example of this recently when I traveled to Normandy with friends to visit several World War II battlefields. Our guide in the museum had no sense of audience perspective whatsoever. For sixty minutes, it seemed his entire purpose was to make us feel ignorant and prove how much he knew. At least thirty times, he asked us questions that he knew we could not answer. The group went from excited and ready to learn, to discouraged and disinterested. I *watched* as my friends' heads lowered and their eyes looked away each time the guide got ready to ask them another question.

When the tour was done, I gathered my friends together and used our experience as an opportunity to teach a lesson on communication, asking them to analyze our guide's technique and how it made them react. I concluded by saying, "Never ask the audience a question that they cannot answer and then tell them the answer to make yourself look smart. Anytime you do that, it separates you from the people you're speaking to."

HOW TO CREATE AN ATMOSPHERE OF ANTICIPATION

Once you have the right *mindset* of anticipation, you can employ *practices* that create an atmosphere of anticipation in your audience. Here are four you can begin using immediately.

1. Turn the Faucet On

Louis L'Amour, the highly prolific bestselling author of Western novels, gave this advice to writers: "Start writing, no matter what. The water does not flow until the faucet is turned on."^{[87](#)} That's also true for speakers who want to create anticipation. From the time you receive an invitation, to the time you write your message, to the time you prepare to deliver it, to the moment you step in front of your audience, your sense of anticipation needs to be flowing. And nobody but you can turn it on.

When you are asked to speak, what is your reaction? Excitement? Fear? Nerves? If you can turn on your sense of anticipation, believing that you *can* do a good job and that you *can* help people, it will start you on a great track because anticipation is a key to self-discipline. If you procrastinate, it may be because you do not anticipate that something positive will happen. But if you anticipate that the speech you are going to prepare will make a positive difference for people, you'll hardly be able to wait to get started preparing it.

That's the way I always feel. Every day I spend time preparing messages or writing books. Every day! I am usually up at 5:30 a.m. at my desk working on them. If I'm traveling, I write whenever I can, wherever I am. My anticipation faucet is always in the "on" position. I'm excited to get up and prepare because I believe what I write and say will make a positive difference in people's lives.

When you've turned on the faucet of anticipation, the water of creativity also flows. You get more ideas while you're writing your message. That will make you even more excited about your message. As a result, you will walk on stage excited and the communication will flow. And when people take action in response to your message, possibilities also flow. It all starts when you turn on the faucet. Don't wait for an opportunity to start getting ready. Get ready and then find an opportunity.

2. Set the Table So People Know Good "Food" Is Coming

For the people in your audience, listening to your communication should be like going to a great restaurant. Recently my wife, Margaret, and I had the privilege of dining with friends at one of the best restaurants in the world, Louis XV in Monte Carlo. Our anticipation for this experience was off the charts because the restaurant is run by Alain Ducasse and has received three Michelin stars.

From the moment we entered the dining room, we were enthralled. The tables were set with fine china and adorned with beautiful flowers. A harpist played soft music, setting the atmosphere. The maître d' greeted us and spoke about many fantastic courses we would be enjoying, setting our expectations high. And the large staff was poised to wait on our every need. When the first course arrived, the server explained what we were being served and how the food was prepared. It looked beautiful and tasted delicious. And as much as we enjoyed it, our conversation shifted in anticipation as we wondered what the next course would be. That sense of excitement lasted throughout the entire meal! It was a truly memorable experience.

As a communicator, you are like the chef, the maître d', and the server all wrapped into one. You know the menu and you control the service. You can create the atmosphere for your audience and signal what's coming, which build people's sense of anticipation as they wait for you to serve them their "meal."

There is nothing I enjoy more as a speaker than giving people a glimpse of what's to come throughout my talk and building their excitement for receiving it. I often do this by using phrases like these:

- I woke up this morning filled with anticipation about our time together.
- I am going to share something with you that I have never shared before.
- I've created this lesson just for you. You are the first to ever hear this!
- Look at the person sitting beside you and say to them, "You're going to learn something today."
- What I'm about to share with you has life-changing possibilities.
- My level of expectancy for this lesson is a *ten*. How many are as excited as I am? Look at your neighbor and say, "I'm excited to hear this lesson!"
- In a few minutes, I'm going to give you the "secret sauce" to your success.

- Ask yourself, *What's the best thing that can happen to me during our time together?* Throughout this talk, see if you can find it.

Phrases such as these are fine china, beautiful flowers, and gracious greetings in your audience's experience. They build positive anticipation before you ever serve the courses and feed people. I recommend that you find phrases that fit your personality and style, and then use them to build anticipation in your own way.

3. Be a Fountain, Not a Drain

Recently, people have used a great phrase to describe how to treat others: “Be a fountain, not a drain,” a saying coined by baseball player Rex Hudler.⁸⁸ Those words also express how we should strive to treat others in our communication. My friend Tim Elmore, the founder and CEO of Growing Leaders, writes about how we can be either fountains or drains with the people in our lives:

Fountains and drains have two opposite functions: Fountains overflow with water while drains remove the water completely. In relationships with others, most people are usually a fountain or a drain—they either flow and overflow onto others, or they just drain people of their energy. My guess is that you've probably met both kinds of people: They either refresh the life in others or they dry it up.⁸⁹

As you prepare to speak to people, you need to think of yourself as a fountain. You need to be someone who gives to others. We all know that in relationships, each of us is either a plus or a minus. Being a minus causes people to avoid you. Being a plus draws people to you and creates a sense of anticipation in them. If you thought about it, I bet you could name some of the famous fountains around the world. Here are the ones I think of:

- Trevi Fountain in Rome
- Crown Fountain in Chicago
- Banpo Bridge Rainbow Fountain in Seoul
- Jet d'Eau in Geneva
- Magic Fountain of Montjuïc in Barcelona
- People's Friendship Fountain in Moscow
- King Fahd's Fountain in Jeddah

But I bet you can't name any famous drains, can you? Why? Because there are no famous drains!

To make sure I'm a fountain and not a drain, I monitor my attitude, because I've found that when my attitude turns bad, I become a drain. And there's only one thing more contagious than a good attitude—a bad attitude. If you want to build anticipation in your audience, make sure your attitude is good and you're ready to overflow with positivity.

4. Live on the Other Side of Yes

You already know there is a relationship between what we expect and what we experience. Your expectations, more than anything else in life, determine your reality. If you expect every person, challenge, and opportunity in life to give you a *no*, that's what you will get. If you always expect life's answers to be *yes*, you will get them. And if you can live on the other side of *yes*, you can experience

a life that believes in nearly limitless possibilities. Why do I think this is possible? Because research shows that people who believe in themselves use more of their brains. They have more brainpower to solve problems because they approach them from many different angles and adapt their approaches as needed.^{[90](#)}

I communicate on the other side of *yes* because that is where I live. I grew up reading books such as *The Power of Positive Thinking* by Norman Vincent Peale, *The Magic of Big* by David J. Schwartz, and *Move Ahead with Possibility Thinking* by Robert Schuller. They all influenced me to have abundance thinking, a *yes* mindset. I believe that, yes, all of us can have possibilities, hope, perseverance, answers, options, and successes. And because I believe these things, I can communicate these things. And all of them create positive anticipation.

If it feels like I'm overemphasizing being positive, believing in yourself, and believing in your audience, I'm not. Why do I say that? Because it's *impossible* to overemphasize them. In fact, creating positive anticipation in an audience is almost impossible without them. Philosopher Søren Kierkegaard said, "If I were to wish for anything, I should not wish for wealth and power, but for the passionate sense of the potential, for the eye which, ever young and ardent, sees the possible. Pleasure disappoints. Possibilities never."^{[91](#)}

That is what I wish for you. I wish for you to see possibilities. I wish for you to be excited about speaking to others, for you to be like world-renowned architect Frank Lloyd Wright, who, when asked which of his works he would call his masterpiece, replied, "My next one."^{[92](#)} I would wish that every time you step up to communicate, your sense of anticipation would be so strong that it spreads to your audience, and they enjoy every part of the experience and benefit from it. Why? Because when you can't wait to say it, they can't wait to hear it. That is the Law of Anticipation.

THE LAW OF SIMPLICITY

Communicators Take Something Complicated and Make It Simple

WHEN VINCE LOMBARDI WAS THE coach of the NFL's Green Bay Packers, he appeared at a convention of coaches. Several speakers described their elaborate offensive and defensive schemes in great detail, evidently proud of their complicated playbooks. When Lombardi was asked his strategy, he replied, "I only have two strategies. My offensive strategy is simple: When we have the ball, we aim to knock the other team down! My defensive strategy is similar: When the other team has the ball, we aim to knock *all* of them down!"⁹³

When I speak, my strategy is similarly straightforward. When I walk on stage, I sit on my stool, work to connect with people, and move into my content with the goal of keeping it simple, natural, and easy to understand. Why? Because communicators take something complicated and make it simple. That is the Law of Simplicity.

WHO ARE YOU TRYING TO IMPRESS?

When I started out as speaker, I did not know or understand the Law of Simplicity. As a young theologian in college, I took many courses on speaking, but none of my professors taught the value of keeping communication simple. Warren Buffett said, "The business schools reward difficult complexity but simplicity is better."⁹⁴ The college I attended did too. It seems that many people in education value taking something simple and making it complicated. They wear it like a badge of honor, hoping you'll be impressed by the difficulty of their subject, the complexity of their ideas, and the obscurity of their vocabulary. And they reward students who imitate them.

When I was in college, each senior was required to speak in chapel to an auditorium filled with professors and students. We all dreaded the day when it would be our turn to try to impress the professors with our speaking skills. As I got ready for my speech, one thing I knew for certain was to stay away from simple. We were nearing graduation and had endured two years of Greek study, and we were expected to show off our knowledge.

When my dreaded day came, I delivered a message titled "The Incompatibility of Sin and Sonship." I went down the theological rabbit hole, searching for obscure problems and presenting complex ideas. I received the Senior Speaker of the Year award for my efforts. The professors loved it, but the students were bored out of their minds.

Sadly, my training carried over to my first congregation, a community of farmers in the poorest county in Indiana. That entire first year, I taught right out of a Greek New Testament I'd used as a textbook in college. At first, I didn't have a clue, but I slowly realized I was not connecting with the congregation. I began to see that they didn't want obscure word studies from a kid out of college. They wanted what legendary songwriter Harlan Howard said about the music he loved: "Country music is three chords and the truth."⁹⁵ They wanted something that would help them, delivered with simplicity.

No matter your audience—whether they're farmers, entrepreneurs, parents, managers, service industry workers, technicians, voters, artists, or students—they want to be engaged. They want to understand you easily and be able to do something positive with what you tell them. Don't try to be impressive. Embrace the idea expressed by novelist and playwright Clare Boothe Luce: "The height of sophistication is simplicity."⁹⁶ I learned that lesson by losing my audience by trying to impress them, then gaining them back by simplifying my message and making it practical.

THE SIMPLE APPROACH

Simplicity is a great principle for any area of life, not just communication. When I read the biography of Red Auerbach, who coached the great Boston Celtics basketball teams from 1950 to 1966, I was struck by his "keep it simple" philosophy. Reportedly, someone once asked Auerbach what magic formula he had for winning championships. He laughed and replied, "Our secret to success is what I call 'effective simplicity.' Nothing complicated. In fact, we only have seven different plays and Bill Russell touches the ball on every one of them." Simplicity certainly worked for him. Coaching Boston, Auerbach won nine NBA championships.

Simplicity is a wonderful way to approach life. I try to carry that idea into every aspect of my day-to-day living by focusing my attention in only five areas:

- **Values:** These are my foundation. I stand *on* them, and I stand *up* for them. Decision-making is simple when you know what your values are.
- **Principles:** These are my "North Star," the beliefs and guidelines for how I conduct my life.
- **Priorities:** I keep these in mind so that I keep the main thing the main thing. Knowing and doing the things that are most important every day makes every day effective.
- **Systems:** I plan, organize, and work in a systematic way that helps me achieve my goals. Systems are freeways that allow me to arrive at my desired destination quickly and maximize my time.
- **Intentionality:** This is the bridge that allows me to cross over from good intentions to good actions every day. It keeps me focused and brings effectiveness to what I do.

I've spent my life working to simplify what I believe and what I do. And I've found that the older I get, the fewer things I believe, but I believe them more deeply. Did simplifying my communication cause me to simplify my life, or did simplifying my life lead to simplifying my communication? I don't know. But they have definitely affected each other and have improved my life in many ways.

SIMPLE COMMUNICATION

When you don't value simplicity in communication, you can find yourself in situations like the people in a funny story I came across several years ago. A man in a hot-air balloon realized he was lost. He

reduced altitude and spotted a woman below. He descended a bit more and shouted, “Excuse me, can you help me? I promised a friend I would meet him an hour ago, but I don’t know where I am.” The woman below replied, “You’re in a hot-air balloon hovering approximately thirty feet above the ground. You’re between 40 and 41 degrees north latitude and between 59 and 60 degrees west longitude.”

“You must be an engineer,” said the balloonist.

“I am,” replied the woman, “how did you know?”

“Well,” answered the balloonist, “everything you told me is technically correct, but I’ve no idea what to make of your information, and the fact is, I’m still lost. Frankly, you’ve not been much help at all. If anything, you’ve delayed my trip.”

The woman below responded, “You must be in management.”

“I am,” replied the balloonist, “but how did you know?”

“Well,” said the woman, “you don’t know where you are or where you’re going. You have risen to where you are due to a large quantity of hot air. You made a promise, which you have no idea how to keep, and you expect people beneath you to solve your problems. The fact is, you are in exactly the same position you were in before we met, but now, somehow, you’ve managed to make it my fault.”⁹⁷

My friend Kevin Myers, whose story you read in the Law of Leverage (chapter 8), has studied communication for many years, and he frequently mentors young communicators to help them improve. In addition to teaching them the Law of Leverage, he teaches a concept he shared with me about the differences between simplistic, complex, and simple, and I want to teach it to you.

1. Simplistic: Shallow and Fast

One of the reasons some communicators shy away from simplifying their messages is they fear being simplistic. Being simplistic is *ignoring* the genuine complexity of a problem or situation and offering a too-easy solution. It’s what people often do in conversation when responding to somebody else’s problem. One person lays out a difficult leadership problem or life-altering situation, and the other person responds, “All you have to do is...” and they complete the sentence with an underthought idea. They’re often trite and only half right.

Have you ever heard someone say, “All you have to do is give me a title and position, and it will be easy to lead”? Clearly that person doesn’t understand the complexity of leadership. I’ve observed plenty of people with titles in leadership positions who couldn’t lead. Or maybe you’ve shared something gut-wrenching you’ve gone through, and someone said, “Experience is the best teacher.” Not only is that not helpful, it isn’t true. If experience were the best teacher, everyone who got older would get better. But they don’t. Experience is the best teacher only if you evaluate it, learn from it, and apply the lessons to your life!

Simplistic embraces popular thought but not proven thought. *Simplistic* asks no questions and leaves more than half of the issue uncovered. It doesn’t look for *real* answers, just easy ones. Simplistic is never satisfying. It has never satisfied me, nor will it satisfy an audience. Only the naive and inexperienced accept simplistic answers. To communicate effectively, you have to go deeper.

2. Complex: Deep and Slow

Most issues are complex. So are most problems. So are their solutions. Let’s face it: while simplistic is underwhelming, complexity can be overwhelming. To really dig into anything that needs to be solved, you need to ask questions. You need to uncover hidden pieces of information. You must take

anywhere from a handful to hundreds of factors into account. It's easy to get lost in complexity, and the process is usually very slow.

So how can you tackle complexity? With sustained thinking. I find the process of tackling complexity with sustained thinking both challenging and fulfilling. Working hard to get below the simplistic and wrestle with the complex takes time and energy. But the reward is wonderful. Having a eureka moment of understanding is fantastic. Taking that eureka and expressing it simply is even more rewarding. And if I can take that simple idea and make it memorable too? That's a home run!

3. Simple: Deep and Fast

The reward for digging into complex problems and ideas and coming out the other side with a simple way to express them is turning muddled teaching into crystal clear communication. Physicist Albert Einstein has been quoted as saying, "If you can't explain it simply, you don't understand it well enough." I don't know if he originated that idea, but it's true just the same. If you have examined an idea deeply, and you can communicate it quickly and simply, people will always want to hear you speak.

Simplistic	Complex	Simple
Shallow and Fast	Deep and Slow	Deep and Fast
Asks No Questions	Asks Many Questions	Answers Many Questions
Embraces Popular Thought	Embraces Sustained Thought	Embraces Proven Thought
Ineffective Solutions	Complicated Solutions	Elegant Solutions

You may be asking yourself, *Why don't more people deliver the deep and fast communication of the Law of Simplicity?* Because it's such hard work! French mathematician and philosopher Blaise Pascal once wrote in a letter, "I have made this longer than usual because I have not had time to make it shorter."⁹⁸ The complexity stage requires sustained thinking and writing. To deliver fast and deep, you must work long and slow. It takes a long time to write short.

Many times, when I'm working to simplify a message, I have to write down everything I can to determine what I truly think and know. It becomes a distilling process that draws on previous thoughts, ideas, or experiences. I work to craft these ideas into a greater yet simpler thought. When I can distill many simplistic things into one simple thing, I know that one thing is significant and can be communicated effectively.

Not everyone understands the work it takes to create simple communication. During an interview on one of my book tours, the host said to me in a condescending tone, "I've read some of your books and they are really simple."

"Yes," I responded, "the principles are easy to understand, but they're not so easy to apply." Apple cofounder Steve Jobs said, "It takes a lot of hard work to make something simple, to truly understand the underlying challenges and come up with elegant solutions." Jobs always worked hard to bring simplicity to all of Apple's products. "It was the original vision for Apple," Jobs said. "That's what we tried to do with the first Mac. That's what we did with the iPod."⁹⁹ Jobs biographer Walter Isaacson wrote,

Distinctive design—clean and friendly and fun—would become the hallmark of Apple products under Jobs.... an engineering and design aesthetic that set Apple apart from other technology companies and ultimately helped make it the most valuable company in the world. Its guiding tenet was simplicity—not merely the shallow simplicity that comes from an uncluttered look and feel and surface of a product, but the deep simplicity that comes from knowing the essence of every product, the complexities of its engineering and the function of every component.^{[100](#)}

Jobs brought this desire for simplicity not only into the design aesthetic of Apple products; he famously brought it into his communication about those products during launch events. The work required to do that is no small thing, but it has an incredible payoff.

GREAT COMMUNICATORS ARE GREAT SIMPLIFIERS

If you want to be a great communicator, you need to do the hard work of the Law of Simplicity. Every time you sit down to write a message, you may need to remind yourself, as I often do, that nothing is as simple as we hope. But with perseverance, we can take something complicated and make it simple. To do that, I work on achieving three things as I write.

1. Clarity

Your first goal as you prepare to communicate is to make what you say crystal clear. What standard should you follow? Here's mine: if you can't communicate your message to an eighth grader—who can then turn around and explain it to someone else—then it's not simple enough.

A master of clarity was wartime British prime minister Winston Churchill. He put painstaking effort into his speeches. He once claimed he would spend an hour working on a single minute of a speech. President John F. Kennedy, an excellent communicator himself, greatly admired Churchill's ability to write with clarity and power. Of Churchill's speechwriting, Kennedy said, "In the dark days and darker nights when England stood alone—and most men save Englishmen despaired of England's life—he mobilized the English language and sent it into battle."^{[101](#)}

In one of his earliest speeches to the members of Parliament after assuming leadership of the country, Churchill summed up the goal of his administration: "You ask, what is our aim? I can answer in one word: Victory. Victory at all costs. Victory in spite of all terror. Victory, however long and hard the road may be, for without victory there is no survival."^{[102](#)}

You can contrast that with the communication of Earl C. Kelley, a professor of secondary education at Wayne University. He wrote an introduction that has become famous for its lack of clarity in a book for teachers. Kelley summed up the work he and other educators had done at a workshop over a series of years:

We have not succeeded in answering all our problems—indeed we sometimes feel we have not completely answered any of them. The answers we have found have only served to raise a whole set of new questions. In some ways we feel that we are as confused as ever, but we think we are confused on a higher level and about more important things.^{[103](#)}

Kelley wrote those words in 1951. Has educational communication advanced since then?

When you speak, your ideas need to be simple, straightforward, and in language anyone can understand. C. S. Lewis knew this. Lewis was a professor of English literature, a lay theologian, and an expert in apologetics. A professor who taught at both Oxford and Cambridge, he was absolutely brilliant and intellectually capable of running circles around others when he spoke. But he understood the power of clarity. In one of his essays, he wrote about the importance of using common language.

To conclude—you must translate every bit of your [subject matter] into the vernacular. This is very troublesome and it means you can say very little in half an hour, but it is essential. It is also of the greatest service to your own thought. I have come to the conviction that if you cannot translate your thoughts into uneducated language, then your thoughts were confused. Power to translate is the test of having really understood one's own meaning.^{[104](#)}

No wonder Churchill said, “Broadly speaking short words are best and the old words when short, are best of all.”^{[105](#)} If you want to communicate at the highest level, your language needs to be on the bottom shelf where it's accessible to everyone.

2. Brevity

You don't need to speak a long time to say a lot. It's not the number of words you use; it's the impact you make with the words you use. Donald Walton, author of *Are You Communicating?*, points out,

- The Lord's Prayer contains only 56 words.
- Abraham Lincoln made his memorable address at Gettysburg in 268 words.
- It took only 1,322 words in the Declaration of Independence to get our whole country started.
- A survey of 74 federal agencies showed they issued 102,000 publications over 18 months. The *Monthly Catalog of U.S. Publications* listed 66,000 for the same period. One official's explanation: “The government is putting out printed material faster than it can keep track of it” (from *US News & World Report*).
- George Washington delivered the shortest inaugural address of any President—only 135 words to state his aim for the new nation. The undistinguished William Henry Harrison was our wordiest President. His inaugural speech contained more than 9,000 words. Standing in the rain during his lengthy harangue, Harrison caught pneumonia and died soon after.
- Moral: Be brief and you can claim to be like the father of your country; get too windy, and it may be the death of you, in one way or another.^{[106](#)}

Brevity takes work. When President Woodrow Wilson was asked how long it took him to prepare his speeches, he responded:

That depends on the length of the speech. If it is a ten-minute speech it takes me all of two weeks to prepare it; if it is a half-hour speech it takes me a week; if I can talk as long as I want to it requires no preparation at all. I am ready now.^{[107](#)}

If you want to be a great communicator, don't use the “ready now” approach. Do what it takes to keep your speaking short and simple.

There's an art to saying a lot in a few words. You must choose your words wisely and pick only the ones that make an impact. That can be a challenge. Presidential speechwriter Peggy Noonan recalled her difficulty writing her first speech for Ronald Reagan soon after she arrived at the White House. It was to be a very short (and some would say inconsequential) speech the president would

read as he presented a Teacher of the Year award in the Rose Garden. As she struggled at her typewriter, this story came to mind:

Remember the waterfront shack with the sign FRESH FISH SOLD HERE. Of course it's fresh, we're on the ocean. Of course it's for sale, we're not giving it away. Of course it's here, otherwise the sign would be somewhere else. The final sign: FISH.^{[108](#)}

In the end, she found a way to write the speech, Reagan did not change a single word, and she got her start. The speech she later wrote for Reagan on the shuttle *Challenger* disaster is considered the eighth-best American political speech of the twentieth century.^{[109](#)} The speech was only 650 words, but it consoled a nation heartsick after the tragedy.

3. Focus

In his book *The Laws of Simplicity*, MIT professor and graphic designer John Maeda writes about ways we can improve life by making it simpler. His first law couldn't be more direct: "Reduce." But my favorite of his ten laws is the last: "Simplicity is about subtracting the obvious and adding the meaningful."^{[110](#)} What he's really writing about is focus.

There's a reason all TED Talks are asked to be eighteen minutes or fewer. The organizers want all TED speakers to do the work of making their communication not only clear and brief but also focused. A focused piece of communication possesses everything it needs and nothing else.

A lot of people come to me asking my advice on speaking and book writing. Some of the best advice I can give was written by the editor of a publication nearly a hundred years ago:

If you've got a thought that's happy—boil it down!
Make it short and crisp and snappy—boil it down!
When your brain its coin has minted,
Down the page your pen has sprinted:
If you want your effort printed—boil it down!
Take out every surplus letter—boil it down!
Fewer syllables the better—boil it down!
Make your meaning plain. Express it
So we'll know, not merely guess it.
Then my friends ere you address it—boil it down!
Cut out all the extra trimming—boil it down!
Skim it well, then skim the skimmings—boil it down!
When you're sure 'twould be a sin
Another sentence to cut in,
Send it on and we'll begin to BOIL IT DOWN!^{[111](#)}

Listening to great communication should be like having a great dining experience. Great chefs use only the best ingredients, and they concentrate their flavors. Each element of the dish is distinct. Nothing essential has been left out, and nothing extraneous has been added. The result is something intense, surprising, and deeply satisfying.

As you communicate, follow that same philosophy, putting together your messages using both art and science. As you work to practice the Law of Simplicity, remember these points:

- Less is more.
- Clarity is power.
- Clear is kind.
- Everything must be as simple as possible.
- If you can't explain it simply, you don't understand it.
- Stop trying to impress the audience.
- Start helping your audience.
- Get to your point before people start asking, "What's the point?"
- Say what's important over again.
- Say it simply, say it slowly, say it with a smile.

If you put in the work and do these things every time you speak, you will always improve your message and delivery. Why? Because communicators take something complicated and make it simple. That is the Law of Simplicity.

THE LAW OF VISUAL EXPRESSION

Show and Tell Is Better Than Just Tell

AS A COMMUNICATOR, YOU NEED to decide what you will do visually to enhance your presentations. You could rely 100 percent on your voice to carry your message, the way people did in the heyday of radio. But it's important to note that even in radio, they used music, sound effects, and words to paint pictures. Perhaps you *could* use only your voice. But why would you? Show and tell is better than just tell. That's the Law of Visual Expression.

A WORLD OF IMAGES

I was recently talking with my friend Tim Elmore about this law. Tim is the founder of Growing Leaders and a gifted communicator. He is especially skilled in the use of pictures in his communication, both physical images and word pictures. He shared with me something he wrote that captures the environment we currently live in:

We live in a culture rich with images. We grew up with photographs, TV, movies, video, VH1, DVDs, Facebook, and Instagram. We can't escape the power of the visual image—and most of us don't want to. We've grown accustomed to watching, not merely listening to, our music; radio gave way to TV, which gave birth to MTV. Even our music is inseparable from images. Our grandparents grew up listening to the radio for entertainment; kids today grow up watching YouTube. And the pace of this visual expansion accelerates. As a child, I was among the first to mature with the television set—the “one-eyed babysitter.” Today's adolescents can aptly be called “screenagers,” as their screen time is not limited to a television but has expanded to laptops, video games, tablets, and smart phones. Within the next seven years, ninety percent of the content we'll receive on our cell phones will be visual, not verbal.^{[112](#)}

WHY IS TEACHING WITH IMAGES SO EFFECTIVE?

Tim is an expert on generational differences and has dedicated the last forty years to investing in younger generations. His book *Habitudes*, which teaches values through pictures, has sold millions of copies and has made a great impact on high school and university students not only in the United States but in other countries around the world. As he worked on that book, he did a lot of research on

the power of the visual related to communication and understanding. Here are some of his conclusions:

1. The Majority of People Are Visual Learners

About 60 percent of all people are visual thinkers.^{[113](#)} When most of us hear *elephant* or *red fire engine*, we don't think of those words. Instead, images of those items come to mind. Even our physical bodies are designed to receive visual signals. According to experts, about 80 percent of our sensory inputs are visual in nature.^{[114](#)} No wonder Aristotle said, "The soul does not think without a picture." If you want to connect with people and help them learn, you need to use visuals.

2. Pictures Stick in People's Minds

Have you ever heard someone joke, "I can never un-see that" after they stumble into an awkward situation? There's truth in that statement. Behavioral scientists who have conducted studies have discovered that people remember pictures better than they do words most of the time.^{[115](#)} They call this tendency the "picture superiority effect." Tim points out, "Post-modern society is a world saturated with data. People process approximately one thousand messages a day, digitally and personally. The only hope we have of our message sticking is to insure it contains pictures."^{[116](#)} The more visual you are, the more memorable you are.

3. People Are Highly Responsive to Images

It is a cliché, but it's also true: a picture is worth a thousand words. People stream shows and can't wait to talk about them with friends. Drivers are drawn to billboards. People who don't read the news in a paper still seek out the comics. Ads use images, not just text. And art galleries continue to exhibit the work of the masters because their images generate conversation. People are drawn to images and react to them mentally and emotionally.

4. Images Engage the Creative and Holistic Parts of the Brain

In *A Whole New Mind*, Daniel Pink writes about the shift in human society from the Information Age, which was driven by knowledge workers, to what he calls the Conceptual Age, which will be driven by creators and empathizers. In the book, he recounts extensive research on how the different sides of the brain work. He points out that the right brain is good at processing images and faces, is creative, can process information holistically and simultaneously, is able to synthesize, and can see the big picture.^{[117](#)} When you use visuals, you help your audience process, synthesize, and understand.

5. Visuals Tell Stories in Our Imagination

Tim says, "A simple picture can spark a new thought each time you look at it. Why? Pictures tell stories. The philosophers of our day are musicians and filmmakers, who paint pictures in our minds and inspire imaginations."^{[118](#)} If you want to engage the imagination of your audience, don't give them stats. Give them images. Knowing this, as communicators we should make our presentations as visual as we can.

PICTURE THIS!

Film director Martin Scorsese said, “If one wants to reach younger people at an earlier age to shape their minds in a critical way, you really need to know how ideas and emotions are expressed visually.”¹¹⁹ These visuals don’t have to be restricted to film or video. I’ve found that there are three ways a communicator can improve their communication visually.

1. Body Movement, Gestures, and Facial Expressions

The first visual aid you need to employ as a communicator is your body. You can learn to use movement, gestures, and facial expressions to enhance and emphasize what you say. I know this because when I first started communicating, I was a neck-up speaker. I stood stationary behind a large lectern and simply spoke words to my congregation. It was like I was hiding. That lectern was so big, I could have been naked behind it, and no one would have noticed. Observing me speak must have been like watching an iceberg for my audience back then. Very little of me was visible and my movement was imperceptible.

As I gained experience, I became more comfortable and relaxed. I gained enough confidence to move from behind the lectern. That allowed me to use body language to enhance my communication. I started using more gestures. And I discovered that the more I moved, the more alert my audience became.

One day when I was speaking, I decided to sit down on the steps at the edge of the stage. Immediately I felt a change in the room. I could sense a more intimate connection with the audience. I was no longer speaking *to* them. I was having a conversation *with* them. I made a mental note of that and put it into my communication toolbox.

Many years ago, I was invited to speak at the Crystal Cathedral. It was the first venue I had ever spoken in that had large projection screens. When I started to speak, I noticed the crowd wasn’t looking at me. They were looking to my left. That was very unnerving. I felt like I didn’t really have their attention, that I wasn’t connecting. Then I realized they were watching me, but on the big screen, not on the platform. My immediate inclination was to leave the platform and walk twenty yards to my left under the screen so that I could be in their line of sight.

While I was delivering my message, I was also having a dialogue with myself trying to decide what to do. Then, just at that point, I said something funny and made a face. The audience exploded! The room roared with their laughter as they watched the screen. That’s when I got it. I understood the power of a camera and a large projection screen to enhance communication, especially in a big venue. After that, I adjusted my communication and became content to let the cameras enlarge my expressions and movement so that everyone could see them.

Today I work at being a highly visual speaker, and I use everything I can to help me communicate, including my smile. There’s a reason for that. I remember well looking into a mirror when I was in the third grade and thinking, *I am not a handsome boy*. In that moment, I decided to smile. Immediately I looked better. It didn’t heal me, but it did help me! Since that time, I have intentionally and continually smiled, especially when I’m on stage. The world is filled with hundreds of languages. A smile speaks in all of them. It communicates everything a glad heart wants to express.

I also use larger movement to enhance and support my communication. Recently while speaking in Cancun, I stepped on stage before a raucous crowd. Everything I said was met with cheers. I loved the energy, but I knew that if I couldn’t settle them down, I would never be able to connect with them. Thinking fast, I walked forward off the stage to get physically closer to them. It had an immediate calming effect. Instinctively, I walked over to one of the tables in the room and asked if I could sit down with the people there to have a conversation.

I had their attention. Every one of the three thousand people in the room was focused on that table, and they were all leaning in. I spoke to them quietly about principles that would help them personally and professionally. On an emotional level, it felt like we were all sitting around the table as friends. We connected. And because we connected, they were able to receive what I had to offer them.

I need to clarify something about how I use physical movement. I use my body to emphasize what I say, which is like a performance. But I don't want to be a *performer*. I want to be *part* of the crowd, not *separate* from it. My desire is to move toward people as they move toward me. While it's physically true that they are sitting in seats in front of me, I am always inviting them to "sit beside me." I want to be in the moment with them and for every one of them to feel and recognize it. For that to happen, not only do they need to be able to see me; I need to be able to see them! That's why I want the lights to be up in the auditorium.

I touch on lighting briefly in the Law of the Thermostat (chapter 13), but I want to emphasize it here as well. There is a world of difference between a room with the house lights up and the house lights down:

House Lights Up	House Lights Down
Energy Is High	Energy Is Low
Focus Is on the Audience	Focus Is on the Stage
Communicates Inclusion	Communicates Exclusion
Invites Interaction	Creates Isolation
Shares Emotion	Separates Emotion
Says, "We Are One"	Says, "I Am the Star"

When I speak, I want to move the audience emotionally, but I also want to feel moved by the audience. I want what I say to touch them, and seeing their response touches me. While I have something to give, they do too. My visual expressions of vulnerability demonstrate that I am secure with them and am willing to move and be moved. All of this increases the sense of connection for me and them. The experience is priceless.

Years ago, a mentor told me, "John, don't say—show. Don't promise—prove. Don't just talk—act." When you bring your entire self to your communication, you are doing those three things. If you want to become a better communicator, you must do more than speak from the neck up. Don't remain stationary and attempt to command attention. Use body movement, gestures, and facial expressions and *capture* attention.

2. Word Pictures

Daniel Pink says, "If a picture is worth a thousand words, a metaphor is worth a thousand pictures."¹²⁰ He makes this assertion because word pictures engage both hemispheres of our brains and bring us to greater levels of understanding and involvement.

A message I have been delivering frequently is on how to become a catalyst for transformation. I've lost count of the number of times and the countries where I've presented it. To increase my audience's level of understanding and engagement with the message, I use six word pictures:

The first picture is a Mirror. I ask them to picture themselves. Why? Because transformation begins in me. It begins in you. It always starts with an individual.

The second picture is Clapsed Hands. Transformation requires partnerships. It never happens solo. One is too small a number to achieve greatness.

The third picture is a Ladder. Transformation means helping others rise up to a better place. To be catalysts of transformation, we must hold the ladder for others so they can climb up to their potential.

The fourth picture is a Heart. Transformation occurs when people embrace good values in their hearts and live them out in their lives.

The fifth picture is a Table. When people gather around a table, learn values, share their lives, and grow, transformation occurs.

The sixth picture is a Bridge. What do bridges do? They help people cross over from where they are to where they want to be. Transformation is the bridge that takes people to a better life.

Transformation is an abstract, intangible idea. With these word pictures, people can easily grasp the concept. It becomes accessible, and they can see themselves being a part of it. But I like to take it one step further. After I share the word pictures, I ask everyone to stand so I can add a physical motion with each picture to make it more memorable.

The Mirror: Point to Yourself

Hands Clapsed: Shake Hands with Someone

The Ladder: Grasp Rungs as You “Climb”

The Heart: Put Your Hand on Your Heart

The Table: Draw a Big Circle with Your Hand

The Bridge: Point from Here to There

And I narrate each part as they do the motion:

“Transformation begins in me...”

“As I join hands with others...”

“Helping others climb up to their potential...”

“By learning and living good values...”

“Around a table...”

“To build a bridge to a better future.”

I take great joy in teaching these motions and asking the audience to repeat them after me, and I usually make it playful and fun by exaggerating my own motions and moving around. When something is fun and includes the senses, people want to recount it to others, and because it’s visual, they can remember it and retell it.

In the summer of 2022, I was invited to address a meeting of the representatives of the judiciary in Costa Rica, including their Supreme Court justices. When I arrived at the justice department building, I was ushered into a large room filled with people. It took three seconds of speaking to see that this was a very serious group of men and women who were not quick to smile or laugh.

After teaching the six word pictures of transformation, I debated whether to ask these stuffy-looking judges to do the motions—what one member of my staff sarcastically calls the Transformation Hokey Pokey. But I knew I wanted to leave a lasting impression on them because they, as much as anyone in the country, could bring transformation to Costa Rica. So I went for it.

They stood up reluctantly. As I started teaching the motions, they looked around at one another as if to seek permission from their colleagues. But the chief justice, who was in the front row, enthusiastically participated. Then so did the other Supreme Court justices seated right behind him. There was a sudden change in everyone's demeanor, and they participated, laughed, and relaxed. It's a moment I'll never forget.

There is great value in using word pictures with an audience, and here's the best thing about it: anyone can do it. Anyone who can speak can create "visuals" using words. You don't need artistic ability, technical know-how, equipment, or props. You only need the desire to create them, the preparation to craft them, and the intentionality to use them.

3. Pictures, Props, and Videos

The final category of visuals involves using actual physical objects, in person or on screen. According to the Presentation Training Institute, just three hours after a presentation, 85 percent of the audience can remember content presented visually versus 70 percent who can retain verbal content. But after three days, 60 percent can still remember the visual content, whereas only 10 percent can remember something from the oral presentation.^{[121](#)}

There is an art to using these kinds of visuals—and also an element of risk. If you can transport a well-thought-out prop to where you will speak and present it so everyone can see it, you can be very effective. In the Law of Observation (chapter 2), I explained how Zig Ziglar used an old-fashioned hand pump on stage to effectively illustrate his points.

Steve Jobs's presentation of the first iPhone at MacWorld in 2007 became legendary, not only because the design of the iPhone was revolutionary but because he actually used the device in real time with the results projected on a giant screen to show his audience what it was capable of. He received ovation after ovation. If you watch it on YouTube, as tens of millions of people have done, you'll see him do mundane actions such as swiping photos or songs to view them, pinching images to change their size, and scrolling through a list of voice mails. We now do those actions every day and think nothing of them. But until that moment when Jobs presented them, no one in the world had even seen them. Why? Because Apple had just invented them and was showing them to the public for the first time!

What if Jobs had gotten up to present the iPhone and none of his audiovisual equipment worked? Well, that's the risk of using visuals. In fact, during rehearsals, the iPhone, which was an incomplete prototype, gave Jobs nothing but trouble. But he took the risk and made the presentation anyway.^{[122](#)}

When you use technology as part of your presentation, there is always a chance that your media won't be compatible with their system, a computer crashes, wires get crossed, a technician can't solve a problem on the fly, or the power goes out. Even a Super Bowl—arguably the biggest, most meticulously planned, and most lucrative single sporting event every year—experienced a power outage in 2013 that shut down the game for more than thirty minutes.

I don't use props or images very often, but I admire people who use them effectively so that they enhance their communication. My favorite visual to use other than my own movement is a photograph. For example, every year I lead an event called Exchange, and I present a session titled "Lessons I've Learned This Year." I love showing a picture for each lesson that captures its spirit.

One time at Exchange, I showed my audience this picture of Ethan, a third grader in Charlotte, North Carolina.

I had been visiting a school, and during a Q&A with all the children in the third grade, Ethan raised his hand, stood up, and asked, “Mr. Maxwell, do you ever feel deep down here,” pointing to his heart, “that you want to help people make a difference?” It was like he had read my mind and heart! “Yes, Ethan,” I told him, “That’s exactly how I feel.” I reached out and gave him a hug. “Ethan,” I said, “you are going to change your world.” Then to my Exchange audience, I taught a lesson on how all of us were created to make a difference.



Another year I showed everyone this picture:



The photograph was taken at the beginning of the COVID-19 pandemic. As I mentioned in the Law of Conviction (chapter 3), all my live speaking events for the year had been canceled. I felt like I had been handed a bunch of lemons. What did I do? I made lemonade. I went to my friend Andrew’s studio and started teaching lessons on video. We published them on YouTube so organizations and their teams could receive life-changing lessons for free. I reached more than a million people with these messages. It was my way of lighting a candle instead of cursing the darkness. I went on to teach

my Exchange audience a lesson on how crisis can bring out the best in a leader who brings out the best in others.

To become a great visual communicator, do you need to use slides, photos, videos, or props? No. Of course not. I just looked up the top TED Talks of all time. Each of the four communicators used visuals differently.

The fourth most popular talk, “How Great Leaders Inspire Action” by Simon Sinek, has received more than 57 million views. He used an old-fashioned flip chart and marker to make his points.

“Inside the Mind of a Master Procrastinator” by Tim Urban, the third most popular talk, has received 59 million views. He uses simple but humorous hand-drawn graphics.

In “Your Body Language May Shape Who You Are,” social scientist Amy Cuddy used photographs and short video clips of people to illustrate body language as she spoke. Hers is the second most popular TED Talk with nearly 64 million views.

And the top TED Talk? “Do Schools Kill Creativity?” by Sir Ken Robinson. It has received 72 million views. What kind of visuals did he use? Only facial expressions. His quick wit and compelling ideas carried most of his message.^{[123](#)} What Nancy Duarte, another popular TED Talk speaker, said is true: “If you communicate an idea in a way that resonates, change will happen, and you can change the world.”^{[124](#)}

Shakespeare famously shared some of his philosophy for presenting to an audience in the words of Hamlet when the character gave direction to the traveling players. He said, “Suit the action to the word, the word to the action.”^{[125](#)} And that’s the bottom line when it comes to the Law of Visual Expression. Whatever people see must support what they hear. If there is a disconnection between the two, the audience will become distracted and be taken out of the moment. And they won’t feel what you feel, think what you think, or laugh when you laugh.

People want to be engaged and entertained, now more than ever. They crave and expect multisensory experiences. The more you can do visually, the more most people will like it—and the better communicator you will become. Show and tell is better than just tell. That’s the Law of Visual Expression.

THE LAW OF STORYTELLING

People See Their Own Lives in Stories

AS A CHILD, I LOVED when my mother read stories to me. She did it all the time because she was a librarian and teacher who loved books. My favorite story was *The Little Engine That Could*. As Mom read the story's signature phrase, "I think I can. I think I can," I could barely contain my excitement because I identified with the little engine, and I wanted her to succeed in getting over the hill.

When I was in first grade, during story time our teacher asked each student to share their favorite story with the class. When my turn came, I stood in front of the class and not only told the entire story of *The Little Engine That Could*; I acted it out. When I was done, the whole class applauded! That day I realized three things. First, it was fun to tell a story. Second, my classmates, who were all my friends, liked hearing my story. And third, I loved performing it for them. I have been hooked on storytelling ever since.

THE POWER OF STORYTELLING

Journalist and storytelling expert Christopher Booker wrote,

We spend a phenomenal amount of our lives following stories; telling them; listening to them; reading them; watching them being acted out on the television screen or in films or on a stage. They are far and away one of the most important features of our everyday existence.... These structured sequences of imagery are in fact the most natural way we know to describe almost anything which happens in our lives.^{[126](#)}

That is true. Poet and novelist Margaret Atwood said, "You're never going to kill storytelling because it's built into the human plan. We come with it."^{[127](#)} And storytelling does so much for us. Why?

Stories animate our reasoning process.

Stories create emotional responses.

Stories are pictures of who we aspire to be.

Stories give us permission to act.

Stories connect.
Stories stick.
Stories captivate us.
Stories are us.

Stories are at least as old as human beings. The first day people talked, I guarantee you they were telling stories.

If you want to become an excellent communicator, you need to learn the Law of Storytelling because people see their own lives in stories. Cognitive psychologist Jerome Bruner estimates people are twenty-two times more likely to remember a fact when it has been wrapped in a story. Why? Because stories are memorable, they help us grab the gist of an idea quickly, and they trigger emotion.^{[128](#)}

I love stories. I tell them constantly. I listen to them attentively. And I'm looking for them continually. They expand my world, and they enrich the members of my audience who hear them. C. S. Lewis summed up just how important they can be. Describing any person who hasn't heard, read, or embraced stories, he wrote, "He may be full of goodness and good sense but he inhabits a tiny world. In it, we should be suffocated. The man who is contented to be only himself, and therefore less a self, is in prison. My own eyes are not enough for me, I will see through those of others. Reality, even seen through the eyes of many, is not enough. I will see what others have invented."^{[129](#)} Or as said by Anthony Hopkins portraying former US president John Quincy Adams in the movie *Amistad*, "Whoever tells the best story wins."

MASTER STORYTELLERS

When I knew I intended to write the Law of Storytelling, the first person I wanted to consult was Don Yaeger. He writes and tells a story better than anyone else I know. This is what he shared:

We can all name them. Who in your organization holds your attention when they speak up? Who can you count on to be the most engaging dinner conversationalist? What speaker do you see on a program who pulls you in?

The names that come to mind are those who tell stories so well that time seems to stand still. And it's true whether they're speaking to an audience of one or one thousand; on a sales call or a stage; a podcast or around a meal. Those who most deeply connect with their listeners do so through great storytelling.

Decades of research and centuries of wisdom make clear that our brains are wired to remember well-told stories long after the facts grow old. Those who are able to share meaningful and impactful narratives become success stories themselves.

Great storytellers become the best salespeople, the most memorable leaders, the most engaging speakers, the best mentors, and the teachers we will remember for a lifetime.

Storytelling is part of the marrow of what makes us human. We see it in cave paintings, hear it in ancient songs, read it etched into stone and transcribed onto scrolls. But the truth is that storytelling matters even more today than ever. Think about all of the websites, webinars, podcasts, streaming video, and good, old-fashioned, in-person conversations we engage with every day. The way we use these platforms to tell the stories of ourselves, our experiences, our

companies, our brands, and our ideas has the ability to reach and influence people to a degree unmatched in human history.

The good news on the storytelling front is that great storytelling can be learned. *In fact, it has to be learned....* Storytelling isn't a form of magic but of technique—although the effect you can have on others can seem like magic at times. And becoming a far better storyteller than you believed possible is certainly within your grasp! You just have to approach it as you would other leadership development and effective communication skills worth mastering.^{[130](#)}

Don says the bottom line is getting your audience to care about what happens in the story, preferably in a deep way. The Law of Storytelling is about winning the hearts of your audience. That is something I have been learning and improving upon for most of my life. For example, back in the fall of 1999, Margaret, some friends, and I visited the small town of Jonesborough, Tennessee, to attend the annual National Storytelling Festival. I was in my early fifties and had been communicating for more than thirty years, yet I knew I still had a lot to learn about storytelling.

For three days we sat on blankets or folding chairs, occasionally in the rain, to watch one storyteller after another captivate us. We heard speakers tell every kind of story and tale: sad, happy, funny, sentimental, historical, fictitious, mythical. Some had a message. Others simply entertained us. But all the stories and storytellers had one thing in common: they had the power to captivate every one of their listeners.

At the end of the conference, I sat with my friends, who were also communicators, and together we analyzed why the storytellers were so effective. Here are the characteristics we identified:

- **Enthusiasm:** They loved what they were doing and expressed themselves with joy and vitality.
- **Animation:** The presenters exhibited lively facial expressions, movement, and gestures.
- **Audience Participation:** Nearly every storyteller involved the audience in some way, asking listeners to sing, clap, repeat phrases, or mimic gestures.
- **Responsiveness:** The storytellers responded freely to their listeners.
- **Memory:** They all told their stories without notes, which allowed them to maintain eye contact.
- **Laughter:** They used humor, even in serious and sad stories.
- **Creativity:** They told classic themes using fresh perspectives.
- **Immediacy:** They told most stories in the first person.
- **Heartwarming:** Their stories made everyone feel good for having heard them.

My friends and I came away from the experience humbled and intrigued. And we took the things we'd learned, incorporated them into our communication, and told a lot more stories when we spoke.

YOU CAN CONNECT TELLING STORIES

Anyone can become a better storyteller and improve their communication. The thing you need to keep in mind is not to try to make yourself look impressive using stories. Though the presenters we saw at the National Storytelling Festival were master performers who were highly impressive, they were not trying to impress us. They were helping us see ourselves in their stories. They were connecting with us and using stories to communicate ideas, emotions, and truths. That's what you need to do. Tell stories with the purpose of connecting with others. If you put the focus on the listeners, your storytelling skills will improve overnight.

How do you connect? Simply think about what it is to be a human being. We all laugh, cry, face problems, succeed, fail, and possess hopes and dreams. Poet and author Maya Angelou was asked in an interview how to craft a compelling story. Here was her response:

There's a statement by [the Roman dramatist] Terence: "I am a human being. Nothing human can be alien to me." If you know that, accept that, then you can tell a story. You can make people believe characters are just like they are. Jack and Jill went up the hill, one fell down and the other came tumbling after. The listener thinks, "Oh, I've fallen down, so I can understand," even if it happened in Holland or Kowloon. Human beings should understand how other humans feel no matter where they are, no matter what their language or culture is, no matter their age, and no matter the age in which they live. If you develop the art of seeing us as more alike than we are unlike, then all stories are understandable.^{[131](#)}

Because you are human and you experience emotions, you can use stories in your presentations. Connect with your humanity.

WHAT CONSTITUTES A STORY?

What is a story? Boiled down to its essence, stories are really very basic. Charlie Wetzel, my book writing partner of nearly thirty years, once taught his son's second-grade class how to tell a story. Charlie knows a lot about this. I'd estimate he's written more than five hundred original stories for my books based on history, business, sports, government, and popular culture. His challenge was how to communicate storytelling to a group of six- and seven-year-olds. He broke it down into its most basic parts: Every story has a hero, a goal, conflict, and resolution.

The hero, or the main character in the story, can be anyone or anything, and your goal is to help your audience identify with them. That hero has a goal but faces conflict as he tries to achieve it. That is the core of the story. And in the end, the hero either succeeds or fails. Every story, from the simplest children's tale to the great epics of literature, is a variation on this pattern:

The Little Engine That Could

Hero: The Little Engine

Goal: Making it over the hill to deliver the toys

Conflict: The difficulty of getting up the hill

Resolution: The engine makes it and delivers the toys

Hamlet

Hero: Hamlet, prince of Denmark

Goal: Deciding whether to kill his uncle to avenge his father the king's death

Conflict: Not knowing with certainty if his uncle really killed his father

Resolution: Hamlet kills his uncle, but he dies in the process

The Odyssey

Hero: Odysseus, King of Thebes

Goal: To return home to his wife and son

Conflict: Storms, monsters, and various creatures delay him for ten years

Resolution: Odysseus arrives home in time to reunite with his family, slay his enemies, save his wife, and restore his kingdom

You can use stories for any purpose: to prove a point, illustrate an idea, teach a process, break the tension, or move your audience emotionally. Most of the stories and anecdotes I use are ones I've collected. I'm *always* on the lookout for great stories. Every time I read, I'm looking for them. When I'm with friends or colleagues, I ask if they have any good stories. And people send me good stories all the time. As I look for them, my criteria for stories worth telling are the same as I discussed in the Law of Leverage (chapter 8): they must convey heart, help, humor, or hope.

The other types of stories I often tell come from my own life. When I was a young speaker first starting out, I avoided recounting any of my life experiences. This was because my college speech professors discouraged us from telling personal stories. They said it showed egotism. For a while I tried following their advice, but since the stories were not my own, I had no emotional investment in them, and I came off as aloof when I told them. That detachment separated me from my audience. So, I started experimenting with telling my own stories, and I discovered they were the most effective.

The ability to tell a personal story effectively is really a matter of attitude. If you tell success stories for the purpose of self-aggrandizement, of course it will come off as egotism. But if you tell stories of your own struggles and mistakes, it humbles you and helps others. And if you tell a funny story, it makes everyone laugh. That's why my favorite humor is self-deprecating. When I good-naturedly poke fun and laugh at myself, everyone else does too. It closes the gap between me and my audience.

When I tell a story from my personal perspective, I'm always trying to put the audience in my shoes. I'm trying to give them a chance to live my story with me, which really makes *them* the hero of the story. It's not about me. It's about the audience.

HOW TO SHARE A STORY EFFECTIVELY

Roddy Galbraith, a faculty member and mentor for the Maxwell Leadership Certified Team, has trained our certified coaches and speakers in communication since the inception of the program. During a teaching session recently, he and I were discussing communication, and I taught my method of storytelling based on the acronym **SHARE** :

Show
Help
Amplify
Relate
Enjoy

Let's examine each part of the SHARE storytelling method.

1. Show: What Do I Want Them to See and Hear?

What is the essence of the story you want to tell? Is there anything in it that doesn't need to be there, any detail that doesn't contribute? Playwright Anton Chekhov advised, "Remove everything that has no relevance to the story. If you say in the first chapter that there is a rifle hanging on the wall, in the

second or third chapter it absolutely must go off. If it's not going to be fired, it shouldn't be hanging there.”¹³²

Don Yaeger emphasizes the importance of including dialogue. “Memorable storytelling is a combination of what you say and how you say it,” Don explains. “Using somebody’s actual phrasing can add color to a story that will pull your listener or reader in and make them care about the characters. And that’s one of your storytelling goals: to have your audience care, preferably in a deep way, what happens.”¹³³ You want people to see themselves in your stories.

And as always, you need to make sure the story you want to tell is tailored to your audience. As Don says, “There’s nothing that makes someone more interested in you than when they find out you’ve taken time to show interest in them.”¹³⁴ If the story you’re considering doesn’t fit your audience, look for a different story.

Selecting what to include and what to remove from a story takes some practice. Some people write them out to decide what to include. Then when you tell a story, pay attention to your audience’s reaction, and make adjustments for the next time you tell it. Stand-up comedians do this all the time.

2. Help: How Will Telling This Story Help Them?

I always want my audience to have a takeaway from any story I tell. I believe a story with application is a story with a happy ending. Don calls this defining your storytelling ROI. He recommends speakers ask themselves, *What do I want the listener to do, think, or feel when they’ve heard my words?*¹³⁵ Can you tell stories simply to entertain your audience? Of course. But why not get all the value out of a story that you can? The better you align your stories to the purpose of your presentation, the greater the impact they will have.

3. Amplify: What Do I Want Them to Imagine?

Stories have potential to help people dream, explore, and expand their lives. That requires creativity from the presenter. One of the best ways to enter a creative space as you work on a story is to maintain a beginner’s mindset. As teacher and author Shunryu Suzuki said, “In the beginner’s mind there are many possibilities. In the expert’s mind there are few.”¹³⁶

One of my favorite stories of open-minded creativity was told by Roy Disney, Walt’s older brother. When Walt was in the fifth grade in Ohio, his teacher gave the class an art assignment. When she saw Walt’s drawing, she saw that his flowers had faces.

“Walter, flowers don’t have faces,” she admonished.

“Mine do!”

Walt Disney harnessed his imagination as a boy—and continued to do so as an adult, always keeping that joyful, creative, beginner’s mindset. He dreamed big dreams and helped others do the same. As Jamie Buckingham wrote, “Across the years that dream materialized into a mouse who talked, an elephant who flew, a cricket who danced, and flowers—thousands of flowers—all with faces.”¹³⁷

Your imagination can fuel your audience’s imagination. It’s been said that imagination is given to us to compensate for what we are not, and a sense of humor to console us for what we are. Find ways to use both. As you fine-tune your story, think about how you can expand possibilities for people and help them engage their higher aspirations.

4. Relate: What Do I Want Them to Feel?

Much too often I hear speakers tell stories directed only to the minds of their listeners, failing to reach their hearts. This weak approach misses opportunities because all people are emotional. Even the most logical and cerebral person is more emotional than he thinks he is. If you want evidence of the impact of emotion, look at the sales figures of the *Chicken Soup for the Soul* books. These books, filled with heartwarming stories, have become the bestselling trade paperback series of all time. The series has sold more than 500 *million* books worldwide!^{[138](#)}

If you want to tell a connecting story, put your emotions into it. Don't be afraid to show people that you care about what you're talking about. Storytelling is built on humanity. It connects with others when it contains emotion.

The stories Martin Luther King Jr. often told during the civil rights movement illustrate the power of emotion. Author and historian Donald T. Phillips described how King used stories:

He also often told the story of an elderly, "toil-worn woman in Montgomery" who began her "slow, painful four-mile walk" to work. "It was the tenth month of the Montgomery bus boycott," Martin said. "The old woman's difficult progress led a passerby to inquire sympathetically if her feet were tired. Her simple answer became the boycotters' slogan. 'Yes, friend, my feet is real tired,' she said, 'but my soul is rested.'" In fact, it was Martin Luther King Jr. who made that simple answer the boycotters' slogan, by telling the story every chance he got.

Later, during the Birmingham movement, Martin witnessed one particular touching exchange between a white police officer and a small black child. It also became a story he would tell many times over—and one that never failed to move the audience. "A child of no more than eight walked with her mother one day in a demonstration," he said. "An amused policeman leaned down to her and said with mock gruffness, 'What do you want?' The child looked into his eyes, unafraid, and gave her answer. 'F'edom,' she said. She could not even pronounce the word," he concluded, "but no Gabriel trumpet could have sounded a truer note."^{[139](#)}

King's stories generated deep feeling in his audience. Yours should too.

5. Enjoy: How Can I Make the Story Fun and Unforgettable?

When you've accomplished the first four parts of SHARE—*Showing* what you want people to see, telling the story to *Help* them, *Amplifying* what you want them to imagine, and *Relating* what you want them to feel—you're ready to make your story as *Enjoyable* as possible. How can you do that? By paying attention to *how* you communicate the story. The telling can take a good story and make it a great story.

I try to make the stories I tell exciting and fun because joy is contagious. Some of that joy I express physically, which I discussed in the Law of Visual Expression (chapter 11). But I also like to use humor. As somebody once said, laughter is like a windshield wiper. It doesn't stop the rain, but it helps us to keep going. If you're naturally funny, use that skill when you tell stories. If you're not, then find ways to have fun, because that will make your presentation fun for your audience.

I know how to have fun. And I like creating funny moments. One of the things I do when I travel with a tour group is lead the people I'm hosting to do the hokey pokey with me. And I always pick the most absurd places to do it: on a tank in the Golan Heights, on the bridge in Massachusetts where the Revolutionary War began, on a boat in front of the Eiffel Tower. It creates a great story *they* can tell others.

A way I love to have fun when I speak is pulling out one of my laminated cards and using it to tell a story or anecdote. In the Law of Content (chapter 6), I explained how I prepare my outlines for speaking. Most of the stories I tell are written into my outline. If it's a personal story, all I write is an asterisk and a phrase to remind me what to say. If it's an anecdote or funny illustration, it's pasted into my notes. But I also carry a group of laminated cards with me in my briefcase or jacket pocket when I speak. These are my tried-and-true go-to stories and humorous illustrations. I have told these stories so often I have them memorized. But I always read them. Why? Because I don't want to appear too polished. I want it to feel to my listeners like I'm reading it, experiencing it, and reacting to it for the first time *with* them.

What I always do before I read one of these cards is build it up. Comedian Bob Newhart said, "Tension is very important to comedy. And the release of the tension, *that's* the laugh."¹⁴⁰ For example, one of my favorite laminated cards is a piece by author Paulo Coelho called "Life Explained." When I pull out the card, I tell my audience, "You are about to understand life." That gets their attention. Understand life? Who can explain life? Then I say, "Tell the person you are sitting beside, 'You're about to understand life.'" I might play with them a little more while I hold the card. I want them to *see* that I'm about to read them something. Then I start reading slowly, using pauses occasionally to create greater anticipation:

On the first day God created the dog. God said, "Sit all day by the door of your house and bark at anyone who comes in or walks past. I will give you a life span of twenty years." The dog said, "That's too long to be barking. Give me ten years and I'll give you back the other ten."

So God agreed.

On the second day God created the monkey. God said, "Entertain people, do monkey tricks and make them laugh. I'll give you a twenty-year life span." The monkey said, "Monkey tricks for twenty years? I don't think so. Dog gave you back ten, so that's what I'll do too, okay?"

And God agreed.

On the third day God created the cow. "You must go to the field with the farmer all day long and suffer under the sun, have calves, and give milk to support the farmer. I will give you a life span of sixty years." The cow said, "That's kind of a tough life you want me to live for sixty years. Let me have twenty and I'll give back the other forty."

And God agreed again.

On the fourth day God created man. God said, "Eat, sleep, play, marry and enjoy your life. I'll give you twenty years." Man said, "What? Only twenty years? Tell you what, I'll take my twenty, and the forty the cow gave back, and the ten the monkey gave back, and the ten the dog gave back, that makes eighty, okay?"

"Okay," said God, "You've got a deal."

So that is why the first twenty years we eat, sleep, play, and enjoy ourselves; the next forty years we slave in the sun to support our family; the next ten years we do monkey tricks to entertain the grandchildren; and the last ten years we sit on the front porch and bark at everyone.

Life has now been explained to you.¹⁴¹

It always gets a laugh.

Bob Newhart is known for his comic timing. When asked about it, he said, "It's like a metronome inside your head. And you get to the punch line, and you're just about to deliver it, then it's just...." he

pauses, the silence hanging. “*Now!*”^{[142](#)}

Do your best to find ways to incorporate humor into your speaking, and especially in your stories, because humor can do so many things to improve your communication. Humor is efficient. You can get your point across with less verbiage when it’s funny. Humor also breaks down barriers. You will be amazed at the things you can say and the ideas you can sneak into people’s hearts and minds using humor. Laughter causes people to lower their guard. Using humor, we can approach difficult subjects in a nonthreatening way and make people think.

Storytelling can help you in every aspect of communication. Chuck Swindoll, a brilliant communicator, said, “Stories transport us into another world. They hold our attention. They become remarkable vehicles for the communication of truth and meaningful lessons that cannot be easily forgotten.”^{[143](#)}

I encourage you to use stories every time you speak. And be bold about it. Nothing makes a story go flat more quickly than a timid delivery. If you’re going to tell a story, be engaging and energetic. Become a great storyteller, because people see their own lives in stories. That’s the Law of Storytelling.

WHEN IT IS SAID

THE LAW OF THE THERMOSTAT

Communicators Read the Room and Change the Temperature

PRESIDENT HARRY S. TRUMAN SAID, “NOT all readers become leaders, but all leaders must be readers.”¹⁴⁴ I believe he was saying that good leaders are always growing, always learning, always reading books to improve themselves. But I believe as a leader he also knew that leaders are readers of other things as well: people, situations, trends, and opportunities.

Good communicators are similar. They are also readers. They not only read books and articles and consume information to continually learn, grow, and find ideas but also are capable of reading the room they’re speaking in. Furthermore, the best communicators can also transform the atmosphere in the room when they need to. That’s the Law of the Thermostat: communicators read the room and change the temperature.

SPEAKERS WHO CAN’T READ THE ROOM...

Have you ever been in an audience when something distracting occurs in the room, but the speaker or performer just continues, business as usual, even though the environment is keeping the audience from listening and staying with them? Maybe the temperature of the room is intolerable and everyone is suffering, yet the speaker never acknowledges it. Or music is blaring from the room next door, and everyone is getting irritated, but the person on stage pretends not to notice. Or someone in the audience experiences a medical emergency and is helped out of the room, and everyone in the audience is worried about them, but the speaker ignores it. Or the audience disengages out of boredom, yet the speaker drones on. It’s terrible. A speaker who can’t read the room is like a tone-deaf singer. His performance is ineffective, and it’s painful for everyone present.

Each of us possesses intuition in our area of gifting. My intuition and awareness are at their best when I am communicating; I can see all that is happening around me and sense what people are feeling in the room. But I also know that reading the room is a skill that can be learned—even by speakers who don’t possess a tremendous amount of natural talent. My desire is to help you develop that ability so that you can not only read the room but also change it to communicate more effectively.

THERMOMETERS AND THERMOSTATS

Bad speakers can’t read the room. Worse, they ignore it and the people in it when they speak. This disconnection may be because they’re so afraid that they can’t think of anything else. Or they may not

care enough about the people. Or they may put the responsibility for connecting on their audience instead of on themselves. Sadly, when bad speakers *do* notice that their communication isn't connecting, their most likely solution is to double down on content. But if people have already disconnected and aren't listening to the content, *more* content won't make the situation any better.

Good speakers can read the room. They're like a thermometer in that they can measure the temperature in the room. After they finish speaking, if their audience was unresponsive or acted negatively, they may think, *Tough crowd*. Or if the audience was warm and lively, they may think, *Wow, what a great audience!* Because they are good speakers, they know the temperature. But they are unable to change it.

Good communicators, on the other hand, are more like thermostats. Yes, they can read the temperature of the room the way a thermometer does, but they can do more. They are capable of *changing* the temperature. Communicators can take a cold room and make it warm and inviting so that people are enjoying the atmosphere. They can create a setting that's more conducive for communication. And because they can read the room *and* change the temperature, their communication is able to connect.

HOW TO READ THE ROOM AND RAISE THE TEMPERATURE

To help you move toward becoming a better communicator, I want to share seven practices that will enable you to grasp and practice the Law of the Thermostat.

1. Read the Temperature in the Room before People Arrive

In my speaking career of more than fifty years, I have communicated in more than a hundred countries and in just about every kind of setting you can imagine. In fact, as I write these words, I am in a hotel in Italy. Tomorrow I will fly to Romania to speak. After I arrive, I'll travel to the venue where I'll speak, and the first question I will ask is, "Can I see the room I'll be speaking in?" Why? Every auditorium, theater, sanctuary, ballroom, banquet hall, and conference room is different, and I always want to see the place where I will be communicating.

Because of my experience, I can look at a room and know immediately how conducive it will be to communication once it's filled with people. Here are the things I look for:

- **Lighting:** When I speak, I want plenty of light everywhere because the energy in a room increases with the amount of light. This can be a challenge. Many technicians want to make the room dark because they are used to working with performers. Actors, singers, and stand-up comedians need the focus to be on them, so technicians keep the stage light bright and the house lights down. That's not good for communicators. Yes, you want light on you because that creates energy in the room. But as communicators, we need to interact with the audience. That means we need to see the people, and they also need to be able to see each other. When you speak, get as much light as you can on you *and* keep the lights in the room up too.
- **Proximity:** I want to be close to the people when I speak. If the room is small, I'd prefer to be on the floor rather than up on a stage. In large rooms, my favorite stages have steps that go down directly to the audience, so that I can move down to the people to have a more personal conversation with them. I also don't want any barriers between me and the audience. I can't count the number of times I've entered an auditorium before speaking and found a row of plants lining the front of the stage. I always ask them to be removed. Even small barriers like those

send an unspoken message: “I’m up here, and you’re down there.” I want my message to be, “We’re in this together.”

- **Sound:** Few things are more frustrating for an audience than not being able to hear the speaker. Even the greatest communicator in the world can’t engage an audience if the people can’t hear him. Some of my greatest challenges as a speaker have come from terrible sound systems in hotels. It mystifies me that an industry that wants to generate income by renting space for events doesn’t install better systems in their facilities. If you get a chance before you speak, check the sound system to make sure it’s good. If you can’t check it ahead of time, then pay attention the moment you start speaking. If you suspect a problem, ask the people if they can hear you, so that the technical staff is aware of the problem and will work to solve it.
- **Screens:** If you will be speaking in a large room, there may be cameras tracking you and projecting your image on screens. These screens are your friends. Once audience members sit a certain distance from you, they no longer watch you directly. Instead, they watch the screen. Be aware of where they are and speak to the camera as well as the audience to maintain a connection and let people see your facial expressions.
- **Staging:** If you can see your room before you start speaking, you can make sure your space is set up the way you want. What works best for me is a barstool and high table beside it for my notes. I like to sit while I speak to be more conversational. But I also want to be able to get up and move around. Think about what you need and ask for it.

Here’s what I know: when everything is right in the room before the people come in to listen, the temperature goes up, and the odds increase for everything going right in the room when you deliver a message. But trust me, that doesn’t always happen. In over five decades of making presentations, I have experienced the good, the bad, and the ugly when it comes to environments!

One of the ugly times occurred in Nairobi, Kenya. When I arrived at the hotel, my host was excited because a crowd much larger than anticipated had shown up to hear me. That was the good news. The bad news was that the room he had reserved would not accommodate all those people. What was the host’s solution? To have me speak in the gigantic hotel lobby. Yes, the lobby, where people were walking in and out of the front door, arriving guests were registering, hotel staff was carrying luggage to and from five different elevators, and people were rushing through on their way to restaurants, meeting rooms, and the hotel’s amenities. Let’s just say the room was not in any way conducive to speaking. If all that wasn’t challenging enough, the space was made worse by five massive pillars that broke up the lobby. That meant less than half of the audience would have a straight view of me.

I knew from the start I was in trouble because the conditions were going to make connecting with the audience almost impossible. And I was not prepared mentally or emotionally to overcome such great challenges. But I had no choice but to do my best.

As I stood to address the crowd, my friend Tom Mullins, who was traveling with me, stood up, picked up his chair, and carried it to the front until he was only ten feet from me, in my direct line of sight. He sat down, pulled out his pen and notebook, looked at me with a big smile and said, “Talk to me, John. I’m so excited to hear you speak!” In that moment, everything changed for me. Tom, who is a fantastic communicator, knew what I was up against, knew I felt discouraged, and did the one thing he *could* do to help me. He *encouraged* me.

“Thank you, Tom,” I whispered, and began speaking. What a friend!

2. Know and Understand Temperature Indicators in the Room

It can help you greatly to gauge the physical circumstances in the room prior to speaking. And it's a tremendous help if you can make adjustments to create a more conducive environment before you speak. But there are also other indicators that will tell you whether the room is warm and ready to receive you or is cold and difficult as you step in front of your audience. Look at some of the factors that will tell you whether a room is warm or cold:

Cold Room

Formal Gathering

People Are Required to Attend

They Are Unfamiliar with You

They Are Unfamiliar with the Subject

You Are Uncomfortable

Warm Room

Informal Gathering

People Want to Attend

They Are Familiar with You

They Are Familiar with the Subject

You Are Confident

A few years ago, I was invited to speak to fifteen hundred leaders in Abu Dhabi as part of a one-day conference. I arrived midday while the conference was already in progress, so I was unable to examine the room before I was to speak. The best I could do was to take a quick peek into the room. What did I see? The front row of the room did not have seats; it had thrones. Not chairs that *looked* like thrones, but actual thrones for members of the royal family!

That may not sound like a big deal, but my subject that day was the *5 Levels of Leadership*, where I teach that the first and *lowest* level of leadership is position. I was about to walk on stage, face members of the royal family who were sitting on their thrones, and tell them and everyone else that positional leadership was only a starting point! I would explain that to develop *genuine* influence, they must build relationships, make the team productive, and add value to people. I knew the room was going to be formal and cold when I started speaking, so I spent a lot of time warming up my audience by connecting with everyone. Only after that did I start teaching my content.

3. Watch the People in the Room

In the Law of Anticipation (chapter 9), I discussed how to build excitement in an audience, which is something you should always strive to do. But you must also observe the reactions of people in the room from moment to moment *while* you are speaking. I call this having *20/20 communicator's vision*: seeing clearly who is there, how they are reacting, how they are responding, and how they are interacting with one another. That kind of vision comes from watching your audience, not staring at your notes. You must pay close attention to the people. How else will you know if you're getting through to them?

I start speaking by scanning the room. Are people leaning in and ready to learn? Or are they leaning back and showing little interest in me? I want to measure how they're feeling as I begin. While I'm observing them, I also know they are sizing me up, so I relax and sit on my stool. I smile. I tell them I'm glad to be with them. When I say to them my name is John and I'm their friend, I watch to see how they react. Do they appear open or skeptical?

As I continue, I tune in to people's facial expressions, posture, and body language. Even quick smiles, raised eyebrows, or small frowns can be revealing. If the atmosphere feels tense, I don't let myself get hijacked by negativity. I look for more ways to connect. I may use humor or express empathy, which usually reduces people's resistance.

As I speak, even though I'm focused on my audience, I'm also highly aware of the time of day I'm speaking, where I am in the schedule, and how long it's been since people have had a break. There are two things no speaker is good enough to overcome: hunger and full bladders. You simply can't compete with them. When most of the people in your audience are hungry or need to use the bathroom, you have to wrap it up and let them go. You never want your audience to be finished before you are. The moment your audience is finished, *you* are finished.

As soon as you *can* start observing the people you will be speaking to, you *should*. Recently, Jared Cagle (a member of my writing team) and I traveled to a young entrepreneurs' conference in Atlanta. The hosting organization's team met us as we arrived and took us backstage to the green room, where we would wait before I spoke. As we sat down, the team started to leave, but I stopped them, asking if they could stay with me a couple of minutes. I wanted to express my gratitude to them for making my communication possible, but I also wanted to get to know them. It didn't take long for us to share a connection, and I also started to get a feel for them and the audience I would be speaking to.

As we were chatting, the event's producer announced I had fifteen minutes before I would go onstage and said he would come back to get me when it was time. He looked surprised when I asked if I could enter the room right then so I could interact with the people. For those fifteen minutes, I met as many young leaders as I could, asked questions, and learned about them. By the time I was asked to speak, I felt I had a head start because I was confident that I had already read the room.

On the drive back to the hotel, Jared asked me questions about my communication. He is a valued contributor on my team, and he is always learning. One of the questions he asked was about reading the room. "What did you notice? And how did that change your communication as a result?"

"They were young and lacked experience. I could sense they wanted a father figure," I explained. Knowing that didn't change the content of what I said. What it affected was the way I delivered it. I took the tone of a loving father who believed in them and wanted to encourage and mentor them. Once you know what the people need, you can give it. And that really warms up the room.

4. Be 100 Percent Present in the Room

Communicating effectively requires every bit of a person's focus and energy. That's why it's so important to be totally present in the room whenever you speak. Otherwise, your audience might say, "It was a very moving speech; in fact, most of the people left before it was over."

When I speak, I give everything I have. I always treat it as my main event, the time of day when I must give 100 percent of my effort and focus. Despite this, there have been times when people left the room when I was speaking. But that didn't stop me from giving my best.

One of the most challenging speaking engagements, where I had a hard time being 100 percent present, occurred in Mexico City. When I speak to an audience whose primary language isn't English, my hosts typically handle it in one of two ways. Most often, they provide an interpreter on stage with me. I'll communicate a sentence or phrase in English, and the interpreter will translate it to the audience. It slows down communication, but I've gotten used to it with experience. The other method is to provide an interpreter who sits in a small booth at the back of the room with a microphone and transmits a simultaneous interpretation of my words to earpieces the audience members wear.

The planners of this event told me they would provide simultaneous interpretation. *No problem*, I thought. I was used to that. But as I stood up and started speaking, I heard a booming voice in Spanish over the sound system in the arena. I paused. When I spoke again, I heard the voice again, and I realized there was no booth or earphones. The simultaneous interpretation was live over the giant

sound system. Every time I spoke, I heard myself and the translator in a cacophony of sound. After about ten minutes of speaking, I started to panic. I wasn't sure I could do this all day.

More than anything, I didn't want to be present in that room. But I coached myself: *You can do this. You just have to make adjustments.* I stayed with it, found a rhythm of speaking that worked for me, and focused more on my audience. And I got to a place where I was truly okay with the situation.

Then I got diarrhea.

While I was speaking on stage, I could feel in my gut that I was in trouble. Literally! I had to go to the bathroom, but how could I pull that off? My feeling of panic became my motivation for creativity. On the fly, I decided to break people into small groups, and I gave them a question to answer and discuss. As soon as they started talking, I rushed off the stage and sprinted to the bathroom. The next two hours were the worst I have ever experienced as a speaker. Seven times I spoke a few moments and then broke them into small groups so that I could escape to the bathroom. Seven times! Between the jarring simultaneous translation and the diarrhea, I've never experienced a more difficult time when I did not want to stay in the room!

Unless you experience extreme extenuating circumstances, you need to stay in the room—mentally, emotionally, and physically. You need to be in the moment with your audience, making the most of it because you will never again be in that moment with that audience for that purpose. Be present. Give your all to connect with people. It has the potential to be magical. I have experienced times when the connection with my audience was so strong and so personal that I never wanted it to stop. You can experience that, too, but only if you're 100 percent present.

5. Interact with the People in the Room

In several chapters of this book, I have discussed the value of interacting with your audience and getting people to interact with each other. If you can get people to respond to you and talk with each other, you can warm up the room. Most miscommunication is the result of assuming your audience is with you when it isn't. When people interact, they're showing you where they are. When you connect, you know they're with you.

Because I often speak internationally, I'm very aware of language and cultural differences. You can't assume that expressions we use in English translate to other cultures. But here's the great thing. You can ask. For example, I may ask an audience if they have ever heard the expression, "It's lonely at the top." Their response determines if I use that expression while teaching them. But it has another positive effect. People find it endearing when you ask their opinion or advice. They want to help, and this gives them an opportunity to be on your side.

I love interacting with my audiences, and my rule of thumb is that the colder the room, the more I interact with people. I may ask a question and request people raise their hands in response. I may encourage them to shout out a response. I may get them talking to the person next to them. I may ask them to introduce themselves to others around them. I know not everyone loves this, but if I can get most of the people talking and having fun, it breaks the ice and warms up the room, even for the introverts. You need to understand: people won't like you as a communicator because they understand you; they will like you because they feel understood. Interaction allows that to happen and that raises the temperature of the room.

6. "Remarkableize" Your Communication in the Room

OK, I just checked my dictionary, and there is no such word as *remarkableize*. But there should be. Somebody has to be the first person to introduce a new word, so why shouldn't I give it a try? Let me

start by defining it. To remarkableize is to make something so unusual or special that people are surprised or impressed and take notice. As a communicator, I am always working to remarkableize what I say so that it becomes unforgettable to my audience.

Sometimes I do this by telling fun stories, like the time I was on vacation in Australia and, on a whim, decided to try to get into the Australian Open without having bought an advance ticket—something the locals said was impossible. I sent them pictures of me from my seat midcourt. Another time at a stadium event for men, I told the audience about my dad's lifetime of honorable service and asked him to stand up to be recognized. They gave him a five-minute standing ovation. There was also the time I was speaking and the music stand holding my notes kept slipping down, making everything fall on the floor. I turned it into a three-and-a-half-minute impromptu comedy routine. (Look for it on YouTube.)

You can use spontaneity and creativity to remarkableize your communication. Spontaneity will allow you to seize the moment, and creativity will empower you to maximize it. You can take a mistake and turn it into a memorable moment. Don't be afraid of looking foolish when unexpected things happen. Instead, harness them and look for opportunities to make your communication memorable.

7. Be Flexible—There May Not Even Be a Room!

Several years ago, I connected with Casey Crawford, the cofounder and CEO of Movement Mortgage, a fourteen-year-old organization that is already in the top ten retail mortgage lenders in the United States. Casey invited me to mentor the leaders of Movement Mortgage, which I've done the last several years. Recently the organization asked me to be the keynote speaker for a large gathering of their leaders in Cancun, Mexico. When I arrived at the resort and was ready to speak that first night, I found out where they planned for me to speak—not in a ballroom but on the beach.

When I got to the location, I immediately knew I needed to pivot. Hundreds of people were playing, swimming, and socializing around the bars. They were having a grand ole time, and there were way too many distractions for a traditional keynote speech. In addition, there were no seats, so I knew I needed to be succinct.

Adjusting quickly, I scrolled through my notes on my iPad. I took a single thought from my lesson that I knew would add the most value to them, and I put it on my iPhone. Then when they gathered for my speech, I connected with them, presented that thought, and asked them to share with someone standing beside them what they had learned and how they would apply it to their life. It worked because I was flexible.

The more speaking you do, the more flexible you must become. Over the years, I have spoken in a leper colony and at London's Royal Albert Hall. I've addressed audiences at the top of Mount Miguel in San Diego and in the dungeon where Jesus was held in Jerusalem before his crucifixion. I've spoken on the aircraft carrier USS *Enterprise* in the Atlantic Ocean and from a boat in a pond in southern Indiana. I've preached in cathedrals and country churches. I've spoken on a plane and at the Mayan ruins of Guatemala. I've communicated in stadiums and small studios. Each place was unique, requiring me to be flexible, adjust to my setting, and work to warm up the audience.

As a communicator, the first temperature you must set is always your own. You need to warm yourself up before you try to raise the temperature of the room. As you face challenges and work to succeed when things don't go as expected—and you can be sure those things *will* happen—do what I do. I...

Get Over My Situation.
Get After My Attitude.
Get Into My Adjustments.
Get On with My Mission!

Remember, it's not about you; it's all about your audience. Do what you must do to create the best experience you can for them in whatever circumstance you face.

Richard Stearns, former CEO of Lenox and Parker Brothers Games, as well as president emeritus of World Vision, has done extensive speaking and writing in his leadership career. He has analyzed the speaking of Martin Luther King Jr., and in his book *Lead Like It Matters to God*, he writes,

On August 28, 1963, during the historic March on Washington, Martin Luther King Jr. delivered one of the most famous and powerful speeches in American history. He had written out his text for the speech the night before, staying up until four in the morning working on it. But if you listen to recordings of this speech, toward the end before he launches into the rousing “I have a dream” refrain, there is a long pause. At that moment, when King looked at his notes, the next section of his remarks didn’t feel right to him. And he paused for a full ten seconds, thinking about what he should say next. During that pause, gospel singer Mahalia Jackson, who was standing behind him, said, “Tell them about the dream, Martin, tell them about the dream!” King had used his “I have a dream” language in earlier speeches, but he had not planned to use it that day. But during that long, ten-second pause, as he wrestled with what to say next, he listened. Then he launched into the soaring prose that would make history on that hot summer day.^{[145](#)}

Stearns says King shifted to “I have a dream” because he was a good listener who heard the words of Mahalia Jackson. I believe it was something more. Martin Luther King Jr. was not only an expert orator. He was also an expert at reading his audience, whether he was in a small room with a handful of people or on the steps of the Lincoln Memorial speaking to thousands. He possessed every one of the skills I describe in this chapter—plus many more. Few people possessed his ability. He not only read the room and changed the temperature of the crowd; he changed the temperature of the nation and the world. He was a master of the Law of the Thermostat.

THE LAW OF THE CHANGE-UP

Sameness Is the Death of Communication

A YOUNG PLAYWRIGHT GOT EXCITED when an important critic agreed to attend the opening of his new one-act play. On opening night, the critic arrived as promised and took his seat in the middle of the third row. The curtain rose, but within minutes the critic fell asleep and remained in that condition for the rest of the performance.

The playwright was crestfallen. As soon as the play ended, he dashed down to the critic's seat and said, "I'm sorry you couldn't stay awake longer. You *know* how much I wanted to get your opinion of my work."

The critic rubbed his eyes and with a yawn said, "Young man, sleep *is* an opinion."

There's an old saying: when the audience falls asleep, wake up the speaker! Even if your content is fine, your intentions are right, and your thesis is strong, if your audience isn't engaged, you need to change things up to get people engaged again.

Real-life playwright Alan Ayckbourn summed up the importance of keeping an audience engaged when he stated, "You're asking people quite often to sit in the same seat for two hours plus, with just a brief interval for drinks. You've got to give them a feeling that if they leave the auditorium at any second they're not going to be happy, because they want to know what happens next."¹⁴⁶ As a speaker, you bear the responsibility for keeping your audience excited and engaged, and you can do that using the Law of the Change-Up, because sameness is the death of communication.

EVERYONE LOVES VARIETY

How enjoyable is a play where nothing happens? How exciting is a football game that ends in a scoreless tie? How catchy is a song with no variation? How engaged are you when someone talks to you in a monotone voice during a conversation? These are situations we try to avoid, not ones we seek out. Why? Because sameness is boring. And forgettable. It's like having the same food, three meals a day, seven days a week, fifty-two weeks a year. We human beings crave change. We like variety. We love to be surprised. That's true in most of life, and it's especially true when it comes to communication. Nobody wants to hear a predictable and monotonous speaker, nor does anybody strive to be one. As communicators, we all want to keep our audiences sitting on the edge of their seats.

Changing up your delivery can make what you say unforgettable. What you say can be...

Extraordinary

Important

Noteworthy

Exceptional

Eventful

Significant

Enduring

Remarkable

Memorable

Meaningful

Lasting

Exciting

If you desire those words to describe your communication, then you must take responsibility for changing up your delivery and bringing life to your message.

As Americans, we're used to demanding our rights. We enjoy a right to free speech guaranteed by the First Amendment of the Constitution. But while speech is guaranteed, listeners are not. Your first responsibility as a speaker is to grab your audience's attention. Your next responsibility is to do what's necessary to keep it.

I delivered my first message to an audience when I was still in college. It was a fifty-five-minute speech to a group of thirty people. And it was *boring*! They may not have fallen asleep, but when I returned to deliver a message to that same group the next year, it wasn't the same group. Most of the people who had previously attended didn't come back to hear me. I don't blame them. I know I didn't make a good first impression.

As I gained experience as a speaker, I discovered I often lost the attention of my audience after about ten minutes. I knew I needed to improve somehow, or I wasn't going to become an effective speaker. One of the first things I did to change up my delivery was to walk around on the stage while I was talking. The first time I did it, I could see that my movement brought people's focus back on me. That caused me to start searching for other ways to change up my delivery. Today, I change up my delivery very intentionally. I alter my speaking tempo continually. I stand up from the stool I teach from. I move around. I raise my voice. I pause. I prompt my audience to interact with me and each other. I use facial expressions. I ask questions. I laugh at myself. I want people wondering what I'm going to do next. This is how I change up my rhythm.

Communication is like driving a car. You must change the movement of the car continually on the way to your desired location. As a driver, you must stay aware of the road and the other drivers around you. As conditions change, you must continually adjust to what's in front of you and around you. You must make turns, increase and decrease your speed, change lanes, shift gears, and occasionally stop. Auto manufacturers may succeed in inventing totally self-driving cars, where the driver does nothing, but that will never apply to communication. Every time you speak, you need to read your audience the way a driver reads the road, and you must change up your delivery to make your message effective. And if you want to become really great at communication, you need to keep learning, improving your skills, and adding additional change-ups to your repertoire.

In 2007, talk show host Charlie Rose interviewed Steve Martin, asking him questions about his memoir, *Born Standing Up*. Martin has had a long and highly successful career as a stand-up comedian, actor, musician, and writer. Along the way, he's won five Grammy awards, an Emmy, the Mark Twain Prize for American Humor, a Kennedy Center honor, and an honorary Academy Award. In the interview, Rose asked him about his advice for being successful. Martin responded,

Well, it really is this—when people ask me, say, “How do you make it in show business?” or whatever, and what I always tell them—I've said it many years and nobody ever takes note of it, because it's not the answer they wanted to hear. What they want to hear is, “Here's how you get an agent. Here's how you write a script. Here's how you do this.” But I always say, “Be

so good they can't ignore you." And I just think that if somebody is thinking, *How can I be really good?* people are going to come to you.¹⁴⁷

Martin was so good that he filled stadiums with his stand-up comedy routine in the seventies—the first comedian ever to do it. But it took him ten years before that to make his comedy routine really good, plus another five years to gather those kinds of crowds. But his approach to performing was the same as his approach to learning to play the banjo. When he started, he said he couldn't tell the difference between a C chord and a G. But he said, "If I just stay with it, one day I will have played for forty years." Not only did he learn to play, but he added three Grammy awards for playing music to his two Grammys for comedy.

WAYS TO CHANGE UP YOUR COMMUNICATION

You can bring that same kind of thinking to your communication. You can continually learn new ways to change up your presentation to keep your audience with you every step of the way. If you do, it will set you apart from other speakers and connect you to your audience. You can become so good they can't ignore you. Here are some ways to help you get there.

Use Movement and Facial Expressions

Let's start with the most basic technique, the one I started with: movement. Chris Anderson, the head of TED Conferences, advises new speakers to be careful about too much movement, but he's really talking about *nervous* movement:

The biggest mistake we see in early rehearsals is that people move their bodies too much. They sway from side to side, or shift their weight from one leg to the other. People do this naturally when they're nervous, but it's distracting and makes the speaker seem weak. Simply getting a person to keep his or her lower body motionless can dramatically improve stage presence. There are some people who are able to walk around a stage during a presentation, and that's fine if it comes naturally. But the vast majority are better off standing still and relying on hand gestures for emphasis.¹⁴⁸

Start by using your face and hands, as long as those movements are true to who you are. If you sense that people's attention is wandering, you might need to walk to a different spot on the platform. You can address one part of the audience and then move and address another. Or walk forward to close the distance between you and the people you're talking to. At times I've walked all the way into the audience to create greater intimacy when I wanted to make a point. I've also sat on the edge of the stage, or knelt, though I must admit, that was when I was younger, and my knees didn't hurt so much. Try different things, and pay close attention to the responses you get. As you experiment, you'll develop a sense of what works for you and what doesn't.

Understand and Practice Good Timing

It's very easy to tell you to "understand timing." It's much harder to explain how. If you are naturally gifted as a communicator, then you already possess intuition related to timing. Much of it is instinctive. But timing can be learned, and the more you practice speaking, the better you can become.

It's much easier to recognize bad timing than it is to create good timing. When a speaker's timing is off, you know it, like in the story of an old-time preacher giving a sermon on abstinence from alcohol. With great passion he said, "If I had all the beer in the world, I'd take it and pour it into the river." His listeners murmured their affirmation. "And if I had all the wine in the world," he continued, "I'd take it and pour it into the river." His audience continued to encourage him. "And if I had all the whiskey in the world," he thundered, "I'd take it and pour it into the river." Everyone shouted and cheered as he sat down.

With the sermon complete, the song leader stepped forward and without hesitation said, "For our closing, let's all sing 'Shall We Gather at the River.'"

To help you better understand timing, I'll tell you my definition of it: Timing is the art of regulating your speech and movement in relation to your audience to produce the best results. That includes using the right words, facial expressions, movements, tone, and interaction; with the best rhythm and speed; at the best time. I know this sounds complicated, but here are three things I do to help me with my timing. I believe they will also help you. I focus on

- What I *see*
- What I *say*
- What I *show*

Here's what I mean:

1. What I See Determines When I Speak

During my first speaking class in college, the professor suggested that we find a point on the back wall above the heads of our audience and fix our attention on that spot when we were on stage. What a terrible suggestion! I know what he was trying to do; he was trying to help people terrified by the idea of speaking to overcome their fear. But while that advice might have helped a reluctant speaker get on stage, it would not help anyone become a good communicator.

Good timing requires reading the room. You can't do that if you're fixated on your notes or refuse to make eye contact with the people you're talking to. Chris Anderson with TED Talks recommends finding five or six friendly looking people in different parts of the audience and making eye contact with them as you speak, thinking of them as friends you haven't seen in a while.^{[149](#)} Other experts recommend picking out people with fairly neutral facial responses, neither overly positive nor negative.^{[150](#)}

Once you're reading people's faces, you can change up what you're doing because much of good timing is a response to the reaction of your audience members. Do they look like they are enjoying what you're saying and want more? Are they losing interest and ready for you to move on? Do they look confused and in need of explanation? Is there high tension that needs to be relieved? Is emotional vulnerability making them ready to hear a truth or a call to action? Be proactive and alert and adapt to what you see.

Recently, I was speaking in Houston to two hundred entrepreneurs. I was the third speaker on the schedule, and when it was my turn to communicate, the audience had been sitting for more than two hours. When I stood up on the stage, I said, "My name is John, and you need a bathroom break. Come back in ten minutes." I received more thanks for the break than I did for my message. That's understanding timing!

2. What I Say Determines When I Speak

Another aspect of timing has to do with setting up your audience for something you want to say later. You can tell part of a story but withhold the ending until later. Or you can give a principle early and return to it later because it will have greater meaning after you've taught on it. You can do other things to build anticipation. For example, sometimes I'll say, "In a few minutes I'm going to share a life-changing principle with you." A few minutes later I might even play with the audience a bit, saying, "I'm about to give you that principle that can change your life" or "Are you ready to learn this life-changing principle?" After I see their response, I might say, "I don't think you're ready yet" or "You're almost ready." This keeps them eager and engaged. Use similar techniques, but just make sure you don't withhold the principle so long that people stop caring. And be sure when you present it that it delivers on your promise!

3. What I Show Determines When I Speak

Sometimes good timing means saying *nothing* at the right time. Recently I was privileged to speak at an event celebrating the twenty-fifth anniversary of my friend Chris Stephens. Before the event, Chris and I got to play a round of golf. On the fourth hole, Chris nearly made a hole in one, with his ball a mere foot from the hole. I was so excited for him that I asked him to lie down on the green beside his ball so I could take a picture. Then on the sixteenth hole, I almost made a hole in one! My ball was only four inches from the hole, so I asked Chris to take a picture of me beside my ball.

That night before I spoke, I gave the two pictures to the media team at the Knoxville Convention Center and prepped them for what I planned to do. As soon as I got onstage, I talked to the audience about how wonderful Chris was.

"Chris is not only a great leader. He's also a great golfer," I said, telling them about our golf game earlier that day. "He almost made a hole in one on his tee shot on the fourth hole!" As I spoke, the image of him with his ball went up on the big screen. The crowd erupted with cheers and applause. When the noise stopped. I said, "Just look how close he was to the hole!"

Then *my* picture came up on the big screen, with my ball even *closer* to the hole. That time I just looked at the screen and said nothing. After one look, the audience went wild. I just smiled and let the picture do the talking.

Practice the Pause

That brings me to the next thing you can do to change up your communication. Practice the pause. Mark Twain said, "No word was ever as effective as a rightly timed pause." I couldn't agree with him more.

I use the pause every time I speak, sometimes more than once. Some speakers are afraid of silence and fill it with nervous chatter. But not saying anything for a few seconds is one of my most effective ways to connect with an audience. It's also one of my most enjoyable moments of communication. There's an intimacy created by pausing, because silence gives people the time and space to respond in their minds and hearts. It's where they fill in the blanks and meet what I've said with their own thoughts, experiences, and conclusions. It can become an act of unspoken partnership. In such moments, silence truly is golden.

As you work to practice the pause, keep these thoughts in mind.

1. The Pause Can Emphasize What You're Saying

Silence can underline an important statement. Any time you stop, it gets people's attention and causes them to focus on what was just said. It makes them lean in. When you pause, let them linger there. Allow them to really dig in, to chew on what you said. When I read anything aloud to my audience, I emphasize important words by pausing. I purposely change my rhythm because it's a way of "underlining" a word or phrase.

Give this a try. When you're alone, choose a written piece you plan to use in a speech. Read it aloud in a monotone to get a sense of the message. Now, underline the parts you feel are important, and read it aloud again, emphasizing those words by saying them more slowly and forcefully. After you read a sentence or phrase that carries great meaning, pause completely. Can you hear the difference? The next time you speak, "underline" what you say using pauses, and watch people's reaction.

2. The Pause Can Give Your Audience a Chance to Catch Up with You

There are times when you speak that your audience needs a chance to catch up with you, an opportunity to process your words. Right now, I am mentoring Mark Cole, the co-owner and CEO of my company, in communication. He is very passionate and has the tendency to speak too fast and without enough variation. I recently encouraged him to have a stool onstage and to sit down a couple of times during a speech because I believed it would help him slow down. And it worked. Mark, the man with a mission who's always racing from place to place, became someone who settled down, relaxed, and allowed his audience to catch up with him.

If you're a fast talker, you need to slow down sometimes just to let your audience breathe. Don't be afraid of silence. Communication isn't meant to be an all-out sprint. It's meant to be an enjoyable journey.

3. The Pause Can Bring Your Audience Back to You

During any talk, the audience members' minds can wander. That happens even for the greatest of speakers. It's impossible to keep your audience with you 100 percent of the time. Pausing can help you bring the people back to you.

When I sense that my audience is mentally leaving me, sometimes I just stop speaking for a moment. Whether people are too focused on what they're writing, talking to another person, texting, or staring off into space, silence from the stage makes them think, *What just happened?* and they look up. A short pause brings some of them back to me. A long pause brings all of them back.

When you speak, you are a guide taking others on a journey. If they wander, don't plow ahead and leave them behind; wait for them. Silence draws them back to you and what you're saying.

4. The Pause Can Point to What You're about to Say

If pausing gets people's attention when their minds are wandering, it *really* gets their attention when they're already focused on you. When you stop talking for no apparent reason, your audience assumes there *must* be a reason. And they become very attentive.

Sometimes when I pause before saying something I want to emphasize, I also heighten the anticipation by doing something visually. I'll move forward and lean toward them. Or I'll walk down into the audience. Or I'll clap my hands. Or I'll raise my hand. Any of these actions makes everyone wonder what I'm *about* to do. For example, one of the concepts I teach is that everything worthwhile in life is uphill. Did reading those words capture your attention? *Everything worthwhile is uphill.*

Probably not. But if you *really* think about that truth, let it sink in, and apply it to your life, it can really help you. When I teach the concept to an audience, to help them really get it, right before I say the words, I pause and raise my arm up at an angle toward the ceiling. Then when everyone is wondering what in the world I'm doing, I say, "Everything worthwhile is uphill." And I pause again. Then I point down with the other arm and pause again. "Our problem is, we have uphill hopes but downhill habits." When I do this, I can watch people get it. I see the light bulbs go on. This may sound simple, but it works. Try pausing for emphasis and notice the impact.

5. The Pause Allows You to Reveal Your Emotions

I learned the power of the pause from watching Johnny Carson, the host of *The Tonight Show* from 1962 to 1992. He always opened his show with a monologue, and my favorite moments were when he told a joke that fell flat. When this happened, Carson would take the audience on a journey. He'd just stop talking. He'd show surprise on his face. He might look at his bandleader, Doc Severinsen, and shrug his shoulders. He'd look mystified, as if to say, "Where in the world did *that* joke come from?" And his studio audience would howl with delight. Often, he got greater laughs when a joke failed than when one worked. I used to watch his monologue just to see what he did after a joke bombed, and so did millions of others.

Silent moments are great opportunities to let people see your sense of humor. They are also great times to let people see your heart. If something is deeply meaningful to you when you're speaking, and it is genuinely choking you up, don't try to hide it. Simply pause until you can speak clearly. Most people feel empathy in those moments and identify with your passion.

6. The Pause Allows You to Pivot to What You Want to Say Next

I often use a pause to change direction in a message. After I say something heavy or serious, I might allow silence to help me transition to something lighter. I can also use it to go in the opposite direction. If I say something funny and I want to transition to something more serious, I'll use a pause. A pause can be good as a mood or subject changer.

7. The Pause Allows a Listener to Hear "the Whisper"

A well-timed pause can become extremely personal for someone in your audience. While everyone will witness the same pause, each individual may experience it differently. Writer and theologian Henri Nouwen said, "Silence is an act of war against the competing voices within us."¹⁵¹ Pausing allows people to hear their own most important internal voices, which is a whisper of truth. You may define this higher voice as the conscience, wisdom, or God, but it's a voice that whispers rather than shouts.

My friend Tim Elmore says, "Great communicators speak with power and clarity, and they know when to let silence speak for them." When you as a communicator stop speaking and allow each person to hear the whisper that can be heard only by them alone, the impact and benefit can be so much greater than any words you might say in that same moment. There are times as a speaker that I pause because I know the less I say, the more people will learn. This has been especially important when I've spoken about my faith because I believe we hear the most from God in the silence. As one of my favorite psalms says, "Be still, and know that I am God."¹⁵²

If you've never employed the power of silence in your communication, I hope you'll try the pause as a change-up in your speaking. It feels like a risk when you first try it. And there will be times it

doesn't do what you expect. Don't let that discourage you. Keep trying. It takes time to master the pause, but the more success you have with it, the more confident you will become, and the more effectively you'll use it as a change-up.

Create Interaction with Your Audience

The final advice I have for you related to the Law of the Change-Up is to create interaction with your audience, both among them and between you and them. I do this very intentionally during every presentation. I know that the more I involve people, the more I impact them. I already explained some of this in the Law of Connecting (chapter 7), where I tell people my name and ask them to tell me theirs. But I also use interaction in a lot of other ways.

Back when I used to host a leadership conference for pastors, I started my first session by naming each different denomination and asking people to raise their hands when I said theirs. For each group I made a good-natured joke, teasing them about some peculiarity they had. (Don't worry. I also had jokes about my own denomination.) As each group identified themselves, I'd make the respective remark and everyone would laugh.

Why did I do this? Because it was common for some pastors to focus too much on denominational differences. I was letting everyone know that we're on the same team and that our small differences shouldn't divide us. With everyone laughing, their defenses came down and they were ready to learn.

I'll say other things to the audience to get them engaged, such as, "Are you ready to learn something? Turn to your neighbor and tell them you're ready to learn." Or I'll say, "You are so smart. I can tell you understand what I'm teaching. You're getting it." Then I'll pause and say, "I've also noticed the person on your left is not as sharp as you. Look at the person beside you and say, 'It's OK. I'll help you.'"

People laugh and talk to one another. Or I'll even ask someone in the audience to help me. If I say something off the cuff that the audience loves, I might ask someone in the front row to write it down for me so I won't forget it. Afterward, they eagerly bring me their notes. Why do I do all this? Because interaction turns a speech into an experience.

Good communicators understand the power of interaction. So do good leaders and businesspeople. A few years ago, when I was in Istanbul, a group of us went to a restaurant called Nusr-Et. It is a steakhouse that has become world-famous. That night we met the owner, Nusret Gökçe, who started with that one restaurant in Istanbul and now has more than a dozen in cities around the world. They call him "Salt Bae." (*Bae*, pronounced *bay*, is slang for "before anyone else," meaning they're the number one person.^{[153](#)}) Why do they call him Salt Bae? Because he is such a showman, and he uses salt like an artist.

The night we ate at his restaurant, he came to our table, cut up our gorgeous steaks, and then sprinkled them with salt. But he didn't just *sprinkle them with salt*. He did something different. He used a change-up. He made a show of it. He raised his hand with coarse salt in it, and let it slip through his fingers, bouncing down his raised forearm, and onto the dish. We were captivated. When he was done, we all applauded him. But he wasn't actually done! He gave each of us a chance to try his salt technique. We all took videos of one another making our amateur attempts. It was such fun.

That is a meal none of us will ever forget. Why? Because Salt Bae made it an unforgettable experience by doing something unexpected. He created interaction with us and with one another. The food was great. But the interaction was even better. It has made him famous. Look him up on YouTube and you'll see why he has tens of millions of views!

Salt Bae found his way of interacting as a communicator. You need to find yours. If you can turn your communication from a speech into an experience, it will become unforgettable.

People who study communication know there is a direct correlation between unpredictability and impact. Matt Abrahams, a Stanford Graduate School of Business lecturer and coach, says, “Even just a 10 percent increase in vocal variety can have a highly significant impact on your audience’s attention to and retention of your message.”¹⁵⁴ If you want people to pay attention to what you say, be less predictable. Change things up!

The more variety you bring to your communication, the more engaged your audience will be, and the more they will enjoy the journey as you take them where they need to go with your message. Audiences don’t want to just sit by passively as you talk. They want to be a part of the experience. That can happen only if you keep them with you. Never forget that sameness is the death of communication. That’s the Law of the Change-Up.

WHY IT IS SAID

THE LAW OF ADDING VALUE

People May Forget What You Say, But They Never Forget How You Make Them Feel

ONE OF THE HIGHLIGHTS OF speaking is getting to meet wonderful people. I was once on the same program with Maya Angelou, the poet and civil rights activist. My time in the green room was unforgettable because her warmth was engaging, her stories were captivating, and her words were insightful. But above all, her persona made an indelible impression on me. Even though she was a larger-than-life figure who knew presidents, TV and movie stars, and civil rights icons, her focus as we talked was on me. She expressed admiration for my work and said it had helped her. I was shocked. I had no idea that she even knew who I was. She also asked me questions about my family, my interests, and my latest writing project. She encouraged me to keep adding value to others and expressed her hope we could meet again. Regretfully, soon after our time together she passed away.

That day I left the green room empowered by her presence. Big people make us feel bigger, and that's exactly how I felt. And it's why I've used a quote often attributed to Angelou as the description of the Law of Adding Value: people may forget what you say, but they never forget how you make them feel.

HOW I LEARNED TO VALUE PEOPLE

To practice the Law of Adding Value as a communicator, you must do two things. First, you must live good values. Living good values enables us to value others. It keeps our motives right. It allows us to do the right things. When we live good values, we have something good to give. It also empowers us to do the second thing, which is adding value to people. Doing the right things, for the right reasons, with and for people, adds value to them. When a speaker and his message add value to people, great communication can happen.

How does a person come to understand the importance of adding value? Every person's experience is unique. I want to share mine with you in the hope that it will stir the desire to add value to others if you don't already possess it. I learned this lesson from a few key people and experiences, and I want to share them with you now.

1. My Father's Example

Dad was a people person. He loved people, and they loved him. He never rushed when he was around people. He walked slowly through crowds, stopping often to hug someone or to say a few words of encouragement. The more I walked with him and watched him, the more I wanted to be like him.

I remember a conversation I had with Dad in his office when he was ninety. One of the things he said was, “Son, isn’t it wonderful that the older we get, the more we love people?” I had to laugh. Because Dad genuinely loved and valued people, he thought everyone else did. Age exaggerates our qualities, both good and bad. But I’ve known people who *disliked* people more as they got older. But that wasn’t my dad, and that’s why he was always my hero. The best advice he ever gave me was on my graduation day from college. He said, “Every day, value people, believe in them, and unconditionally love them.” He embraced those values and lived them every day, and I saw the results. His was great advice that I’ve tried to live for more than fifty years. And I hope as I get older, my love for people will continue to grow every day the way his did.

The values lesson I learned from Dad? How I value people determines how I view them. That’s a lesson you need to learn and take to heart if you want to add value to people.

2. My Zig Lesson

When I was in my twenties, I went to hear Zig Ziglar speak for the first time, and I heard him say something that grabbed my attention. “If you will help people get what they want, they will help you get what you want.” That was a life-changing idea for me because until that time, I focused more on how people could help me. I expected them to help me first, and then I would be willing to help them. That day I started to experience a shift. I made adding value to people my number one priority—without expecting anything in return.

Good speakers put their audience first. As I said in the Law of Connecting (chapter 7), communicators know it’s all about others. But good leaders and businesspeople know the same thing, and they put others first. A good example is Jeff Bezos, the founder of Amazon. He believes Amazon’s growth has been extraordinary because the company puts customers first. In fact, “Customer Obsession” is the first of the leadership principles listed on Amazon’s website:

Leaders start with the customer and work backwards. They work vigorously to earn and keep customer trust. Although leaders pay attention to competitors, they obsess over customers.^{[155](#)}

People who add value to others always put others first. They do it because it’s right, but they also do it because it makes sense. It doesn’t matter what profession you practice:

- **Salespeople:** If customers believe you have their best interest at heart all the time, they will seek you out when it comes time to buy.
- **Speakers:** If audience members know it’s all about them and not about you, they will embrace you and your message.
- **Managers:** If you are kind and encouraging when giving corrective feedback, employees will work harder to make positive change.
- **Writers:** If your words are filled with hope and help, readers will seek out your advice and keep turning the pages.

- **Leaders:** If you build trust and make people feel important, they will help you accomplish your goals and lift your leadership load.

The values lesson I learned from Zig is this: always put others first. *Always!* If you want to practice the Law of Adding Value, you need to put people first.

3. My Hot Stove Lesson

In *Following the Equator*, Mark Twain wrote, “We should be careful to get out of an experience only the wisdom that is in it—and stop there; lest we be like the cat that sits down on a hot stove lid. She will never sit down on a hot stove lid again—and that is well; but also, she will never sit down on a cold one anymore.”¹⁵⁶ That is great advice, but it’s sometimes hard to embrace.

When I was in my twenties, I had a hot-stove experience with a member of my staff. I was a young leader, and I poured myself into developing this staff member. I mentored him and I loved him. But then I had to fire him. It was so traumatic for me. Afterward, I said to myself, “That will never happen to me again.”

I continued leading, but I kept everyone at arm’s length. I built walls to protect myself from further hurt, and as a result, I stopped investing in people. After a few months, I realized that through this process of disconnecting, I valued and loved people less. I was distancing myself because I had experienced trauma, but if I stayed on that same course, my life would become a tragedy. I had to get over my hot-stove experience and begin to love and value people again. It took some time, but I regained my trust in others.

The values lesson I learned was not to allow a bad experience to become a lifetime experience. You must allow others to get close to you to add value to them.

4. My Enron Lesson

In 2000, a lot of companies went under when it was discovered that their leaders had lied about their company’s success and engaged in unethical accounting practices. The headliner was Enron, an organization that trumpeted its great values while at the same time deceiving employees and investors. The company lost \$74 billion in value, bankrupting investors, many of whom were employees with their life savings invested in Enron stock.¹⁵⁷

In the wake of these scandals, my publisher asked me to write a book on business ethics. I wasn’t sure I could do it. First, I believe there’s no such thing as “business ethics”—there’s just ethics. Second, I had built everything in my life on my faith. How could I write a book on ethics without faith and deliver it to a culture that didn’t believe in truth or absolutes?

Exploring this issue caused me to discover the enduring value of good values. They are the foundation on which ethical people build their lives. Without a foundation of good values, people ignore rules and break laws. But with good values they not only obey laws but value others. The key was the Golden Rule, a value present in every culture and religion: “treat others as you would want others to treat you.” With that conviction, I wrote *Ethics 101*. And years later, I created the Maxwell Leadership Foundation to teach good values because when people learn and live good values, they are better able to add value to their communities, their families, and even to themselves.

The values lesson I learned is that good values are more powerful than rules or laws for helping others. If you want to practice the Law of Adding Value, build your life on a foundation of good values.

5. My Walk with Jesus

I don't want to offend anyone who isn't a person of faith, but I feel compelled to write about the final source of the lessons I learned on good values. If talk about faith offends you, then please skip ahead. But let me first tell you this: you don't need to be a believer in Jesus to learn from his life.

One of the things that always stood out to me from reading the Gospels was how Jesus valued *everyone*. He valued people who were not valued by others. He loved a cheating tax collector named Zacchaeus. He loved a Samaritan woman whom other Jews would never have spoken to. He loved a woman caught in adultery whom the law said should be stoned. He loved lepers and other outcasts. He loved the thief who died next to him on the cross. While religious people wrote all of them off, Jesus wrote them into his story. While the traditional leaders built religious walls to exclude people, Jesus built relational bridges to include them.

Learning from Jesus, I realized I can't be like him unless I love everyone. That includes people who don't look like me, act like me, think like me, or believe like me. As a result, I try to love everyone every day. And when I speak, I try to show my audience how much I value them and care about them.

The values lesson I learned from Jesus? Value everyone. If you want to add value to people in such a way that they never forget how you make them feel, then you need to value everyone too.

PRACTICES FOR ADDING VALUE TO OTHERS

I hope understanding my journey has helped you. Each of the lessons I learned helped change my heart and my attitude toward people. If you embrace them, you will want to embrace people. But you need to do more than *want* to add value to people. You must also take action. Here are six ways you can get started practicing the Law of Adding Value.

1. Focus on Sowing, Not Reaping

Human beings are all selfish by nature. It takes effort to change our focus from receiving to giving. Most people begin their day wondering, *What will I receive today?* People who add value to others instead ask, *What will I give today?* They focus on the seeds they will sow, not the harvest they hope to reap.

If you have any experience with farming or gardening, you know sowing is all about planting seeds now so there will be a harvest in the future. If every day I focus on sowing by adding value into the lives of others first, then reaping a harvest will become automatic. But it often comes later. For a half century, I have intentionally added value to others, thinking in terms of sowing, hoping for a return someday—for them, their families, and their communities. What I didn't expect was to be a beneficiary myself of that sowing. I'll tell you about that later in this chapter.

2. Be Aware That How You View Things Is How You Do Things

Everything we do in life is colored by our point of view. Our perspective influences our beliefs, and our beliefs determine our behavior. For example, if we possess a scarcity perspective, we think in terms of *What can I spare?* which tends to make us stingy. But if we possess an abundance perspective, we think, *What can I share?* and we are more likely to be generous.

Similarly, how we view people affects how we treat people. If you don't see people positively, you won't treat them well. If you think a particular group is unpleasant or difficult, you won't value them. For example, when I speak on leadership at companies, if a Q&A is part of the session, I am

sometimes asked, “How can we work with millennials?” Often, I can sense the questioner’s attitude toward the millennial generation isn’t positive.

It’s not unusual for there to be a perspective gap between generations of workers, so you have to find a way to bridge it. My answer to the question is to value them. Value their differences and embrace them, because how you view them determines what you will do with them. My baby boomer generation expects others to commit themselves to a job or organization once they *understand its purpose or philosophy*. Millennials commit once *they feel understood*, and not before. And the only way to make them feel understood is to listen to them and value them.

Recently, I did a session about millennials to help an organization work more effectively with them. Here is part of the message:

1. Millennials don’t just work for a paycheck; they want a purpose.
2. Millennials are not pursuing job satisfaction; they are pursuing development.
3. Millennials want responsibility faster than you want to give it.
4. Millennials don’t want bosses; they want coaches.
5. Millennials don’t want annual reviews; they want ongoing conversations.

I think all these desires are valid and reasonable. They have the potential to improve the work environment. When I consider them, I like millennials. I think I might even want to become one!

Seriously, though, if you can find common ground with people and appreciate their differences, it becomes easier to see them in a positive light. And you’re more likely to treat them well and add value to them.

3. Put a “10” on People’s Heads

Perhaps the most effective action I take in valuing people is to put a “10” on everyone’s head. By that, I mean I assume every person is a 10 out of 10 when I meet them. Why? Because everyone deserves a good start. When I walk out on a stage and look at the crowd, I see a sea of 10s. I choose to expect the best of people. I believe every person is worth helping, can apply my message, and will benefit from doing it.

When we first meet people, our natural inclination is to size them up. We tend to rate their abilities and measure their liabilities. Unfortunately, once we’ve evaluated them and given them a score in our minds, we often hold on to these assumptions and are reluctant to revise them. But that means we can miss the talents of people we have evaluated based on superficial information. It’s better to believe in people and give them the benefit of the doubt than to judge them. Assume they are 10s until their actions prove otherwise.

I love the way my friend Horst Schulze does this. He was a founding member of the Ritz-Carlton hotel company, and for many years he served as its president and COO. As a young apprentice hotelier, he developed this philosophy: “We are ladies and gentlemen serving ladies and gentlemen,”¹⁵⁸ which eventually became the motto of the Ritz-Carlton hotel company.¹⁵⁹ I admire that the phrase reflects the respect Horst has for the value and dignity of both his employees and his guests. That perspective had created the foundation for the organization’s exceptional service and business success.

You cannot go wrong treating everyone with dignity and respect, believing they’re 10s when you meet them. Or with adding value to people. You have nothing to lose and a lot to gain.

4. Lift Your Likability Level

People are reluctant to receive anything from people they don't like, so it's important to be likable as a communicator. If people like you, they will listen to you, and they will allow you to add value to them. If they don't like you, they will ignore you or discount your message.

How do you become more likable? By caring about people and serving them. By wanting more *for* them than you want *from* them. People can tell if you're there for them or just for yourself. As author and speaker Simon Sinek says, "People don't buy WHAT you do, they buy WHY you do it."¹⁶⁰ I tell leaders they need to love their people before they try to lead them, because that helps them get their motives right. The same is true for speakers.

Think about your favorite teacher, your closest friend, or the best boss you've ever had. What qualities do they have in common? I bet one of them was a willingness to put your interests ahead of their own. They focus on you, not just themselves. And that's what it takes to be likable. That's the reason I always try to sign books at public appearances. It's a chance to add value. It gives me a moment to have a personal touch with people. My guess is that I have signed nearly one million books over forty years of writing. And while people may forget what I say to them as we interact, I hope they feel valued and the memory of that lasts.

5. Express Disappointment When You Can't Add Value to People

As I've said, I always try to add value to people when I speak or host an event. But I don't always succeed in accomplishing my vision. For example, in 2019, the Maxwell Leadership organization hosted Exchange in London. Exchange is an annual three-day intensive leadership event where I teach one hundred thirty leaders and give them leadership experiences to broaden their horizons and improve their leadership. The location changes each year, and we choose the experiences based on the city. We always pull out all the stops. For example, in and around London, here are the things our attendees enjoyed:

- A tour of London via the Thames River with a stop at the famous re-creation of Shakespeare's Globe Theatre, where we met its director and were able to ask him questions
- An interview with former prime minister Tony Blair
- A private tour of the Churchill War Rooms followed by a Q&A with Winston Churchill's grandson, Sir Nicholas Soames, who served as a member of Parliament for thirty-five years
- A surprise trip to Windsor Castle (via the Belmond British Pullman Train while enjoying tea), which included entry through the quad and the Coat of Arms room; a reception in the Waterloo Chamber hosted by Prince Michael of Kent, Queen Elizabeth's first cousin; and dinner in St. George's Hall, complete with entertainment by the opera singer who performed during the procession at a royal wedding
- An after-hours reception at the Tower of London with a private viewing of the Crown Jewels and a discussion of the Tower's history with its protectors, the Beefeaters
- A surprise dinner at the top of Tower Bridge, offering unparalleled views of the city's skyline at night

I know that sounds incredible. And it was! The attendees were blown away. But on our last day as they gathered for my final lesson, I felt disappointed. Why? Because the leadership experience I most wanted to give them was the one we were unable to pull off: an experience featuring John Wesley, the transformational leader who was a catalyst for making slavery illegal in England.

Wesley was a mentor of William Wilberforce, who spent his life in Parliament dedicated to ending the slave trade. I wanted to take the group to the Wesley Museum to show them the desk where he wrote the books that influenced the way many people in England thought. I wanted them to sit at the organ where Charles Wesley, John's brother, had played some of the thousands of hymns he wrote. I wanted to teach them about transformation from Wesley's pulpit and challenge them to live a life of significance. I thought this would be the most transformative experience I could give them, but we simply could not make it happen. The museum would not accommodate a group our size. We begged, pleaded, and offered financial donations, but they rejected every request.

In our final Exchange meeting, rather than keeping my disappointment to myself, I decided to share it with everyone, even though it made me cry—and many cried along with me. Why would I do that? Because I wanted to demonstrate a leadership lesson, one that they would also carry back in their leadership of others. I wanted them to know how much I as their leader wanted *for* them. Even though I felt the loss of not giving them that experience, I wanted them to know how much I had wanted to add value to them.

6. Run a Different Race

Physicist Albert Einstein once said, “Gentlemen, try not to become men of success. Rather, become men of value.”¹⁶¹ I believe Einstein was describing two different kinds of lives that people can choose to live, two different races they can run. Most people chase success. Einstein was calling people to add value to their world.

I have tried to run that different race, and I encourage you to do that too. It may appear to some that we finish last instead of first, but that's a misunderstanding of the race we're running and how we define winning. When the race we run is about others, then when they finish ahead of us, that's a win for us.

I was in my late fifties when I started thinking more about this, and at that time I wrote a prayer that I hoped would help me remember my decision to be different:

Lord, as I grow older, I would like to be known as...

- *Available* rather than a hard worker.
- *Compassionate* more than competent.
- *Content*, not driven.
- *Generous* instead of rich.
- *Gentle* over being powerful.
- *A listener* more than a great communicator.
- *Loving* versus quick or bright.
- *Reliable*, not famous.
- *Sacrificial* instead of successful.
- *Self-controlled* rather than exciting.
- *Thoughtful* more than gifted.

I'm now in my midseventies, and I still pray this today because I'm still working on becoming that person. I'm still trying every day to run a different race.

ADDING VALUE IS A BOOMERANG

When I first read *Servant Leadership* by Robert Greenleaf, I learned that when leaders serve first, they can make a real difference. I embraced this thought, and by the time I wrote *The 21 Irrefutable Laws of Leadership*, I expressed it in the Law of Addition, which says leaders add value by serving others. Good leaders are servants. So are good communicators. They serve people because they value them. What I didn't know as a young man was that adding value to people acts like a boomerang. If I had heard this idea when I started out, I would not have understood it. Today, it makes perfect sense to me.

If you add value to others without seeking a return (what I referred to as sowing earlier in this chapter), you do, in fact, eventually get a return. That was a major surprise to me. Here's the difference between what I *thought* and what I *got* when it came to serving others:

What I *thought*: Serving others is the right thing to do.

What I *got*: A heart that serves because it values people.

What I *thought*: Serving others is seldom noticed.

What I *got*: My service was noticed, and it became part of my identity.

What I *thought*: Serving others has very little return.

What I *got*: The ROI of serving others is extraordinary.

What I *thought*: Serving others is a private action.

What I *got*: Serving others is a contagious action.

What I *thought*: Serving others helps them become successful.

What I *got*: Serving others helps *me* become successful!

I've worked to sow into the lives of others for many decades. Now, as a man in my midseventies, the harvest I'm reaping is ridiculously generous! I know I don't deserve it... but I'm certainly grateful for it.

I hope you will make it your goal to add value to people when you speak—and when you are off the stage. Do it to *make them better*. And don't be surprised if you eventually receive rewards for your efforts long before you're in your seventies. And never forget: people may forget what you say, but they never forget how you make them feel. That's the Law of Adding Value.

THE LAW OF RESULTS

The Greatest Success in Communication Is Action

WHY DO YOU WANT TO become a better communicator? You may be thinking, *I'm reading the last chapter of this book, and only now you're asking me that question? Isn't it a little late?* My answer is no. The big misses in communication occur when people speak for the wrong reasons, so it's never too late to think about why you want to speak. You'll notice, the last two laws in this book are in a section called "Why It Is Said." These final two laws provide the answer. If your motive for speaking is anything other than adding value to people and moving them to take positive action that will help them, you're missing the boat.

Good leaders want to influence people to take action, make changes, and achieve goals to make the world a better place. Good communicators want the same things. That's one of the reasons good communication skills are foundational for effective leadership. If you can't cast vision, show people a way forward, give them a road map, and inspire them to action, you will have a difficult time leading them.

Think about the communication skills of Winston Churchill challenging the people of England to never give up and never surrender during World War II. Or Martin Luther King Jr. advocating for the rights of oppressed Black people and sharing his dream for a better world. Or John F. Kennedy's speech announcing the intention to put a man on the moon. Or Nelson Mandela's speech for his presidential inauguration seeking to unite South Africa. What distinguished these powerful leaders and communicators from other, more ordinary speakers? They mobilized people. Their communication led to action. Their speaking accomplished what my teachers challenged us to do as I studied theology in undergraduate and graduate school: preach for a verdict. Good communicators move their listeners to action. And if you want to take your communication to the highest level, that's what you need to make your goal. The greatest success in communication is action. That is the Law of Results.

ACTIONS THAT INSPIRE ACTION

Founding Father Ben Franklin said, "Well done is better than well said,"¹⁶² but I bet he also knew that well said can be the catalyst for well done. When people believe they have the ability to take action and to see results, then they feel empowered to act. If no action comes as a result of communication,

then the message never really leaves the stage. If you want to avoid that, then you need to embrace these four actions as a communicator.

1. Be Committed to Action Yourself

How committed are you to what you speak about? I started this book with the Law of Credibility: the most effective message is the one you live. That's where communication starts. It continues with your continued committed action. If you are moved to act, your audience will be moved. If you put into practice what you teach, people will trust you and be inspired by you. It's not enough to be inspirational in your speech. Your enthusiasm may motivate and excite people to think about their dreams, but it won't be sufficient to move people to action. People want an example of someone who has lived it.

This is one of the main reasons I tell my audiences my own stories. I don't do it to brag or feed my ego. I'm not a perfect model, because I've made plenty of mistakes. I do it because I want people to know I've applied to my own life what I'm teaching them. I want to take them along on my journey, and I've discovered that telling them my story accomplishes that. Does everyone respond well? Most do, but not all. Once, when I was teaching the importance of personal growth, I encouraged everyone listening to develop their own growth plan. Getting older may be automatic, but growth is not. I wanted them to become intentional about learning.

After my session, a man came up to me and wanted to know the details of my personal growth plan. I briefly explained what I do every day to develop myself, and when I was finished, he said, "I don't like your growth plan."

"That's OK," I answered. My way isn't the only way. I figured maybe he had something better, so I asked, "What's your plan?"

"I don't have one," he replied.

"Then I like my plan better," I responded.

For a second he just looked at me, but then he broke out laughing. "You're right," he chuckled. "I'm going to get one." I hope he did.

Your credibility as a communicator comes from backing up with action the words you say for inspiration. You can teach anything you know, but you reproduce only who you are.

2. Reframe the Way People Think

Most people have good intentions, but many don't take action, and that inaction often leads to regret. Psychologists surveyed a random group of adults and asked them this question:

When you look back on your experiences in life and think of those things that you regret, what would you say you regret more, those things that you did but wish you hadn't, or those things that you didn't do but wish you had?

They discovered that 75 percent of the people had more regrets for the actions they had *not* taken than for the ones they had.^{[163](#)} As a communicator, one of your goals should be to help people reframe their thinking so that they shift their mindset from good intentions to intentional actions.

Intentionality and commitment are essential for anyone who wants to achieve something of value. Have you ever asked someone to do something, and their response was, "I'll try"? It's a wishy-washy answer, isn't it? The implication is that they'll give *some* effort. Will they give the absolute minimum? Will they take only the first step and do nothing more just to be able to say they tried? Will they just go through the motions? Or will they give it all they've got?

When you help people shift their mental framework from *trying* to *doing*, it changes their attitude. When they become committed to doing, they have the potential to change their lives because commitment brings dedication, resolve, tenacity, and perseverance.

Professor Juan Carlos Pastor of IE University writes about what a master Steve Jobs was at helping people reframe their thinking. Pastor says this of a speech Jobs gave in 1997 when he returned to Apple after a twelve-year absence:

Effective leaders help followers to define problems in a new way and propose alternative paths to action. Steve Jobs, one of the most charismatic orators of recent times, exemplified this quality in his speeches. He did not design any devices or do any software coding. He was the orchestra conductor who helped his team to think differently. In a famous 1997 speech at Macworld Boston, when Apple seemed to be completely defeated by Microsoft, he advocated a radical change in Apple's strategy by reframing the way they thought. He asked his employees not to focus on beating Microsoft but on making Apple great. This reframing in the way of thinking marked Apple's turnaround in the following years.^{[164](#)}

Jobs changed the goal for Apple employees and helped them to believe they could—and would—achieve it. This moved their thinking from trying to doing. That's what good communicators do. They help their audience understand that success comes to those who do today what they were thinking they might do someday.

3. Make Taking Action Seem Irresistible

Early in my communication career, I spoke because I wanted to help people understand. My focus was on knowledge. It took me a few years to realize there was another level of effectiveness in communication I should be reaching for. I recognized that understanding changes *minds*, but only action changes *lives*. That's when I made moving people to action my new goal.

There's a paradox to the way understanding and action work. Most people want answers before they act. They desire understanding. What they don't realize is that often we must take action to find answers. An unwillingness to move before having all the answers keeps people from making the breakthroughs they desire.

This resistance to action before knowledge is as old as humanity. Ancient Greek playwright Sophocles wrote, "One must learn by doing the thing; for though you think you know it you have no certainty, until you try."^{[165](#)} With this in mind, I started asking myself how I could make taking action irresistible. I wanted to create an appetite for it, to help people overcome what author and medical doctor Michelle May calls the *When-Then* lie: "When (something happens), then (I'll do, feel, or be something different)."^{[166](#)} I wanted to create urgency in my audience to *do* something *before* they had all the answers.

Appealing to what motivates people in an audience requires more than a simple call to action. It requires you to paint a picture of the positive outcome they will experience once they *take* the suggested action. If you put them in the picture and help them see themselves succeeding, they can imagine how good it will make them feel to take action.

That's one of the things I do as I communicate for my nonprofit organizations, EQUIP and The Maxwell Leadership Foundation. Both are committed to helping countries experience transformation by teaching good values to people in small-group settings. One of my responsibilities as a communicator for these organizations is to inspire people to become facilitators of these values-

based transformation tables. You already know from reading the Law of Preparation that I want people to see their possibilities, know their value, feel empowered, and desire to act. As I speak to these potential facilitators, I want them to see themselves as successful individuals contributing to their companies, communities, and ultimately country as change agents. I want them to know they have value and can add value to others around them. I want them to feel empowered to go out and lead others not only because of my belief in them but also because of the training and encouragement they will receive. And I want them to feel so excited that they can hardly wait to get started. Often, they are. At these events, attendees sign up in droves to become leaders of transformation tables. As a result of their decision to act, millions of people in Guatemala, Paraguay, Costa Rica, the Dominican Republic, and Papua New Guinea are embracing good values.

Over the years, I've watched a lot of speakers try to mobilize their audiences to action. Some try to do it through positional power. They try to make people feel obligated to act, like a CEO or manager telling employees they *must* take a certain action if they want to remain employed. Other speakers try to challenge them with an I-bet-you-can't-do-this message, like the professor who stands in front of his students on the first day of class and says he gives out only one A every semester. But I believe the best communicators help people to feel empowered and encouraged to act.

4. Use Communication to Create a Bridge to Action

As compelling as your message may be, and as motivated and empowered as your audience may feel, you still need to help people cross over from inaction to action. How can you do that? By building verbal bridges to where they want to go.

Put the Bridge Right in Front of Them

A bridge is of no use to anyone if they can't find it. When you speak, make action as easy to access as possible. Sometimes it's as simple as giving directions. Malcolm Gladwell writes about this in his book *The Tipping Point* when he describes an experiment conducted by psychologist Howard Leventhal at Yale University. Leventhal wanted to see how many of his seniors he could convince to receive a tetanus vaccine at the university's student health center, but because he was a psychology professor, he was also interested in seeing how their motivation would be impacted by different approaches to getting them there. As part of his experiment, he gave students different versions of a seven-page booklet about tetanus. One was a "high fear" version with graphic descriptions and color photographs of people suffering from the disease, while the other simply included information.

What surprised Leventhal was that only 3 percent of his students took action to receive the shot. Furthermore, the ones who did came equally from both groups. So he did the experiment again, but this time he included a map of the campus with the location of the health center circled, and he included the center's hours of operation. The result was that 28 percent of his students got the shot, with the students again coming equally from both groups.¹⁶⁷ All they needed was someone to put the bridge right in front of them so that they would be more likely to use it.

Start Them at the Beginning

To get people moving, you have to show them the end result and paint the picture of their better future if they act, but that can also create a problem. After people are focused on the end result, they may not easily see the steps needed to get them there. So show them. Go back to the beginning, show them the first step, and encourage them to take it immediately.

I've heard from musicians that the hardest part of practicing is taking the instrument out of the case. That's certainly not because the action itself is difficult. It's because it means stopping whatever else you're doing, getting yourself up, and getting started. I imagine once the musician is holding the instrument and starting to play, that's when it becomes enjoyable.

As a communicator, you need to convince people to open the case. If you can get them started, they will be engaged and begin working out the next steps as they complete the first one. What motivational speaker Joe Sabah said is true: "You don't have to be great to start. But you do have to start to be great."¹⁶⁸

Show the Value of Small Steps

People often think they need to take a big step to make a significant change. They devalue small steps and often tell themselves those don't count or aren't worth the effort. "I might as well just give up," they tell themselves. But that's simply not true. Nothing happens until something happens. Naeem Callaway, founder and CEO of Get Out The Box, said, "Sometimes the smallest step in the right direction ends up being the biggest step of your life. Tip toe if you must but take a step."¹⁶⁹

When I was a pastor, I was always aware that what I taught on Sunday needed to be easy to apply on Monday. People sometimes feel overwhelmed because they think there's too much to be done, and they can't sort it out. Former senator Karl E. Mundt of South Dakota said, "We can't do everything at once, but we can do something at once."¹⁷⁰ In other words, we can make the complex simple by taking a single step. That's why I always tried to give people one clear, simple, small step that they could use to act on what they learned. That was to get them started crossing the bridge to action.

Remind Them That What They Do Is More Important Than How They Feel

It's reasonable for anyone to feel fear when they are taking new steps. But they cannot improve if they let that fear keep them from acting. Help people understand they shouldn't wait until they *feel good* before they act; instead, they should act first, and that will help them to feel good. Successful people keep moving forward even as they make mistakes, experience losses, and feel discouraged. They don't quit! Nobody gets much done unless he is willing to take a step before he thinks he's ready.

Help Them Discover That Action Builds Confidence

When I was in junior high school, I read my first book by Dale Carnegie, who became my first author-mentor. I learned so many great principles from *How to Win Friends and Influence People*. One of them was that inaction breeds doubt and fear, while action breeds confidence and courage. If you can get people to take any first step of action, any small step, they will begin to experience the power of confidence building in their lives.

Author and speaker Jim Rohn put it this way:

Any day we choose we can develop a new discipline of doing rather than neglecting. Every time we choose action over ease or labor over rest, we develop an increasing level of self-worth, self-respect and self-confidence. In the final analysis, it is how we feel about ourselves that provides the greatest reward from any activity. It is not what we get that makes us valuable, it is what we become in the process of doing that brings value to our lives. It is activity that

converts human dreams into human reality, and that conversion from idea into actuality gives us a personal value that can come from no other source.[171](#)

The more action people take, the more confident they can become. Every time they act and it gives them positive results, they taste success and know they can succeed again in the future. If they act and fail, they realize that failure isn't fatal or final, and they gain the confidence to try again. Either way, taking action is a win.

As you work on communicating with others and inspiring them to act, I want to leave you with one final thought. Your motives matter. You must always lead people to action for their benefit. If you move people for only your benefit, that's manipulation. If you move them for their benefit or mutual benefit, then you're adding value to them and doing them a great service, which is what communication is all about. Never forget that the greatest success in communication is action. That is the Law of Results.

CONCLUSION

THERE YOU HAVE THEM: THE 16 Undeniable Laws of Communication. If you apply them, then you will make the most of your message, no matter the purpose of your communication, the size or scope of your audience, or the environment in which you speak.

I often speak for my friend Chris Hodges. Backstage on the wall in his auditorium, where every speaker can see it before walking out onto the platform, is a sign. It says, “It’s a privilege to be on this stage. Thank you, God, for choosing me.” I am grateful every time I get to speak. I hope you feel that way too! I hope you learn to love communicating as I do. Often while I’m addressing a group, I feel most alive and think, *I was born to do this*. Maybe you were too. No matter what your level of communication, know this: your life and words can be a catalyst for positive change in the lives of others.

Writing this book has filled me with joy. I hope it has brought you joy too—plus plenty of insights, much knowledge, and many practical techniques. My hope is that this book helps you go to a higher level as a communicator. If you’ll use the Laws of Communication every time you speak, they will help you to connect with your audience, increase your influence, and make a difference.

MEET THE AUTHOR



JOHN C. MAXWELL IS A #1 *New York Times* bestselling author, speaker, coach, and leader who has sold more than thirty-five million books in fifty languages. He is the founder of Maxwell Leadership®—the leadership development organization created to expand the reach of his principles of helping people lead powerful, positive change. Maxwell's books and programs have been translated into seventy languages and have been used to train tens of millions of leaders in every nation. His work also includes that of the Maxwell Leadership Foundation and EQUIP, nonprofit organizations that have impacted millions of adults and youth across the globe through values-based, people-centric leadership training.

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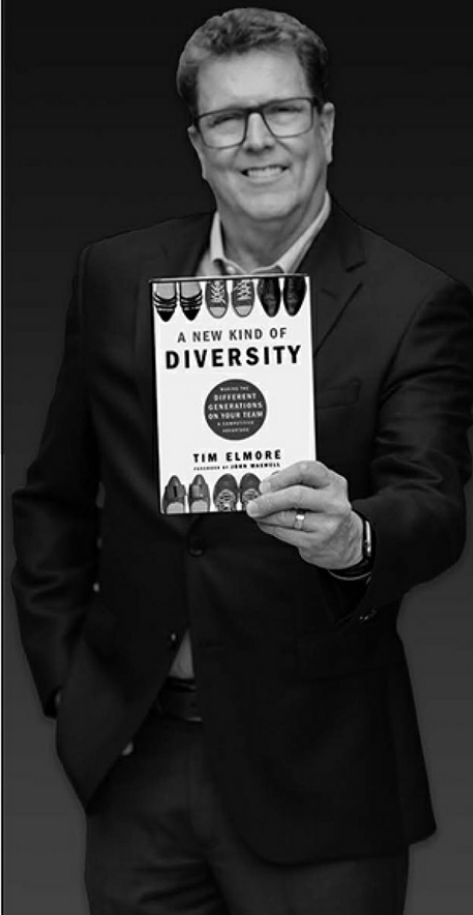
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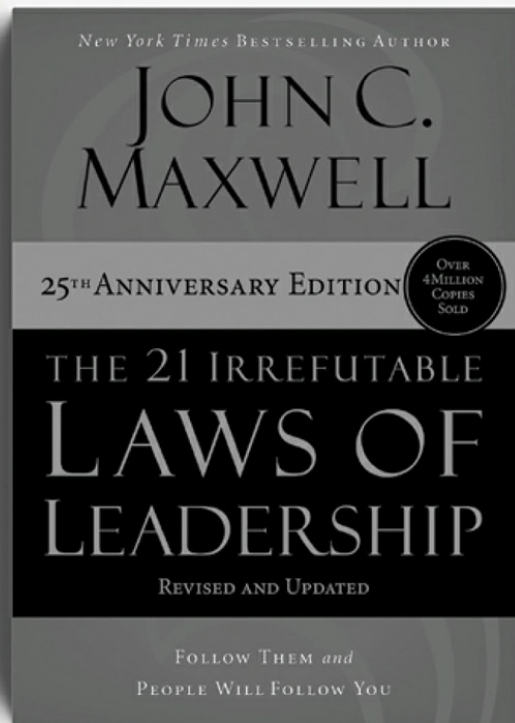
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